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roots and shadows

SHASHI DESHPANDE



DEPARTMENT OF ARTS & HUMANITIES

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ROOTS AND SHADOWS — A Novel

Shashi Deshpande had her early education in Dharwar, then went on to graduate in Economics from Elphinstone College, Bombay, and in law from Bangalore, topping the list of candidates at the University for her final law examination. After the usual marriage-and-children break, she did her journalism at the Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan, winning three medals, including the Times of India Gold Medal. She began writing only at about this time and has since then published nearly sixty short stories. A collection, *The Legacy*, is being used as a text in Columbia University for the course on modern Indian Literature. *Roots and Shadows* is her first novel. The second one, *The Dark Holds no Terrors*, has been published, while two others are awaiting publication. Shashi Deshpande has also written three full length adventure books for children, with a fourth to come out shortly. Daughter of Kannada dramatist Adya Rangacharya, Shashi Deshpande is married to a pathologist and has two sons.

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—a novel

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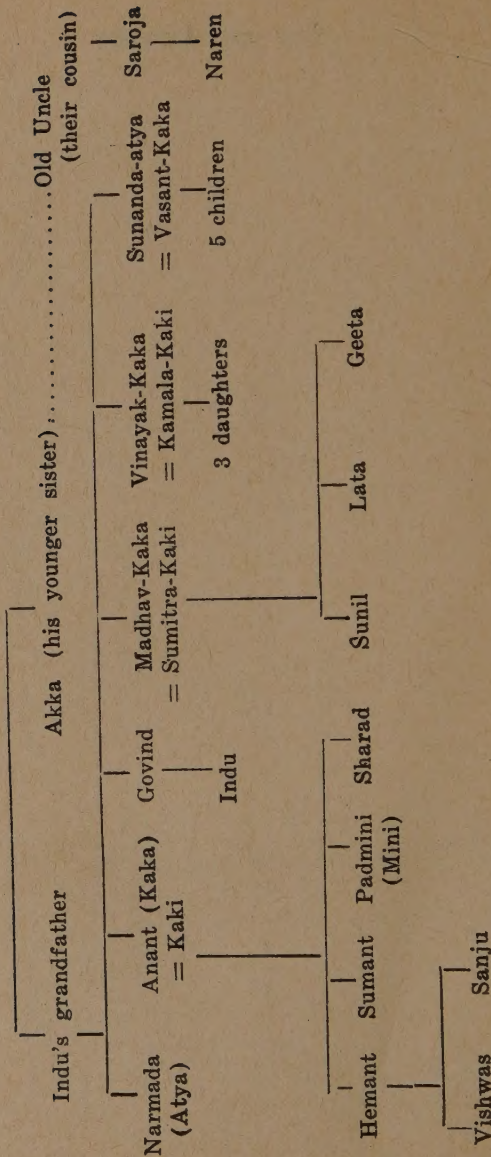
The line 'All things are connected,' on p. 15 was part of the American Indian Chief Seattle's speech in 1854. The lines beginning 'If it pleases you' on p. 83 are my own very free translation of lines from a Kannada Vachana (poem) by Basaveshwara, the reformist saint poet of the 12th century A.D.

I wish to acknowledge my gratitude to my young friend Tejaswini Niranjana, for giving me the title to this novel after I had agonised over it for months.

SHASHI DESHPANDE

For my Parents

THE FAMILY



Prologue

It was the day before the wedding. When I awoke it was still dark, but there was, even at that hour, a subdued bustle inside the house. Most of the lights were on, and sleeping children the only occupants of the pallets spread on the floor. The pallet beside mine had been neatly rolled up. Mini would, of course, leave no duty undone, not even on her wedding day. I rolled up my pallet and went into the backyard to brush my teeth. Early as it was, there was a turmoil of activity here, with dim figures moving in the dusky, pearl-grey light of the morning. I could hear voices slurred with sleep coming from the courtyard behind the kitchen, and I knew the women hadn't slept the whole night. They had been chopping, rolling, pounding, getting ready the festive lunch that would follow the puja that day.

Outside, here in the courtyard, they had lit huge wood fires on which gigantic pots of water were heating for the baths. The logs hissed intermittently, sending up a sudden shower of sparks with a crackling sound. Someone was ladling hot water into a bucket. As the flames danced and leapt, I saw it was Mini. Her face had a tranquil and serene look in the firelight. On an impulse I moved to her, but before I could speak, a woman's voice called out, 'Mini! What are you doing?'

'Taking water for Kaka's bath.'

'Never mind your father today. You're a bride. You shouldn't do any work. Put that bucket down.'

Obediently Mini let go the bucket.

'Oh, come on, Mini,' I called out. 'Do what you want. Take a day off from the rules.'

She turned a startled face to me. Above her head, the long leaves of the mango tree were interlaced with cobwebs that glittered and sparkled in the incandescence of the blazing fire. The pattern of the cobweb was still incomplete. Somewhere inside it, there was a spider, painstakingly completing its work.

'Mini!' Kaka's voice called out. 'Where's my bath water?' Mini started, and picking up the bucket went in. The woman who had been speaking to Mini . . . who was she? . . . muttered and grumbled, and I laughed. The water in the pot seethed and bubbled and the steam rose up from it in a cloud.

I went back into the house, wiping my face with my sari. The house was full, Kaka having invited everyone who qualified in any way as a relation. There was a happy sense of participation that mystified me when I remembered the earlier animosities, the misgivings and conflicts. The smell of flowers, food and incense sticks was everywhere. Drove of women worked continuously in the kitchen, against a deadline it seemed they couldn't possibly meet, turning out mammoth quantities of food and endless cups of tea and coffee. Kaka seemed to be enjoying, as he had always done, his role of a genial host. His loud laughter and roaring voice filled every corner of the house. But the mask came off when he was by himself. I saw him once, all alone in the hall, he looked bewildered and lost. I could almost see his thoughts. This house . . . so bustling and vital now . . . was it possible that the end could be so near?

Luckily there was not much time to think. As ritual followed ritual, there were ripples of excitement with

an undercurrent of tension. In the afternoon, all the women in the family were equipped with green glass bangles. Mini's delicate wrists, loaded with bangles, looked like the symbol of the change in her. They had lost their girlishness and seemed heavy with womanhood.

Mini herself was aloof, as if caught up in some private dream of her own. She seemed to be conforming to the romantic image of the blushing bride dreaming of her bridegroom. But I had seen the bridegroom, and thinking of his heavy, coarse features and crude mannerisms, I rejected the idea. Romantic? No, Mini was pre-eminently a realist. And hadn't the picture, not for Mini alone, but for most brides in this country, always been false? Behind the facade of romanticism, sentiment and tradition, what was marriage after all, but two people brought together after cold-blooded bargaining to meet, mate and reproduce so that the generations might continue?

I was curious, however, to know what Mini's silence contained. She was unresponsive when I tried to make her talk. Until suddenly, with a kind of spurious girlish enthusiasm, she exclaimed, 'What a strange girl are you, Indu! You haven't even asked to see my wedding saris. Come, I'll show them to you.'

With an imperiousness that was a foretaste of the future Mini... how often had I seen marriage turn shy, demure girls into assertive matrons overnight? ... she pulled me along to Kaki's room. 'Wait here. I'll get the keys.'

She was back almost at once with Kaki. Kaki's very keys, it seemed to me, sang a triumphant tune. And why not? She was getting her daughter married. It was an achievement.

I was surprised to see the change in Mini as Kaki lifted the saris out of the trunk. Her face came alive, her eyes glowed and her fingers were tender and caressing as she touched the soft folds of the rich and glittering silks.

'Isn't this beautiful?' She held up a green and gold sari to her face. 'I chose it myself.'

Her eyes were closed, as if in ecstasy, and looking at her beatific face, I knew she was fulfilling her destiny. To her, it was marriage that mattered, not the man.

'And this is for you.' Kaki pulled out a sky-blue and gold sari with a rustling sound and opened it out before me, like a shopkeeper exhibiting a sari in a shop.

'For me?' I couldn't keep the astonishment out of my voice.

'Of course. Don't tell anyone, but ...' her voice fell to a whisper, 'I brought the most expensive sari for you. "He" ... your Kaka ... told me to. You have always been his favourite, you know. I don't know how many times he must have told me, "Buy a good sari for Indu."

Do you like it?' She held it out to me, her fingers with their work-roughened tips rasping against the smooth silk, and turned me towards the mirror. My image, as I looked at it, was misty and blurred. Suddenly Kaki gave a gleeful chuckle as she folded the sari. 'Sumitra will be furious. The sari I bought for her isn't half as good. Nor so expensive.' Mini caught my eye and the two of us giggled like school-girls. Families! And yet, since coming for the wedding, I had seen the concept of the family taking shape, living, in front of my eyes. It had struck me how suddenly, if only momentarily, we had become an entity, a family, united by a strong bond, a common loyalty. It was 'we' now, not 'they' and 'us'.

Three busloads of the bridegroom's party were to arrive in the evening, in time for the pre-wedding rituals. As evening approached, the tempo quickened and the women rushed round like demented souls. Kaka, his face set and anxious, clutched his cap to himself, as if it was a magic talisman. And then, all of them left for the wedding hall in a rush, leaving behind a startling calm. It was like being in the eye of a storm. Before and behind us was turmoil. But, here and now it was quiet.

I had elected to stay behind with Mini, who would go to the hall only later, when it was time for her to take part in the ceremonies. I wore the sky-blue silk Kaki had given me. Jayant, when he saw me, stared at me for a moment as if bemused. Then he smiled and said, 'Indu! You look like a kid wearing her mother's sari.'

'Kid!' I retorted indignantly. 'Just because I'm short ... But do you like it? It's a gift from Kaki. Kaka, rather.'

'You don't say!' He made a mock-impressed face, but his eyes smiled in understanding. 'But, poor Indu,' he clicked his tongue. 'To wear silk! You can't wipe your hands or your face on it.'

'And how you dislike my doing that, don't you? Poor Jayant ...' I used his very tone, 'such a sloppy wife for such a fastidious man.'

'Here,' ignoring my remark, he pulled a handkerchief out of his pocket ... clean, ironed and folded into a perfect square, of course. 'Keep this tucked into your waist.'

'To wipe my eyes at the appropriate moments, you mean?'

'You! And tears! You know, Indu, when I first saw you, I thought you a frail, little creature. Now I know you better. You're indomitable.'

The word fell into me with a heavy thud.

'Indomitable? But Jayant, that's what we called Akka!'

'Perhaps you are like her,' he began lightly, but seeing my face, he went on more seriously, 'Aren't you? Isn't that why she chose you . . . only a great-niece, really . . . from among all the family.'

I was aghast at the idea.

'Like her? But then . . . will I have my victims, too? Maybe I have one already. Look at this wedding! It wouldn't have been possible without me.'

'Mini's?' He said the name with an ease as if he had known both the name and the person for years. As if it wasn't just a week since he had come to know her and the rest of the family.

'Don't feel sorry for her, Indu. She looks a victim, but you know what I feel? It seems to me that the weak have their weapons as well as the strong. And these women . . . I don't know if you can really call them weak. They have an inner strength we know very little of.'

Inner strength . . . I thought of the words as I looked down on Mini's bowed head. A woman's life, they had told me, contained no choices. And all my life, specially in this house, I had seen the truth of this. The women had no choice but to submit, to accept. And I had often wondered . . . have they been born without wills, or have their wills atrophied through a lifetime of disuse? And yet Mini, who had had no choice either, had accepted the reality, the finality, with a grace and composure that spoke eloquently of that inner strength.

The house was silent, as if tired of its pretence of liveliness. A few women who had been left behind, and who had been carrying on an interminable argument in the

kitchen, their voices rising and falling monotonously, were now hustled out by an authoritative male voice. Downstairs, the old grandfather clock would be ticking away, as if it were the feeble heartbeat of the old house; but up here we could not hear it. The air in this room was heavy with mingled fragrances that yet managed to remain distinct. I could identify all of them. The smell of tuberose was heady and strong. It came, I knew, from the basket in the corner, which contained the two garlands Mini and her bridegroom would exchange tomorrow morning. Ropes of the fragrant white mogra, moistened and dewy, lay piled high on a silver tray, ready to be distributed to the women after the evening ceremony.

Inter-mingled with these two perfumes, there was another, more subtle and cunning—the fragrance of the champak. To me, nothing can invoke memories as strongly as smells. And this one brought back that hot afternoon in Naren's room. The smell of the champak wafting in with the breeze. And I, declaring to Naren, an intently listening Naren . . . 'For me, it is one man and one man only.'

I shook off the memories, but the fragrance persisted. Then I saw the flower itself, tiny golden-yellow, shining in Mini's sleek, dark hair. 'Mini,' I began impulsively, but now Mini decided to relinquish her silence, her self-absorption, and said to me, looking at me with a smile, 'Your wedding, Indu? It was not like this?'

'No.'

'You didn't miss all this?' Her gesture seemed to take in all the confusion in the room . . . the clothes, the silverware, the used cups and plates, the trunks and piled-up mattresses.

'Not really.'

And yet, for an infinitesimal moment, I had felt the grey frustrated ghosts of the family scurrying aimlessly round Jayant and me. Or had I? Perhaps it was something I was imagining now?

Sharad rushed in with a clatter of his heeled shoes, dispersing my thoughts. 'Indu,' he spoke in a rush, very much the overworked brother-of-the-bride. 'I'd taped some shehnai music earlier. I just can't find it now. The tapes seem to be jumbled up. Here, hunt it out for me, will you? I've got to drop some of these women at the hall. I'll be back soon.'

While Sharad briskly exchanged some raillery with Mini, I looked at the instrument he had dumped before me with a sense of shock. It was Naren's. How had it come here? Of course... I had returned it to Old Uncle. And Old Uncle had, perhaps, given it to Sharad before his death.

Sharad bustled out and idly, unthinkingly, I switched it on. Music filled the room. It was Naren's music. The song we had heard that day... Father, Naren and I. A tender, lilting devotional song. Of Krishna the baby, and his foster mother. And Naren saying... 'It's mine.' And again... 'Music fills me and there is no more. "I". Just the music.'

I sat crouching there like an animal in pain. If I don't get hold of myself, I thought... I'll start whimpering. I tried to get up, but it was as if I was held in a vice of stillness. I could not move.

Then Mini was beside me, her face anxious, saying, 'Indu, what is it?'

Slowly the world swam into focus again. I stared into her face and said, 'That is Naren's. The music. The voice.' And it was as if he was there with us, silent, aloof,

with his restless hands, sardonic mouth and, when he spoke, a vitriolic tongue.

'Naren ?' she asked, no change in her expression. And suddenly I hated her for her placidity. A childish, blind rage filled me, making me see red. But she said, 'Poor Indu.' Then it was grief and the world went dark again.

I had said 'Poor Mini' so often. I had never imagined Mini saying the same to me. But if I thought, it strange, I did not reveal it.

'You knew ?' I asked her.

She nodded. 'I woke up that night, and you were not in your bed. And your face the day Naren died ...'

'But it's not the way you think it is, Mini. Naren ... he could never be anyone's beloved or husband. I knew it. And it didn't really matter to me.'

'And Jayant ?'

'He is ...' I pondered. 'Yes, all that. You will know how it is once you're married. But maybe,' I said with pity, thinking of the man she was to marry, 'maybe, you won't.'

Her face stared at me, still gentle. 'How do you know ? You don't know how it's going to be for me !'

I began to laugh. 'That's true. I don't. Perhaps Jayant is right, after all. Perhaps you are the stronger.' The weak have their weapons as well as the strong. Yes, they do, Jayant. You're right. As always I could see Mini didn't understand what I was saying. I laughed again and patting her hand, said, 'Let it go, Mini. It's not important.'

As we were talking, Naren's song had come to an end. There was a long pause. And then it began ... the piercing sweet notes of the shehnai. Sweet, but always a hurting, throat-choking sweetness.

'There !' I exclaimed, shaking off my weakness. 'We got it.' And, as the music went on, I said, 'Your wedding's begun, Mini.'

'Yes,' she said and we smiled at each other in understanding.

1

I have this dream, a recurring dream. It began after the demolition of the old house. Since then, it comes to me with infrequent regularity, unchanging in every detail. And each time, I wake up with the same sensation of bewilderment. The dream is so real, so concrete, I find it hard to believe it was only that.

I am in a large, an immensely large hall. Somehow, there is a subterranean feeling about it; but whether it is really underground I do not know. I am going around with many others. There is one man leading us. He is simply dressed in white, and has a Christ-like beard. There is something ascetic about him, and with it a sense of power too. Power without gentleness. 'We feed all our people here,' he says. And for the first time I notice the people in the room, sitting on the floor and eating. Their faces are a blur, as if I am flashing past them at great speed.

Then we are out. It is dusty, a totally barren place. The glare and the heat are both fierce. I am alone now and move among people I don't know. There is an air

of happiness about these people that comes across strongly to me. But I cannot stay here. I have to catch a bus. I begin to hurry as I see it coming, sending up clouds of dust with its wheels. I am not the only one. There is a large crowd with me. I get in. The bus starts and suddenly I remember I have left someone behind. I panic. Stop, stop, I yell and scream. But the bus moves relentlessly on and suddenly in the midst of my despair, I know who those faceless people are. They are my people.

I don't need any psychoanalyst to tell me the significance of this dream. The conclusions are inevitable, unavoidable and too easy; and for that very reason, not satisfying. But can they not, in spite of this, be right after all? I had rejected the family, tried to draw a magic circle round Jayant and myself. I had pulled in my boundaries and found myself the poorer for it. Alienation, I know now, is not the answer. On the contrary, too much of it and we can die of a terrible loneliness of the spirit. 'I am alone' . . . they seem to me to be the most poignant words in any language.

Yet, there is no craving in me to go back. Even if the family were intact now, I would not want to be part of it. The end of an era . . . we journalists (and it is hard to remember that I am no longer one) have used that phrase threadbare. But I could use no other when I left the house after Mini's wedding, knowing it was the last time it would shelter all of us. We left it to Shankarappa and his demolition squad. I did not stay to see the end. But Kaka did. He stood there, they told me, alone among the debris, a dust-covered motionless statue, until there was nothing left but heaps of rubble, piles of wood and dust. Poor Kaka . . . he seems to have shrunk since then. His laughter, his jokes, are like

echoes from the past. Kaki and he are staying with Hemant in a small rented house. Kaki should be happy . . . hadn't she wanted to get out of the old house? . . . but I know she is not. Unlike Kaka, however, she reveals nothing. She is in full control of reality. She is, I now realise, one of the strong ones.

Old Uncle was lucky. He died before the house came down. His going left an unbelievable gap in our midst. He was only a poor school teacher, who retired early due to bad health and came to live with the family as a poor dependent. Yet, when he died, it was as if one of the pillars of our house had gone. When I spoke of this to Jayant, he said something very revealing. 'Ah yes, that happens. But then, new pillars take the place of the old. You're a pillar now yourself, don't you know?'

Am I? Yes, that's true. The family . . . they do come to me often. Strange that they should do so when they have every reason to hate me. But my action in disposing of Akka's money roused no rancour in anyone, except Madhavkaka's Sunil, who never speaks to me, and Sunanda-tya, who will never forgive me. The others are reconciled. Maybe, I tell myself cynically, they don't mind getting nothing so long as the others get nothing too! But Madhav-kaka, who was loudly approving, has one reservation.

'I wish, Indu,' he says, 'you had kept the money exclusively for our own people. If we don't help our own people, who will?'

I could counter this with my own questions. Our own people? Who are they? Where do I draw the boundary? But I don't, because the answers, I know, are not there, not with Madhav-kaka. Shyamrao has his mis-givings too. 'Akka wouldn't have liked the idea of her

money helping just anyone,' he said to me, wryly. 'You know how fanatically loyal she was to her own community.'

He should know. If he was not part of the family, he was Akka's lawyer and the one person with whom she discussed her business matters. Nevertheless, I shrugged off his words too. It is not the dead who need our loyalty, but the living. It's because of this that I broke my promise to Naren. 'Promise me you won't help Vithal,' he had said. 'Promise me. Promise.' Yes, I had promised, but Vithal is one of the first to benefit from Akka's trust.

When I had sworn that none of Akka's money would go to the family, when I had decided that I would give it to strangers instead, I had done so in a fit of pique, perhaps of hatred against the family. But now I wonder whether what I did was perhaps for the best, even for the family. There's Sharad, Kaka's spoilt Sharad, who was all set for a career of parasitism, now thriving in his new job. He is enjoying himself hugely, neither nostalgia nor sentiment spoiling his enjoyment. Atya, however, is not pleased. She is shocked at the thought of her nephew, no, her father's grandson, rather, going into the hotel business. And that hotel built on the site of our old house. To her, there are still very few respectable careers. The law, teaching, working in a government office, and what to her are the newfangled ones . . . medicine and engineering. I cannot convince her that Sharad would have suited none of these. That he is, in fact, all cut out for the one he has adopted (and the fact that he could wheedle Shankarappa, a hard headed businessman, into taking him on itself shows this) with his glib talk and air of assurance and smartness.

But Atya cannot understand me. She lives in her own world and cannot grasp the rules of this strange new one. She came to live with Jayant and me when the old house came down. It was not a choice made with deliberation. She had been listless, apathetic. A childless widow, knowing she had no claim on anyone, the house had been, perhaps, her only security. 'What does it matter where I live?' she had said. And at first, she was very unhappy in my house. Everything, from the traffic on the roads, to the spotless kitchen inside, seemed to frighten her.

But strangely, she gets on well with Jayant. I had wondered how Jayant would accept her with her regulated widow's way of living . . . her rituals, her fasts and her self-deprivations. But now, I can hear them talking as I work. A pleasing background to the staccato tattoo of my typewriter. Jayant, I can see, gets something from her undemanding affection — something he never got from anyone else. But isn't that always true? Does not each relationship have something unique to offer? I think of my own childhood, and of how I got affection from Kaka, understanding from Old Uncle, and loving care from Atya; and I know why there is a faint tinge of pity in me for the small families of today. Father, mother, child

Jayant and I . . . I wish I could say we have achieved complete happiness. But I cannot fantasise. I think of the cries that had filled me earlier . . . I want to be loved, I want to be happy. The cries are now stilled. Not because I am satisfied, or yet hopeless, but because such demands now seem to me to be an exercise in futility. Neither love nor happiness come to us for the asking. But they can sneak up on us when we least expect them. The other day, I came away from my writ-

ing, tired, dishevelled, almost in tears. 'And after all,' I cried out despairingly to Jayant, 'it may be stillborn. If no publisher accepts it . . . ' 'I'll publish it for you,' Jayant said, putting his arms comfortingly round me. And Atya brought me a cup of tea. Happiness . . . I never knew it was made up of such little things.

Yet, when I had first told Jayant about my plans . . . that I would give up my job and give myself to writing, he had been unbelieving. Then, confident of his influence over me, he had been sure I would change. Later, when he realised this would not happen, he had been furious. And bewildered. As if I had cheated him.

'You don't know me, you know nothing about me,' I had once charged him in anger.

And he, revealing a frightening perspicacity, had said, 'I know as much of you as you allow me to know.'

Now I think he knows me better, my strength, which I had hidden from him, as well as my weakness. Perhaps, because of this, we have a better chance. There is an ease in our relationship that was not there before. If my feelings have cooled down to some extent . . . the fever is no longer there . . . I have gained something else in return. I no longer fight my need of him. I am not ashamed of it. I know it does not make me less of a human being. On the contrary, I remember Old Uncle's words . . . 'The whole world is made up of interdependent parts. Why not you?'

And I think also of those words of a noble savage to a civilisation that defeated him . . . 'All things are connected.' Yes, they are. Which is why no one can be completely free. Freedom has to be relative.

I know this now. But twice in my life I had thought I am free. Once, when I left home as a young girl. And the second time, when, once again I left the family

after Naren's death and returned to Jayant. Both times I found out how wrong I was. New bonds replace the old, that is all. And again it is a conversation I had had with Old Uncle as a girl that comes to my mind.

Since childhood I had been drilled into the right method of serving food. Salt here, chutney and pickles below it, vegetables on the right, dal in the centre, ghee only after serving the dal. The pattern was rigid and there could be no deviation from it. Once, in a contrary mood, I had purposely changed it. The results had been catastrophic. I had fled to Old Uncle, always my refuge then, and cried out, 'Why can't we do it any other way? Why always the same way?'

'Why not, Indu? There have to be some rules so that life can have both dignity and grace. We can always find measures of freedom within these rules.'

I had scarcely listened then, being inured to Old Uncle's garrulity which had, at that age, seemed meaningless. Now the words return, loaded with meaning. To fulfil one's obligations, to discharge one's responsibilities . . . can I not find freedom within this circle?

It was perhaps my understanding of this that made it possible for me not only to pay for Mini's wedding, but to attend it and enjoy it as well. When I remember the righteous crusading spirit with which I attacked Kaka for arranging Mini's marriage, I am amused at myself. It is like looking back on another person, foolish and naive. Now, I do not arrogate to myself any more, the right to judge for others. If ever I am tempted to do so, I recollect Naren's, 'Who are you to judge, Indu?' And Old Uncle's, 'What right did I have to judge him?'

I have, I think, realised that it is not in me, the material of which revolutionaries are made. I no longer have any desire to mould people, to change them, to reform

society. There is only one thing I know I can do . . . I can write. And I am writing now, the book that has been in me these past few years. Whether any publisher will accept it, whether it will win acclaim, appreciation, accolades . . . I school myself not to dream of such things. Rave reviews and world wide fame, a best-seller that will stun the world and generations . . . these exist only in the fantasies of immature minds and publishers' blurbs. But can I withstand other pressures? The desire to be known, to succeed for Jayant's sake . . . will they not impel me to compromise, to write the kind of things that are acceptable, popular and easily sold? If ever I am in danger of doing so, the memory of that time when I succumbed is there to shame me. Ironically, just before it happened, I had, I remember, written an article on Kindness or Courage or something . . . a filler when someone had let us down. And . . . how is it I can remember the words so well? . . . I had said: 'We disdainfully pass by small acts of kindness in the hope of proving ourselves in the larger arena of a greater heroism. But these small acts may be our only chance after all. How many of us can hope to enter the larger arena?'

It was odd that I had had my chance soon after. And I had let it go. I had just written up an interview that I had done, of a woman who had been given an award and an important office in recognition of her social services; specifically, of her services in the cause of the uplift of women. I had finished my piece when someone had directed the little old man in the grimy dhoti and black cap to me. He had brought a piece too. About the same woman. Badly written though it was and full of spelling mistakes, I had read it to the end without

pause. Then incredulously, I had asked him, 'Is this true?'

It could not be, I thought, recalling the woman I had met, soft-spoken, articulate, seemingly sincere and dedicated. This . . . this was a story of shameless exploitation of ignorance, poverty and need. A story of ruthlessness and unscrupulousness in the pursuit of fame, power and money, all of which had now come. And no one, hearing the story of these exploited people, would ever believe it. But if I had doubts about the authenticity of his story . . . and somehow, after the first moment, I never had any . . . he soon undeceived me. And I had gone to my editor with the two copies . . . his story and mine. He had read both and laughed.

'Don't you believe it?' I had angrily asked.

He knew it was not my story I meant. 'Of course I do. There's nothing new in this. I knew all this long back.'

'But . . . but . . . but . . . ' I looked down at my own copy.

'That! Don't tell me, Indu, you really believed all that you wrote! I thought you had got over it long back. Did you truly think that woman was all this?' Contemptuously he flipped the pages of my story.

'And this then?' I held out the other.

'Oh, that's true enough. But we can't print it.'

When I persisted, he laughed. 'I never knew you were such an idealist, Indu.'

I could have fought against anger, abuse, hostility. But I could do nothing against this ridicule. I looked at myself through his eyes and saw myself not as brave, but as foolish and naive.

I went back to the old man and told him I could do nothing for him. I took back my story from the editor. As I did so, he looked up at me over his glasses, saying,

'And no foolishness, mind, Indu. It won't do. God, if we were to publish all the dirt about all the dogs and bitches around . . . !'

Foul-mouthed, cynical, having no illusions about anyone or anything. And I . . . taking care to present to him the image he wanted. He needn't have worried about me. For I rewrote my story, heaping the praise on more than ever. It was a kind of self-flagellation.

There was yet another thing I had to endure. She rang me up after the article appeared. She was charming, praising my writing with a gentle flattery. There was a promise too, of help, any time I needed it. I was reminded, if I hadn't known it already (My god, who'll publish this, Indu! Don't you know how influential she is!) of the persons she knew.

But what really hurts is the memory of what I did then. I went to Jayant and asked him if I should resign. And he, listening to me, sympathising with me, said the same things my editor had.

'That's life! What can one person do against the whole system! No point making yourself ridiculous with futile gestures. We need the money, don't we? Don't forget, we have a long way to go.'

To go where? I had not asked him. I had quietly gone back to work. Hating it, hating myself. Waking up each day and thinking . . . I can't go on. Feeling trapped, seeing myself endlessly chained to the long dusty road that lay ahead of me.

And then Akka's summons had come. It had been a welcome reprieve. A chance to get away. To avoid thinking about what was happening to me . . . to Jayant and me . . . and our life together.

The room, like all the others in this old house, was dimly lit. The semi-darkness deepened the shadows on the old woman's face, making it all sharp lines and angles. Her jutting out forehead put her eyes into a deep shade from which they looked out, frighteningly alive in that dying face. There was a triumphant gleam in them. I could almost see her thoughts . . . I made you come home, didn't I? I brought you back, didn't I?

I had left home full of hatred for the family, for Akka specially. I had sworn I would never go back. Which had not prevented me from dreaming of the time when I would. Childishly crude, technicoloured dreams of revenge, forgiveness and death. With the star role, of course, being mine. But there's a difference between 18 and 29. At 29, knowing both Akka and myself, I knew there would be neither repentance nor forgiveness on either side.

'Why hasn't your husband come? Why didn't you bring him with you?'

There was, in spite of her weakness, still that quality of arrogance in her voice that had always infuriated me. As a child it had surprised me that she, so abysmally ignorant, so what-I-considered-stupid, could assume such an air of superiority.

I could have replied, 'How could he come when none or you even acknowledged his existence all these years?'

But I didn't. I wasn't prepared to battle with a dying woman. And there was no pleasure in impudent retorts any more.

'He couldn't get leave,' I prevaricated.

'I had asked Anant to write to you to bring him with you,' she declared angrily.

I smiled, remembering Kaka's letter. Kaka's letters were a family joke. Written on only three occasions . . . a birth, a marriage, a death, . . . they invariably consisted of only two almost undecipherable lines. But I didn't give him away to Akka.

'I had something important to tell both of you.'

'You will have to put up with me.'

'And I wanted to see him, what kind of a husband you've got.'

At that I had to laugh. 'Oh Akka, still intent on approving him, are you? Three years after our marriage? And what if you don't approve of him? Do I give him up?'

Her eyes showed hurt. 'You think that what you do is no concern of ours, do you Indu? You think your life is none of my business? You haven't grown up, child.'

Her anger, her hostility had left me untouched. But her gentleness disarmed me. After receiving Kaka's letter, I had dithered . . . shall I go? What does Akka want to see me for? She had never had any use for me at any time. Why now? And I had been unable to make up my mind. It had been Jayant who had made it up for me by saying, 'Do you have to go? After all, she is . . . what is she of yours? Your father's aunt, isn't she? Rather a distant relation.'

Akka? A distant relation? It had sounded treacherous, disloyal. At that moment I had decided . . . I will go. And now here I was, wishing I hadn't come as Akka told me the reason she had wanted me. A slow anger burned in me as I listened. What was Akka doing? Making sure I would never get away?

'Akka . . .' I began angrily.

She looked at me, her heavy lids drooping, giving her a weary, dying look. 'Don't argue with me, child. I'm tired. We'll talk of it tomorrow if you want.'

That night she sank into a coma from which she never recovered. And now she was dead. Cheating me, after all. As I stared at her, I had an odd sensation of hearing her malicious chortle. But in death her face had an unusually benign look. Even her feet, those small puffy feet on which she had tottered, seemed pathetic, the toes turned mutely upwards. She now looked so tiny, so ineffectual, I wondered how she had maintained her power, her authority over everyone. The idea of being scared of her seemed ridiculous. But then, I had never been scared of her. There had been only resentment and dislike. And now there was nothing. Just this blank feeling, as if I had shut away all emotions and this was an interlude of nothing.

There was no sound in the room, except for the murmurs of the priest. There were no sobs, not even sniffles. Just a heavy taut silence. Fearfully I noticed the one large hair sprouting from her chin. If you live long enough, I thought, you can lose everything, even your sex. And suddenly I didn't want to be there any more. I turned away and went out, pushing through the heavy, unyielding bodies of the women who were raptly, fearfully, watching what was being done.

I went into the dark room and stood there with my back against the wall, feeling ridiculously like a punished child.

'Indu ?' I heard someone call me softly. Even in broad daylight, this room was dark. The dark room. Where so many women had given birth. It seemed to me as if the smell of childbirth clung to it still. A strange, musty

odour rose from the walls. I groped my way towards the voice.

'Indu?' It was Atya and as I reached her, she put her arms round me, holding me so hard that it hurt. Her face was wet. I inhaled the familiar smell of her presence and for a moment I was a child again, secure and loved.

Outside I could hear the shuffling sounds of bare feet on the floor. They were leaving. Someone began to moan as a hoarse voice uttered the name with which Akka would be speeded on her way to heaven. Ram, Ram, Shri Ram. Atya clung to me conclusively. The smell of incense was wafted in to us. And then they receded . . . the footsteps, the murmurs, the smell. We were left in silence. Atya let go of me. She blew her nose and said, 'She's gone.'

Her voice came out, not muffled, but clear and strong.

'Yes,' I said. 'She's gone.'

It's the end. But if one thing ends, something else has to begin. Where do we go on from here? Where do I go on from here, burdened by what Akka has done to me?

I wandered restlessly from room to room. The room in which she had lain was being cleaned by the servants. One of the women suddenly gave a loud, harsh sob which echoed back from the high tiled roof of that empty room. I looked at her in surprise. Why was she crying? Akka's illness had meant nothing but trouble and inconvenience for everyone in the house.

'Why didn't you get her admitted into a hospital?' I had asked Kaka. Kaka had looked at me apologetically. 'She wouldn't let me. She didn't want to go to a hospital. She was worried about the kind of people she would

come in contact with. "God knows what caste the nurses are," she said. "Or the doctors. I couldn't drink a drop of water there".'

'Tchah!' I exclaimed in disgust. 'Just like her. Narrowminded. Bigoted. And thinking only of herself. Never of others.'

'Indu, you shouldn't . . . ' Kaka's face was a study in fear and anger. Fear . . . the aetiology of fear . . . how do you make so many people afraid of you for so long? Since the day Akka had come back, a rich childless widow, to her brother's house, she had maintained an absolute control over her brother's children. Kaka, even after becoming a grandfather, could be reduced to a red-faced stuttering schoolboy by Akka's venomous tongue. It was only Father who had escaped. And I. But had I? Had she had the last laugh on me after all?

Women sat in groups everywhere, their saris held to their eyes, beatifying the dead woman. What can I say about you, Akka, if I join them? I smiled to myself. You were ruthless, dominating, bigoted and inconsiderate. Can I join the paeans of praise with these words?

With a sudden distaste, I knew this was no place for me. I had to get away. And there was only one place I could go to. Old Uncle had always been my refuge. What is Old Uncle to me, Jayant? Another distant relation? I thought of all the things Old Uncle had been to me . . . things I had been unable to define as a child and could realise only now . . . a friend, a confidant, an ally. Nevertheless, it was not Old Uncle I wanted now, only his room.

To my disappointment there was someone in the room. Someone who was sleeping in the large easy chair, a newspaper thrown over his face. Quietly I turned away. Suddenly the person sat up, the news-

paper falling from his face. My heart fell with a shock into the pit of my stomach as I stared into a face with a wild unruly beard, eyes that leapt out at me from a craggy face. The whole strange and yet strangely familiar. He put a finger to his lips, as if we were fellow conspirators, I thought wildly, and going to the door bolted it from the inside. I was still staring at him when he came back.

‘What the hell have you been doing?’ he asked.

My voice came out an undignified startled squeak. ‘Who . . . ?’

‘Mean to say you haven’t recognised me?’ He tugged at the beard as he spoke. ‘I wish I could peel off this thing and unmask myself. The villain of the piece.’

He smiled and at once the face was the face of an old friend.

‘Naren!’ I exclaimed in relief.

‘There! I knew you’d come to it at last. I always guessed you were a smart girl. And now,’ he pushed me into the chair from which he’d risen, ‘tell me what the hell you’ve been doing?’

‘But . . . but . . .’ I had to say something. ‘Why aren’t you at the funeral?’

He towered over me as I sat reluctantly in the huge chair, feeling ridiculously small. As if the same thought had occurred to him, he stopped scrubbing at his face with a large, dirty hanky and said, his mouth quivering, ‘Haven’t grown at all, eh? Not a bit in . . . how many years since we met, Indu?’

‘Twelve years,’ I said curtly. I tried not to smile, but my lips felt less taut. I could feel my whole face giving way to it. ‘And let me remind you that now I’m no longer short. Or dark. I’m petite. And dusky.’

He laughed loudly. 'Not to me. To me, you're still bad-tempered little Indu. Petite and dusky, eh? That means you're rich. That reminds me . . .'

'Why aren't you at the funeral?' I retorted. With Naren, you always had to be attacking. You couldn't afford anything else.

He clicked his tongue reprovingly at me. 'Shame on you, Indu, for taking so little interest in the affairs of your family. I had imagined that it was common knowledge that the old woman hated my guts. As I hated hers. If I had gone to the funeral, I wouldn't have been surprised if she had got up and yelled at me, "I don't want you here, you ippy!" That's what she called me . . . an ippy.'

'And what's that?'

'You don't know? How poorly informed you are! Well, to be frank, so was I at first. "What's a ippy?" I asked her. "Ippies are people who grow long hair and wear dirty clothes," she told me.'

'She's right,' I sniffed. 'Look at your clothes.'

Suddenly Naren sank to the ground and pulling a cigarette out of a packet from his pocket, pointed it accusingly at me. 'Well, forget about my clothes. They're not important. Tell me what the hell you've been doing?'

'What do you mean?' I asked him in asperity. 'That's the third time you've said that to me. What am I supposed to have been doing?'

'The kind of writing you've been doing. I've had my eye on you, young woman. I've read most of the things you've written. And now . . . interviewing society dames and showering them with adjectives. What do you do that for?'

'Money, what else? It's my job.'

It was painful and I didn't want to talk about it. I didn't want to respond to his probing. But suddenly it was exciting. How long was it since someone had really talked to me? Talked about things as if he understood and cared? Reaching across the barriers I had built round myself?

'Money!' he snorted. 'Doesn't your husband earn enough?'

'Depends on what you mean by enough.'

'Tell me what you mean.'

What did I mean by enough? As I began to tell him, it was not a joke any more. I was dead serious. And he sat there, cross-legged on the floor, the unlighted cigarette in his mouth, as solemn as a child listening to a fairy tale. And I felt too as if I was watching, talking about, a phantasmagoria. As if I was, in a detached manner, speaking of someone else's life. The sense of futility, of utter vacuity that had often overcome me, now came back. But now, it was not I who was the ridiculous, befuddled fool, struggling for something that was not really important. It was someone else. The real I was here, talking to Naren, telling him about it, sharing with him the sense of absurdity my words aroused. 'We belong to the smart young set. Do you know what that means? Fresh flowers in the house every day. Can you believe it, Naren, I've gone and done a course in flower arrangement? The best places, whether you go out to eat or to cut your hair. Freshly laundered clothes twice a day. Clothes . . . yes, we have to keep up with the latest trends'

'Hmmm' . . . How could one sound imply so many things? 'You sound like those families in the advertisement slides. Happy, smiling, healthy and in colour.'

'Wait,' I said irritably. 'I haven't finished. We don't have friends, but the right contacts and "people one should know". Who entertain us just as often as we entertain them. And when we get together . . . oh, you should listen to us, Naren. We talk with nostalgia of places abroad. We're gay and whimsical about our own people, our own country. We are rational, unprejudiced, broadminded. We discuss intelligently, even solemnly, the problems of unemployment, poverty, corruption, family planning. We scorn the corrupt, we despise the ignorant, we hate the wicked . . . And our hearts bleed, Naren, for Viet Nam, for the blacks, for the Harijans . . . ' Suddenly my enforced calm, my deceptive joviality fell off me and I banged my fist on my own lap. Hard. 'But frankly, we don't care a damn. Not one goddam about anything but our own precious selves, our own precious walled-in lives. And I'm . . . '

There was a long pause. Naren had all this while neither stirred, nor changed his expression. 'So that's why you do that kind of writing.' He was matter-of-fact, not critical. And somehow it hurt more. 'How you've degenerated, child.'

'Child ?' I laughed suddenly, happily. 'If I remember rightly, you're just three or four years older than me.'

'In years, dear Indu. In years. In experience and living, far older.'

I tucked my feet under me in the chair and giggled childishly. 'Why, what have you been doing ?'

'Lots of things. Not gathering any moss, certainly.'

'Rolling stone, eh ?'

'Happily rolling.' He pulled a pillow off the bed, and putting it under his head, lay down, legs crossed, peacefully blowing rings of smoke at the ceiling.

'And why does a first class M.A. with Economics have to roll?'

'I don't have any trouble getting jobs. But I don't have any trouble losing them either. Nobody seems inclined to keep me for long.'

His face was tranquil and unperturbed as he spoke. I could see that he was hedging, as I had wanted to. Levity, banter, but no revelations. That suited me now after my one outburst. 'What about that base necessity ... money?'

'I get as much of it as I want. Whenever I'm in a job. I hoard, like a squirrel hoarding its nuts. What nuts, by the way, Indu? Have you ever seen a squirrel hoarding nuts? I must say the only squirrels I've seen seem to be employed in running around aimlessly. Well, let's say I hoard like a mythical squirrel. So, when I'm out of a job, I live on my savings. That's my present role.'

I began to laugh. He looked at me in surprise.

'What's so funny about not having money? I know you've become one of the affluent ...'

'No,' I corrected him. 'Not the affluent. In fact, it's considered vulgar to be affluent. We're the upper middle class.'

'Okay, the upper middle class. I hadn't imagined What was I about to say? Oh, forget it. Anyway, it's good to see you, Indu.'

My heart turned over at the sincerity of his words. To belong, to be wanted, needed, loved, desired, admired ... how many traps there are! And I fall into all of them.

'But, by god, Indu, you've changed.'

'How?'

'You look different. Not so sharp-edged. You're softer,

as if your outlines have somehow got blurred. If you know what I mean.'

'No, I don't!' I exclaimed in anger. 'I mean, I don't know whether you're talking figuratively, or literally. Either way it sounds stupid.'

'Stupid, stupid ... that was your favourite word of abuse, eh, Indu? The other was idiot. You used to say those words to almost everyone.'

Memories rushed in on me. 'No, not to you, Naren. I don't think I ever dared call you an idiot.'

He ignored that. 'So you came to see the old witch, did you?'

'Hmm. Rather, she wanted to see me.'

'I wonder why.'

I shrugged. This was not the time to tell him. 'And as to why I laughed then, it wasn't because of the money. I was thinking of Old Uncle coping with you.'

'He? He's given up coping a long time back. You should see me coping with him.'

Abruptly he got up, punched the pillow and threw it back on the bed and began moving around. His face was serious for the first time.

'Why, Naren, what's wrong with him?'

'He's become old. And frail. And cantankerous. And I'm no comfort to him. A waster of a grandson ... he's ashamed of me. No, I'm wrong. It hurts him to see me like this. But I can't change, can I, Indu? A person has to go his own way ...' He stopped abruptly. There were footsteps at the door.

Somebody pushed at the door. Naren opened it. It was Old Uncle. He looked utterly exhausted. 'Naren ... and Indu, is it?' He peered at me briefly as he removed his slippers. 'I must go and wash my feet.'

'I'm off, grandfather.'

I looked at Naren in surprise. 'You don't stay here then ?'

'No.' He offered no explanation. He picked up his cigarettes, two books and a magazine and tucked them under his arm. But instead of going, he sat down in the chair and looked at his grandfather curiously.

'You look tired. Go to bed.'

'A bath first.' Old Uncle mumbled.

'Of course, a bath first. See Indu, how things are ? Unchanged. You can be dying, but you've got to have a bath first.'

'Oh leave him alone, Naren. Can't you see this isn't the time for such arguments ?'

Old Uncle looked at me as if for the first time.

'Can I sit here until you come back from your bath, Old Uncle ?' He gave me a strange look as if weighing me up. It frightened me. When I was a child, Old Uncle had always been on my side. At least, I had always felt so. What did this look mean ? But all that he said was, giving me a sudden smile, 'I'm glad you came, Indu.'

'Everyone says that,' I spoke irritably. 'Why should they imagine I wouldn't ?'

'You ignored us for 10 years.'

And I knew now what it was. 'I'll write to you, Old Uncle,' I had promised. It was he who had come to the station to see me off when I had left. I had written a few times, then stopped. What could I say to an old man who had seemed so far removed from the life I was living ? And more . . . how could I reveal to him that the loneliness of hostel life was to me a savage cruelty that tore me to shreds ? Loneliness . . . yes, I had craved for it often. But it had to be a solitude of my own choosing, not this one forced upon me. And even later, when I was lonely no longer, the total femininity of the place had

both so repelled me and appalled me that I would have given anything to get away from there. But none of my feelings had been for display, certainly not to the family I had so arrogantly turned my back on.

'Oh, that's different. There wasn't an occasion.'

'You mean you'll come only if one of us dies?'

Naren, who had been looking from face to face like an interested child, guffawed. And now I was sure I had hurt Old Uncle. It was a wrong I could never undo. But are there any wrongs you *can* undo?

'That's not fair, Old Uncle. Was I ever invited?'

'You don't need an invitation, child. This is your home.'

'Yes, mine. But not Jayant's. And was he ever invited? If he isn't welcome, I can't come, either.'

Naren sat up with a jerk. 'Same old loyal little Indu.'

'Stop calling me little.' I stamped my foot at him.

'Stop fighting, children.' Old Uncle raised his voice with an obvious effort.

All of us laughed, I almost hysterically.

'I'm off, grandfather,' Naren said, really getting up this time. 'Have a quick bath and lie down. You need a rest. See you again, Indu. Going to be here for some time?'

'I don't know. I haven't thought about it.' As Naren went out, I got up and stretched myself. 'I'll get your bath water ready, Old Uncle.'

'Rest, he says,' Old Uncle mumbled. 'I'll be getting a long rest soon enough. I never thought Akka would go before me. She was only a few years older. And as strong as a horse. But then ... poor woman, poor woman!'

'Poor woman?' I flung the words over my shoulder,

but Old Uncle only said, 'Yes, yes, keep my bath water ready. I'm coming. I'm coming.'

A wedding, a funeral . . . there is very little difference between them. By night time there were so many people in the house, it could as well have been a family gathered for a wedding, except for the sepulchral atmosphere. If there was an occasional sound of laughter, it was immediately stifled. Even the children, continually admonished to 'go out and play', were subdued and clung to their mothers with solemn faces. At night the pallets were spread in the big hall from end to end. Children fell asleep in odd corners, while adults sat in groups talking, drifting from subject to subject (always people, always things, never ideas. Are we truly the descendants of those magnificent people who went deep into the Universe and into themselves to understand the mystery of life?), but eventually coming back, as if in duty bound, to the old woman and her virtues.

For some reason I was an outsider. The waves of sorrow, sympathy and comradeship rippled all around me, but left me untouched. I did not mind. I was content to be by myself. It was only Atya who tried to draw me into the circle.

'Where will you sleep, Indu?' she asked me.

'I don't know. Anywhere. What about you?'

'I . . . don't know. I always slept in her room.' Suddenly her tears overflowed. 'Oh Indu, she's gone. As long as she was with us, we never felt we had no parents. I didn't feel so orphaned even when Mother died. And because Akka was there, we were still young. Now I'm both orphaned and old.' I felt awkward to see a grief I couldn't share. I patted her in an embarrassed manner. Someone called her . . . it was Kaki . . . and, wiping her

tears on her sari, Atya walked briskly away. Mini called out to me from the narrow gallery outside the big hall.

'Mother says we can sleep here. Is this all right for you?'

'Oh, anywhere will do.'

'I've got some mattresses for us. But I couldn't find any blankets. I'm giving you one of Mother's old saris. It's washed. Is it all right?'

Her humble voice irritated me. 'Oh, it's all right, Mini. Don't fuss.'

As we lay on the thin mattresses, I thought of Jayant and how far removed I was from him. And not in space, only. At home we changed our sheets twice a week. The beds had to be made perfectly, the sheets tucked in without a wrinkle, the blankets folded into a perfect square, the pillows a straight line. Here, the sheet was none too clean, the blanket smelt of Kaki's body. Sometime, some child had urinated on the thin mattress and the pungent odour clung to it still. And yet I stretched myself on the bed with relief. Even joy. If only Jayant were here. . . .

This is my real sorrow. That I can never be complete in myself. Until I had met Jayant I had not known it . . . that there was, somewhere outside me, a part of me without which I remained incomplete. Then I met Jayant. And lost the ability to be alone.

'Indu,' a small voice said beside me.

'What is it, Mini?' I turned to her thankfully.

She lay, as she always did, straight on her back, her legs stretched out full length, her hands folded on her chest.

'You know, I'm going to get married?'

'No!' I turned round to her, pulling my blanket over me, giving her my full attention. 'Mini! No one told me.'

'It's just been fixed. A few days before Akka fell ill.'

'Who is it?'

And then it struck me that there was no joy in her tone. But that, perhaps, was due to the atmosphere in the house. 'Oh, what does it matter who it is,' she said peevishly. Someone on the other side of Mini laughed. 'She's feeling shy to say the name, that's what it is.'

It was Sunanda-atya. I should have guessed from the fact that there were mattresses, blankets and pillows for all of them, for her and her children. Sunanda-atya looked helpless and feeble, but when it came to looking after herself, her interests, or those of her children, she was a step ahead of the others. 'She isn't modern like you, Indu. I bet you say your husband's name pat.'

'Jayant? Of course. What else do you expect me to call him?'

'Akka will ... I mean, Akka would have had a fit if she had heard you say it like that. Shows disrespect, she would have said. They also say it shortens your husband's life.'

'They, they, they.' I exclaimed impatiently. 'Who are they? That's just to frighten the women. To keep them in their places. And poor fools, we do just that. What connection can there be between a man's longevity and his wife's calling him by name? It's as bad as praying to the tulsi to increase his life span.' I used to watch the women piously circumambulating the tulsi, devoutly standing in front of it with folded hands and closed eyes. 'What's it for?' I had asked Atya.

'You'll understand when you get married,' she had smiled.

'What'll happen then?'

'You'll have a husband. And the tulsi ... if you pray to her ... she'll keep him safe.'

'Didn't you pray, Atya?' I had asked with the thoughtless cruelty of a child.

'I did, child. But it was not written on my forehead that I should be so fortunate.'

'What's written on mine, Atya?'

'Lots of good fortune, my darling.'

Lots of good fortune. To Atya that meant that I should not survive my husband. That I should die before him. To me? Now good fortune means so many more things. But this above all. That Jayant should be with me. Always, all the time, forever. So how am I different from you, Atya? From you and Kaki and Sunanda-atya and all the rest of you women to whom the greatest calamity is life without a husband? What difference does it make if our reasons for thinking this way are different?

'I can't argue with you, Indu,' Sunanda-atya said in her sulking voice. 'You're too clever for me.'

The final rejoinder. It had always been thrown at me like an accusation. As if it was a disgrace to be clever. I had sobbed out my hurt to Old Uncle one day. And he had said, 'For a woman, intelligence is always a burden, Indu. We like our women not to think.'

This had made no sense to me. Nor had his added consolation. 'It's always going to happen to you, Indu. People are afraid, resentful of brains. Take it in your stride. And pity them.'

Pity Sunanda-atya and her waster of a husband and brood of children? Somehow, I couldn't. I felt as resentful as if I was twelve again and totally vulnerable. I turned away from her in silence. That was one thing I had learnt now. One thing my marriage had taught me. The gift of silence. I faced Mini again. 'Well, who is it, Mini?' I whispered. But Mini was fast asleep.

I woke up with my usual feeling of total disorientation. For a few moments I lay absolutely still, letting consciousness seep into me. Slowly the fragments came together . . . the sparrows, with their noisy chirping, sounding like school children let out for the break; someone coughing and gargling loudly as he performed his morning ablutions; the tinkle of teacups and the hiss of the Primus stove; a child crying; water running into a bucket . . . all of these forming a whole. This is our house. I am home.

Ten years I stayed away from this house. And yet, each day of these ten years, I woke up to the same sounds. For a few seconds of each day, I was back in this house. But this time it was real. I was sleeping in the big hall with Mini beside me. She was frowning anxiously in her sleep as if confronted by a problem she could not solve. My hand hovered over her for a moment, wanting to wake her up and get her out of the dilemma she was facing in her dreams. But I drew it away. Let her be. Her marriage . . . I knew the facts now and the thought of it angered me. But I knew it was not the reason why she would frown, even in her sleep.

I got up, yawning loudly, thinking longingly of a cup of tea. But first, I had to brush my teeth and wash my face. I wandered into the backyard, to the tap near the raised washing stone. Better this than the bathroom with its slimy stone floor and huge copper vessels so rarely cleaned that they had turned green inside. When had they last been cleaned? There had to be an eclipse or a Divali for the bathroom vessels to get a cleaning. I grimaced at the thought.

As I scrubbed at my face, I remembered a friend of mine, come back from abroad, saying to me, 'You know, Indu, even there, I used to remove my stockings and shoes and wash my feet in the bath tub before going to bed.'

That's how it is. We flatter ourselves that we've escaped the compulsions of the past; but we're still pinioned to it by little things. If not, why do I hesitate to have a cup of tea before washing and brushing? Why do I dislike the thought of a meal before I've had my bath?

'Your natural fastidiousness,' Jayant calls it with a smile in which I see a hint of sarcasm, which seems to my uneasy mind to say.... You're the same after all. Same taboos, same fetishes, under a different name. Sometimes I have a sneaking suspicion that our ancestors are going to have the last laugh on us after all.

'There you are, Indu. I was waiting for you. I've just made some fresh tea. I was thinking of coming up to wake you up.' I wiped my face with my sari... how easy it is to slide into the old ways... and sat down, gratefully accepting the cup Atya held out to me. My earliest memories are of Atya sitting patiently in front of the Primus, waiting for the water to boil.

'Where's everyone?' I asked her. It was now six days since Akka's death, and only the close family was left at home. Which still meant about twenty of us.

'You're between the two rounds. The early risers have finished. And the late risers aren't up as yet. Is Mini still sleeping? Is the tea all right? Want more sugar?'

She was stirring the tea in a large vessel with the strainer. Ours was a haphazard household. Cups without ears, saucers that never matched, and most of the time, no spoons. Tea and sugar were added by the guess

method. Surprisingly, the tea was almost always good.

'No, even this is much more than what I normally take. My usual is half a spoon per cup.'

'Everyone is scared of getting fat these days. As if it's a crime. No sugar, no rice, no ghee . . . And people who can afford to eat all this are the very ones who won't. I don't understand. But then . . . you people know and understand so much more than we ever did. You don't have to worry, Indu. You're too thin as it is. Don't you eat anything?'

I made a face. 'I'm all right, Atya. Forget about me. Isn't there a spoon somewhere?'

'Spoons . . . I don't know where all the spoons have gone to today. I asked Mangala to go and find out and she's disappeared herself. Must have gone to Sanju. That child is still a baby. Wants his mother the moment he wakes up.'

'Mangala . . . that's Hemant's wife, isn't it?'

'Of course. See what happens when you stay away too long?' It was strange how they all seemed determined to ignore the reason for my staying away. But Atya was not the person to argue with.

'It's not that, Atya. I get confused between her and Nalini, Sumant's wife.'

'You won't get confused if you come home more often. You don't know how we old people long to see you. You were fifteen days old when Anant brought you home. I gave you a bath. You didn't cry . . . not a bit. You were such a smiling and placid child.' Why is one so ridiculously pleased to be reminded of one's infancy? I could feel a fatuous smile creeping across my face. But Atya's smile was pure affection. How old was she? Older than Kaka. The eldest of grandfather's large family. Which made her past sixty. She had had a hard life.

What else can a childless widow expect? Her in-laws had, true to tradition, ill-treated her after her husband's death. And then, grandfather had brought her home. Her home, where she worked from morning to night, every day of her life, expecting nothing. In spite of all the household work she did, she was never too busy to have time to give a hungry child something to eat, soothe a crying child, or relieve a tired, irritable young mother of her burden. Her eyes were still clear, still unshadowed. Whatever she had gone through hadn't darkened her vision.

'I'm surprised you can remember each one of us, Atya.' I grinned at her. 'I mean, you bathed all the babies in the family, didn't you? Are you sure you haven't got us mixed up? Maybe I was the squalling kid, and Sumant the happy one.'

'What's that about me?' Sumant came in, a child on his arm. 'Tea, atya, for both of us. What were you saying, Indu?'

'She was saying that maybe I got both of you mixed up. As babies, I mean.'

Sumant looked bewildered at that, while Atya went on. 'As if I would do that, Indu! I can remember each one of you. Specially you, Indu. I didn't have to share you with any mother, remember?'

'Yes we all knew Indu was your favourite. Yours and even Appa's.'

We had never been close, Sumant and I, though there was scarcely a month between us. But now there was actual hostility, positive unfriendliness in his tone. It was not difficult to guess why. His dingy striped pyjamas, his drooping mouth, they all told the same story. A failure? I hesitated to use the word; but yes, if success meant having a certain income, a certain way of life both of

Kaka's elder sons were failures. And I . . . by that standard I was a success. Even as I rejected the word, I had a fleeting thought of how much more Sumant would dislike me if he knew what Akka had done. I felt guilty about it, and guilt made me unusually gentle. 'Maybe it was pity for a child who was practically an orphan,' I replied equably. 'This little fellow now . . . what's his name?'

'Don't you know? But, of course, how can you? We can't expect you to take too much interest in us. He's Abhay.'

I let that pass too. I had learnt it young and learnt it painlessly . . . the intrigues, the groups, the schisms in a family. The jealousies, the rivalries, the barbed tongues and malicious words. But the years I had stayed away had erased these memories. Now I was learning it all afresh. And this time the acquisition of knowledge was not so painless. It hurt. 'Yes, of course. Abhay.'

Why 'of course'? I hadn't known his name till this minute. But my marriage had taught me this too. I had found in myself an immense capacity for deception. I had learnt to reveal to Jayant nothing but what he wanted to see, to say to him nothing but what he wanted to hear. I hid my responses and emotions as if they were bits of garbage.

'Go to Indu-atya, Abhay. She's also your atya, like Mini-atya. Go on, boy.'

He passed the unwilling child to me. The child squirmed uncomfortably on my lap. Atya gave me a peculiar look, as if the sight of me with a child on my lap aroused some thoughts in her. I knew what they were. They had all said it to me some time or the other since my return, Akka having been the first with her inimitable nastiness.

'I suppose you're taking some of the things they take now to prevent having children. When are you going to have one? After your menopause?'

I had parried all these thrusts effortlessly. But Atya? I could neither lie to her nor reveal the truth.

And what is the truth? That Jayant, son of a perfectionist mother, shies away from the thought of a child of his own? That I, motherless and yet never unloved, quail at the thought of becoming a mother for fear of being disillusioned? You think marriage is the answer. It isn't and then you pin your hope on children. A child, you tell yourself, is the ultimate answer, the only meaning. God! I wouldn't dare to take the risk of finding myself wrong after all. And so, Jayant and I, tell each other . . . not now, we can't afford it, we don't have a reliable servant, I can't get leave The truth is, I will have no child that is not wholly welcome.

Sumant's son was tugging at my arm which held him. 'What is it, Abhay? Want to get off? Okay.'

I let him go. Immediately he went to Atya. Sumant seemed hurt by my willingness to relinquish his son. But Atya made up for my indifference. She poured milk into a cup, added a little tea to satisfy the child and fed him lovingly from a saucer. The boy lapped it up like a hungry kitten. I watched, and thought of the times when she had done the same for us. 'Tea,' we used to cry, 'not milk.' And she would pour a little tea into the milk. But we were never satisfied. 'More tea, I want more tea,' I can remember crying once, little horror that I was. And Kaki had slapped me for it. But Atya never lost patience. She never showed that she did. Only once, I had had a glimpse of her real feelings. I was 15 then, and a monster, with my devastating honesty and insatiable desire, like Rosa Dartle, to know.

'Atya don't you wish sometimes you had your own children?' I had asked.

And for the first time I had seen her with her endurance mask off. 'Wish? Put a person in a room this size,' she had brought her hands together, 'and for some time he'll scream and shout and rage and bang his head against the wall. Then he gets used to it.'

And there were her headaches, days when she could do nothing but lie in a darkened room and suffer.

'Where's Kaka?' I asked Sumant, putting down my cup.

'Appa? Where he always is at this time. In his room.'

I got up yawning again. I could see Sumant was not easy with me. And I thought of what Sharad, Kaka's youngest, had said to me on my return. Sharad had been only 8 when I left, a cheeky, impudent youngster, atrociously spoilt by his mother.

'This is a great day in my life,' he said to me. 'I must write about it in my diary.'

And suddenly, breaking out of his solemnity, he had grinned irrepressibly at me. And I had known that, in spite of the impressive foliage on his face, it was the same old Sharad. But I had been fresh from my meeting with Akka and in no mood to take anything from anyone, least of all from Sharad.

'What's the joke?' I had asked him sternly.

'No joke, I'm serious. Honest. Don't you know your reputation around here?'

'Mud, I suppose,' I had said wryly.

'Formidable, big sister. Formidable. You should listen to them talking about you. You're the standard set up for us luckless youngsters. We're always measured against your stature ... your first classes, your medals,

your writing, your job, etc. etc. etc. And let me tell you frankly, we fail miserably. Miserably. I come up to somewhere here.' He had bent down and I had clouted him on the head. All light-hearted enough, but I had sensed the truth behind the words. They behaved differently with me. All of them. Even Kaka.

'He still does his shirsasana, you know,' Sumant informed me. It was the only discipline Kaka permitted himself. Nothing could interfere with that. 'I should try it myself. Seems to be a good way of shedding worries and responsibilities.'

Sumant spoke without a smile and I could sense the malice behind the words. And suddenly I hated him. Kaka ... the only one in the family who had come for my wedding. Apart from Father, of course. Perhaps it was the first time Kaka had defied Akka. But he had said nothing about that. On the day, however, he had awkwardly pushed a small package into my hands.

'A little gift for you as a bride, Indu. From your Kaki and me.'

I had opened it and found a piece of green silk. Green bangles. Packets of haldi and kumkum. All the symbols of a happy wifehood. I had been incredibly touched. 'I wish I could have given you something more ... but you know my position.'

In the dingy room where we had registered our marriage, Kaka had stood with Father, resplendently dressed in his best dhoti, his silk coat and cap on head, befitting the auspiciousness of the occasion. After it was over and Jayant and I were married, his face had blazed into a brilliant smile. Full of happiness for me because he knew I was happy.

'Now with Mini getting married, what responsibilities

should he have? I should imagine the rest of you are quite capable of looking after yourselves, aren't you?'

If I had thought to shame him, I failed miserably. 'Has he ever looked after us anyway?' he asked me blandly, looking more satisfied now that he had made me lose my temper.

Atya, who had been collecting the used cups and saucers for washing up, broke into our conversation, sensing my anger. 'Have your bath, Indu. Shall I oil your hair? Look at it. Dry as straw. Don't you ever use oil?'

I smiled at her. Pouring oil over troubled waters . . . how often had she done that? 'I'm all right, Atya. I'll have my bath later. Let me relax.'

Relax . . . how little the word meant here. When there never was any tension, when everyone always took things easy, what could the word mean?

'Here, give them to me. Where shall I put them? The backyard, isn't it?'

I piled the cups on a small stone platform near the back door. In a little while, the toothless old woman who had worked for our home ever since I could remember, would lackadaisically dip them in water and bring them back, wet, but scarcely cleaner.

'You want to see Anant, do you?' Atya asked me when I went back in. Did I? My secret still weighed on me . . . I hadn't spoken of it to anyone. Not Old Uncle, not Kaka, not even Atya. How long could I keep it to myself? An ardent reader of Agatha Christies, I had always imagined that as soon as a person died, the relatives came panting to find out what had happened to the money. Now Akka was dead, and they had, all of them, always been parasites on her; and yet no one, not even her husband's nephew Shridhar, who had come to per-

form the ceremonies, had shown the least curiosity about the money.

'Go on, he'll be in his room now. By the way, Indu, do you know there was a letter from Govind?'

'From Father? No, I didn't. No one told me. What does he say? Is he coming?'

'Coming?' Kaki's sharp voice came from the kitchen. She had just come out of her bath, her body still wet, her sari cursorily draped round her. As she spoke, she wiped her face with the end of her sari. 'Why would he come? I don't want to hurt your feelings, Indu; after all he is your father, but' — how often I had heard this sentence — 'I think it's too bad the way he avoids all responsibilities. Is this house only ours? Are these duties only ours?' With an angry jerk she knotted the inside end of the sari round her waist. Years of this tight knotting had left black weals round her waist. Idly I wondered what Kaka made of those disfiguring marks. Most probably, nothing. Husbands and wives ... their worlds touched briefly only in the darkness of the night.

'There's Sumitra and Madhavrao. They never came even after they heard of Akka's death. They write they'll be coming for the 13th day. Yes, they'll come, after we've slogged like slaves getting ready for the ceremonies. Can't get leave, they say. That's a good excuse for him, but what about her? Is she working, too? And your father ... he could easily have come if he had made up his mind. But he's never taken any interest in family matters. Is that fair?'

'He came here two years ago, Vahini,' Atya put in mildly.

'Two years ago! That was only because he was on his way to somewhere else. Some work, he said. Taking photographs!' Kaki went into the women's room to

finish the rest of her dressing up. Which meant tying her hair into a sleek, tight knot and applying her kumkum. Atya, seeing my face, said, 'I always ask myself . . . why couldn't God have let your mother live! When he got married I was just like the rest. I didn't like the idea because she wasn't of our caste. Now . . . I don't know. What difference did it make? She could have made him happy. Look at him now! Ever since he lost her, he's been a wanderer. And with his brains, he could have gone far. That's why, Indu, when we heard you're getting married, I didn't much mind that your husband doesn't belong to our community. I never said it to Akka, but . . .'

I had lost my mother at birth. There is nothing unique about losing one's mother. But a child, in spite of losing its mother, gets some idea of her from others, from photographs, from conversations. But I . . . No one had ever spoken of her, or even mentioned her name. For me it had been a total blank. A blankness that had left its mark on me. And, incredible though it sounds, I had not even known of her existence, until Naren had said to me once, boastfully, 'My mother was drowned. So was my father. How did your mother die?'

And then, for the first time, it had occurred to me that I must have had a mother. I had gone to Old Uncle and heard of her for the first time in my life . . . at the age of six. 'He seems to be happy in his own way, Atya,' I comforted her.

'Does he visit you often?'

'Sometimes. Any odd time. You can never guess when he'll come. He never informs me, either. Disappears in the same way.'

'How does he get on with his son-in-law?'

I laughed. 'Surprisingly well. They seem to appreciate each other a lot.'

That was odd. No two men could be more dissimilar. Father, untidy, careless, no idea of money and hopelessly confused about everything but his work. And, as I always tell Father, he is liable to top the list, if they ever make one, of the worst dressed men in the world. The pity was, that when Father made an effort, as he did for my wedding, he looked even worse. Even Kaka had looked elegant by his side that day. As for Jayant ... I had seen him blink his eyes in disbelief at Father. And yet Jayant, methodical, elegant, particular about doing things the right way, and Father, had formed a Mutual Admiration Society which irritated me by its very unexpectedness. Father seemed enthralled by Jayant's work and the glimpse it gave him of the world of big business. And Jayant had a small boy's enthusiasm about Father's work. 'That's a bit of luck,' Atya sighed. 'I don't know when I'll see my son-in-law. Well, I must go and have my bath. Time to start the cooking.'

Children, few of whom I could identify, were playing in the large hall. They stared at me as I went by. Two large portraits of my grandparents hung in the hall, garlanded as usual. My grandfather I had never seen, but my grandmother had died when I was a child. I had always known that she did not count. A timid, subdued woman, she seemed, even in her portrait, to be amazed by her temerity in being next to her grim, forbidding husband. In my childhood I had imagined him to be, perhaps because of the flowers and kumkum, a particularly vengeful and fearful god.

It was my grandfather who had first lived in this house. His father had built it, but he had died before he could live in it. My grandfather had made extensions

and renovations, but his garish taste and love of solidity had made the house into an odd combination, like a good looking woman dressed in execrable bad taste. Whatever beauty it had now lay in its open courtyards, capturing light and air and bringing them into the house. And the woodwork. While the doors were massive and heavily carved, there was a generosity and imagination about the floor length windows with their gracefully arched frames and delicate lattice work. The staircase, however, was merely functional; just wooden stairs hollowed out in the centre by countless feet going up and down, and enclosed by dark and dingy walls.

Kaka was in his room in the shirsasana pose, head on the floor, legs up in the air. He was wearing a pair of khaki shorts which made him look like an elderly boy scout. I sat down, waiting patiently for him to come down to earth. The morning sun streamed in through the windows, making the cluster of flowers on the ancient carpet bloom and come alive. A couple of pigeons were cooing throatily at one another just outside. Someone was washing clothes in the back courtyard. Whoosh, whoosh . . . I could hear the cloth slapping against the stone. Drops of water sprayed into multicoloured fountains as they caught the sunlight. 'So, Indu . . .'

I turned round. Kaka was back to normal, his face flushed, his hair tousled. He scratched vigorously at his hair, went to the window and yelled, 'Hey, someone get me my tea.'

Then he sat down. I sat opposite him, cross-legged, and said, imitating his tone, 'So Kaka . . .?'

He pulled his paan box towards him and asked me, 'Want some paan? Tobacco?'

I laughed. It was an old joke. As a child, I used to pester him for a bit of paan, a bit of tobacco. One day,

he had given in. I had chewed it hesitantly, shamming enthusiasm, and had fallen down in a dead faint.

'You want Kaki to come up and let you have it, do you?' She had really let off steam against Kaka that time.

'Oh, her bark is worse than her bite. She was so concerned about you she forgot everything else.'

Kaka had always felt guilty that I did not feel the same affection for her as I did for him, 'Loyal little Indu,' Naren had mocked. 'You're very choosy about bestowing your affections, aren't you, Indu?' Old Uncle had said to me once. I was. And unchanging. There had not been many people in my life I had cared for. Atya, Kaka and Old Uncle in the family. Hema in school and college. And then Jayant. The day I had met him, a burden, the weight of uncertainty, had fallen off me. There had been an absoluteness, a certainty instead. I had known then . . . it was this man and none other.

'How does it feel to be back, Indu?' Kaka asked me. 'You don't know how happy I feel to see you home. I felt guilty we never asked you to come home with your husband. The first Divali . . . I did think of it. But Akka . . .'

'Really, Kaka! The way you talk! Why were you so terrified of Akka? What did you imagine she would do to you if you disobeyed?'

'It's not that, Indu. You people will never understand. For our generation, elders were to be feared, respected, obeyed. We used to sit up when they entered the room, and touch their feet when we went out; yet there was affection too.' Old Uncle had said the same thing to me once. 'Affection in a family . . . it should be a living presence. As it was once.' The old . . . they dream of the

past, as revolutionaries do of the future. Perfection for them *was*, as it *will be* for the revolutionary. It never *is*.

'You youngsters now ... you're a different breed altogether. You should see Sharad arguing with me. The rascal is the same with everyone, I must say. Hopelessly spoilt by his mother. The only person he was scared of was Akka. And that, I think, was partly because he hoped she would give him money to pay the donation to enter a medical college. Now he pesters me. From where can I get the money?'

'Is Sharad interested in doing medicine?' I asked in surprise.

'That's what he says. If you ask me, it's not so much the profession he's interested in; he imagines the 'Dr' before his name, himself driving a new car, and patients waiting in rows with their fists full of money. Pooh! The fellow won't even work to realise his dream. He got a third class last year.'

Kaka sighed heavily. I laughed.

'Poor man, your family is a burden, isn't it? Anyway, you're getting rid of Mini all right.'

He looked awkward, embarrassed, as I went on, 'Are you pleased about it, Kaka?'

'Why not? It's a good alliance.'

'I'm sure Akka called it perfect. I hear she's the one who fixed it up.'

'Yes, they're distant relations of her husband's. Her word counted for a lot with them. Without that, I don't think we had much of a chance. You know Padmini's horoscope has a flaw in it.' His voice was ... no, not apologetic ... why should he apologise to me? ... but guarded. I rubbed my fingertips hard on the carpet. Millions of motes flew up into the column of sunlight that entered through the window.

After a pause, realising I wasn't going to say anything, he went on in a firmer, less hesitant voice. 'Yes, I think we've been lucky. Considering the family, status and all that, we've been quite lucky.'

'Lucky?' It was as if he had thrown down a gauntlet. 'Lucky? No, Kaka, that's too much. I mean, I may not have seen him, but I've heard of him'

'And who's the son of a bitch who's been talking rot to you?' If his voice was explosive with anger, I knew it was not genuine. He was using anger very deliberately as a weapon. 'Is it Sunanda? That girl — girl? she's a grown woman though she still has the sense of a silly kid — is a mischief maker. What's wrong with the boy? He has two legs, two arms, two eyes, two ears'

I began to shake with laughter at Kaka's catalogue of his prospective son-in-law's virtues. He gave me a sour look, asking, 'What's the joke? I'm just telling you he's a normal human being. So what if he's a little dark? So what if he's not too bright? So what if'

A child darted in with a cup of tea balanced precariously in his small hands. A good bit of the tea had slopped into the saucer.

'Here's your tea, grandfather,' he said, and giving me a curious, sideways look, ran out again.

'Who's that?'

'Hemant's eldest. Hey you, Vishu, come back. Silly boy, running away like that. Don't you know who this is?'

The boy nodded solemnly, this time avoiding looking at me.

'Then tell.'

'Indu-atya,' he said glibly, as if someone had coached him.

'You know my name. Now tell me yours,' I said.

'Vishwas.'

'And how old are you?'

'Eight.'

'And still a baby. His mother has to give him a bath.'

'Grandfather!' he shrieked protestingly. 'That's not me. That's Sanju.'

'Well, if you're so grown up, look at your nose!' Kaka retorted. 'Can't you wipe it yourself? Or you need your mother to wipe it for you? And what do you mean by bringing only one cup of tea?'

'They gave it to me. I brought it.' The boy seemed unperturbed. Obviously he was as little deceived by Kaka's stern face and harsh words as we had been when we were little. Kaka had never been able to keep us in awe of him. 'Smart child, eh? Knows all the answers. Well, if you're so smart, go down at once and get another cup of tea for Jndu-itya.'

'Okay.'

As the kid went out, I laughed. 'Can you imagine them sending up a cup of tea for me? Women and children should know their places.'

'Have a bit of mine.'

'Honestly, Kaka, I don't need it. I've just had a cup.'

But it was impossible to resist him. I drank gingerly from the cup while he took large noisy swallows from the saucer.

'You know,' he said, peering at me over the saucer, 'they're all scared of you.'

'Of me?'

He nodded. 'They think,' he finished his tea with a 'they think you're capable of anything.'

satisfied grunt, and dragged his paan box towards him,

'Such as?'

I awaited his answer with trepidation, but seeing his face, relaxed.

'Well, there were arguments. Would you come at all? And if you did, how would you come? How changed would you be? Would you come in pants and,' dropping his voice to a whisper, 'with your hair up to here?' His hand went to his ear. I gave him an answering grin. 'It's not so important to shock people any more, Kaka. I've grown up.'

'Have you?' He made a comically surprised face.

'Now I dress the way I want. As I please.'

As I please? No, that's not true. When I look in the mirror, I think of Jayant. When I dress, I think of Jayant. When I undress I think of him. Always what he wants. What he would like. What would please him. And I can't blame him. It's not he who has pressurised me into this. It's the way I want it to be. And one day I had thought ... isn't there anything I want at all? Have I become fluid, with no shape, no form of my own? At that moment a savage truth had stared me in the face ... Without wants there is no 'I'.

And a still more frightful a comically frightful thought had occurred. Am I on my way to becoming an ideal woman? A woman who sheds her 'I', who loses her identity in her husband's?

Kaka now stuffed his mouth with paan and supari and spoke with his mouth full, two red liquid spots oozing out of the corner of his mouth as he chewed.

'But I must say you're much better than those two girls of Madhav's. I wonder Sumitra encourages them to dress in that way.'

'Kaka,' I tugged him firmly back to the point... 'we were talking of Mini's marriage. You never told me what he's doing.'

'Didn't Sunanda tell you that?' he shot me an amused glance. 'Anyway, he's managing their property. They have a good bit of it still. Actually, the father is managing it, but eventually' his voice trailed off.

I waited, silent, until I was sure no more was coming. 'What about his education?'

'He's passed his S.S.C. Went one year to college, I think. Or maybe he didn't really pass. What does that matter? He doesn't need a job. They have plenty. He can live in comfort like a lord on what they have. And what's the use of these degrees? Can they guarantee a job? Look at Naren.'

'Naren!' I was exasperated. 'Don't compare him to this ... this blessed paragon of yours. You know Naren is ...'

'I don't need to be told what Naren is. I know him. And, you know, Indu,' Kaka leaned forwards looking conspiratorial, 'I like that fellow. Your Kaki, Akka, even Narmada, your Atya ... none of them like him. But I do. His mother, Old Uncle's Saroja ... I remember her very distinctly. A little thing like you. But very quiet. And when she sang ... God, what a voice she had!'

'I've heard that,' I exclaimed impatiently. 'And of how she wanted to learn music and how Akka put her foot down.' What—learn music from a strange man! Sit and sing in front of strangers! Like *those* women? Are we that kind of a family? Isn't it enough for you to sing one or two devotional songs, one or two aarti songs? What more does a girl from a decent family need to know?

Kaka sighed heavily. 'Yes, that was wrong. I always felt it. But she never complained. She got married and was very happy. Naren's father ... he was fond of music, too, and he wanted her to start learning. After

Naren's birth, they decided. And then both of them died. Poor Old Uncle never got over it. He always felt guilty towards Saroja. Maybe that's why he's been so soft with Naren.'

The sun had moved and was now on my back. It was too warm. I moved and sat leaning against the wall. There was a sudden babble of sound from downstairs. Then loud laughter. I could hear Sharad's voice. A child began to cry, adding to the hubbub, but there was no dissonance in it. I let all the sounds seep into me gently, without violence. I am home, I thought. This is home. I had to go away to know it. It was moment of rare and pure happiness.

'Does he visit you often?'

'Naren is like you. He tells me I'm a fool to marry Padmini to that man. But tell me, Indu, what am I to do?'

I came back to reality. 'Do? Why, wait for a better chance!'

He gave me the look of an adult to a foolish child. 'Another chance? We had to wait long enough for this one. Padmini is past 24 now. And there's her horoscope. And the problem of finding a family with a status comparable to ours. And when everything clicks, there's the dowry hurdle. What am I to do? Let the girl stay unmarried? It's all right so long as I'm alive. When I'm gone, can you see her brothers looking after her? Maybe the boy is a little ugly, maybe a little stupid... but everything else is fine. The family is good, it's known to us, they have money, she'll be quite comfortable. And Akka had promised she would pay for the wedding expenses as well as the dowry if this came through. What else could I ask for?'

I had never seen Kaka so earnest. But my mind,

relinquishing the other things, picked up only one fact. And the question that had lain dormant in my mind all these days, suddenly sprang to life.

‘Akka had promised. But now what happens?’

Kaka shrugged. ‘I suppose we’ll get it all the same. The others will kick up a row, I’m sure. But that can’t be avoided.’

‘But who’s in charge of Akka’s affairs, Kaka?’

‘Her affairs? You mean her money?’ He seemed curiously unconcerned about it. He took it for granted nothing had changed. He had never-known Akka. At that moment I hated the old woman for doing this to him, to me, to all of us. ‘I suppose Shyamrao knows all about it. You remember him?’ I brought him back to mind. A lawyer and a family friend. ‘He knows everything. Akka trusted him. He’s the one who advised her. We were never consulted.’

There was no rancour in his tone. I wondered at him.

‘Where is Shyamu-kaka? I haven’t seen him since I came home.’

‘He isn’t here. He’s gone to his son’s place for a holiday. Somewhere in the North. We wrote him after Akka died.’ There was a sound in the next room. ‘Hemant’

Hemant appeared in the door. ‘Did you write to Shyamrao? About Akka?’

‘I did. I’ve got a reply. He says he’ll be back in two or three days.’

It was like a reprieve. Hemant, who had gone out, came back into the room, saying, ‘Indu, there was a letter for you in last evening’s post. Did you get it? I asked Sharad to give it to you.’

‘For me?’ It had to be from Jayant. I had written to him on the day of the funeral. ‘No, Sharad hasn’t given

it to me.' Last evening? And last night I was thinking Damn and blast Sharad!

'That boy is the most irresponsible idiot He must have got it in his pocket. Are you going down?'

Going down? I had to force myself to sit still, not to get up, not to run down and snatch the letter from Sharad. My legs trembled with the effort of doing nothing. Long ago it had frightened me . . . my capacity for total self-surrender. It's not only tragic, it's foolish. That's what I had always thought. Self-abnegation had seemed to me to be an exercise in futility. But when I did it for Jayant

'I'll be going down in a minute,' I said casually.

'Hemant, have you checked the list properly? Sure we haven't forgotten anyone or anything? Has anyone written to Akka's sister-in-law? We don't want confusion. You know what happened at Sharad's thread ceremony.'

Hemant gave a thin smile. 'I've done all that I can. But that won't prevent the others from coming at the last moment and asking me, "Why have you done this?" and "Why haven't you done that?" I'm both the dhobi's donkey and the scapegoat here.'

Kaka sat with a deadpan face until Hemant left. Then he burst out, 'The hell with them! Complaining, complaining! One son of a bitch complaining about another. I'm sick of it.'

I was too used to Kaka's language and fits of temper to be affected by this. 'So Hemant is still here.'

'Yes, he has a job here. He stays with us, which is both cheap and convenient for him. But no, he can't be happy. He grumbles, and his wife nags. "Because I'm here I have all the responsibility," he says. And

Sumant says ... "Hemant is lucky. No expenses, no problems." Bah !

I had to laugh. 'But why do you let them get away with it ? It has nothing to do with you.'

'Hasn't it ! How innocent you are, Indu ! Who didn't give Hemant a good education ? Me. Who didn't help Sumant when he wanted some money after his marriage ? Me. Who can't give Sharad money for entering a medical college ? Me. I have a lot of money piled up, haven't I ? Look at this house ...'

He tapped the wall and a bit of the plaster fell down. 'It's the same story all over the house. Even the new rooms.' The 'new rooms' had been built by grandfather nearly forty years ago. 'I can't even afford to pay the taxes on this now. Last year ... no, two years back, I borrowed from your father.'

'Father ?' I was astounded. 'He had money ?'

Kaka looked shamefaced. 'He'd just got a big cheque from some foreign magazine. He gave all of it to me. Last year Madhav paid. If I ask him again this year, his wife will eat him up alive. And Akka ... she helped if she was in the mood. If not'

'But Kaka, have all the lands gone ?'

'All of them. Who would have imagined it ? Our own lands ... for generations they were ours ... and we had to hand them over just like that. I was hoping one of the boys would live there and cultivate some of the land. But no, they all want cosy office jobs. As it is, I've just managed to retain the mango orchards. That pays something. But the last two years even the mango crop failed miserably. If someone had told me this some years back, I'd never have believed it. When father was alive, he just had to go there and the fellows would fall at his feet. Now, they've become too big. They know

they have the upper hand. They're arrogant, disrespectful. And for generations, we were like kings'

This was Kaka, and I could sympathise with him. Anyone else, I'd have said He who works shall eat. Why couldn't I say it to Kaka?

'Are things really so bad, Kaka?' I asked. And I never knew.

'So bad that I'm thinking of looking for some clients again.' Kaka was what used to be called a 'pleader', and it was a family legend that he had had a client once. Though this had never been proved.

I laughed delightedly. 'As bad as that? Poor Kaka. Never mind. When things become unbearable, you can come and stay with me. I promise to look after you.'

'That, of course! Eventually, I'm going to do just that. Once this Padmini and Sharad are off my hands, I'm free. Your Kaki wants to go to Kashi and Badri and what not. Let her go and earn merit for both of us. I'll go and stay with my rich niece. A life of luxury and comfort, eh?'

'You're always welcome. But remember, I'll take you at your word. You can't back out now.'

'Of course not. Who wants to? Lucky girl not to have to worry about money.' He looked as wistful as a child.

'But I always knew you'd do well. I knew you'd succeed.' Succeed? That word again. Why does that word have such unpleasant connotations for me? I, who am so integral a part of a success-oriented society?

'If only one of my children could have been clever like you. No such luck. And how can I blame them! Look at me! Never passed an exam first shot. First your father overtook me, then Madhav, next it would have been Vinayak At that point I gave up. I too have some pride after all.' He roared with laughter. 'Well!'

He clapped a prepared paan into his mouth, pushed in a wad of tobacco and rubbed his hands vigorously on his shorts. 'I must dress.'

And that, I knew, was that!

I went down in search of Sharad, and got my letter from him. After I read it, there was the same cold, dead feeling in me that came after talking to Jayant, reading a letter from Jayant, making love to Jayant. And after a while, I read it again. And thought ... he has written. He does say 'I'm missing you.' He does ask 'When are you returning?' Why do I pitch my expectations so high? I thought of a friend who had said to me ... 'You expect too much and you're bound to be disappointed. And so I'm grading my expectations down. Each month, each day, I expect less and less and less from him.' Why can't I do that? Why can't I compromise for what he can give ... deep affection, yes; total, absolute commitment, no ... instead of craving for a response that will match mine?

Finally I put my letter carefully away in my suitcase, and gave myself up to Atya's ministrations. She rubbed oil into my hair until I was dripping, then scrubbed me with soapnut powder and poured buckets of hot water on to me. She had tucked her sari up and I could see her legs, slim and supple as a young girl's.

'You know, Atya,' I said, screwing up my eyes tightly to prevent the soapnut powder from getting into them.

'What?'

'I've suddenly made a discovery. There are only two types of people in the world. The givers and the takers. You're a giver. Ouch! My eyes, my eyes! Water, quick, atya, water!' The soapnut powder had entered my eyes.

For a few days life had returned to a semblance of normalcy. Now, on the final day of mourning for Akka, it was chaos again. A purposeful chaos. The family was complete, except for Father. And Jayant, if he counted as one of the family. Obviously he did, for I had suddenly begun hearing, to my bewilderment, everyone referring to him as 'our son-in-law' or 'our brother-in-law'. It gave me, who had counted the family out, who had forgotten how things were here, an odd feeling to hear the words with their possessive pronoun. But there was, I knew, no falseness about the words. A person belonged to the whole family. Your brother's daughter was yours, his son-in-law yours as well. This I could understand. Not so easily the thought . . . if they were so prepared to accept Jayant now, why had they held back these three years? And would they change when they heard what Akka had done?

The knowledge still lay heavily on me. There was no one with whom I could share it. At one time, perhaps, I would have gone to Old Uncle. But Old Uncle had changed. When I left, he had been a cheerful, spry old man. Now he looked, not bitter, but defeated. His lips had become as blubbery as a baby's, elastic and spreading, with no firmness behind them . . . 'Time for me to go,' he often mumbled. How much of this was Naren's fault . . . !

I had been hearing of Naren's various misdemeanours since my return. They had all spoken of them; all, except Old Uncle. He never spoke of Naren, not even to defend him. And so Naren, an outcaste, was another

who was not there. But all the rest of us were there to bid Akka a ceremonial farewell.

Vinayak-kaka, his wife and three noisy daughters had arrived two days earlier, shattering the funeral atmosphere with their high spirits. Vinayak-kaka, a licentiate doctor in a small town, was a small roly-poly man, with all of Kaka's effervescence, though little of his spontaneity. There was something studied and calculated about his good humour. Sumitra-kaki, who, with her daughters, had come a day earlier, wore a pained expression on hearing his and Kamala-kaki's loud laughter, and became, if anything, even more urbane on their arrival.

Her younger daughter Geeta, however, seemed to have none of her mother's urbanity. She had bounced at me effusively calling out, 'Hi, Indu! You here? How exciting! I'd heard there was a family feud. What's happened to it?'

I had looked at her with dislike. The difference, I thought, between you and your mother is very superficial. A few years more and you'll be everything your mother is. Maybe I'm lucky after all not to have a mother. To see your future self, to move inexorably towards it, to know there's no escape !

Madhav-kaka, with Sunil, was of course the last to arrive, with his inevitable air of being a very busy VIP.

'It's the Saheb,' Sharad had hissed at me, when I had met him coming in with a suitcase in either hand, parodying Sumitra-kaki's habit of referring to her husband as 'the Saheb'.

'Why can't the Saheb's son carry his father's luggage?'

'And lose caste! Don't be silly!'

Out of the mouths of babes and sucklings, I had thought. We Indians can never get away from caste. If we've rejected the old ones, we've embraced new ones. Do I think of myself as a Brahmin? Rarely, if ever. But I'm the educated, intelligent, urban, middle class. We have our own rules, our own pattern, to which I adhere as scrupulously as Atya and Kaki observe their fasts and pujas.

A birth, a marriage, a death . . . we Hindus have elaborate rituals for all of them. They seemed meaningless to me, the rituals that Akka's husband's nephew, Shridhar, performed, his newly shaven head drooping piously. I hoped no one would do such things for me. Yet I knew it was unavoidable. You can never be just a carcass to be disposed of just like that, without any mumbo jumbo. Your religion claims you at last, however little you believe. We try to fool ourselves that we are not like other living things. For us, we think, death is not the end. It is the beginning of something else. And so, we gently ease the dead, with formality and ceremony, into that something else.

But they don't really go anywhere, our dead. Here, where we were all gathered to perform Akka's final obsequies, I could feel her presence very strongly among us. I could feel her enjoying, as she had always done, having the whole family together; giving her a chance to probe, to scold, to decide, to dominate and show her power. And there was one moment of perception when I felt like Akka herself, seeing the family as an entity, beautiful and living. It is one of those memories that will stay with me all my life. The men and children sitting down to lunch. Rows of plates, made of dried leaves woven together, laid from end to end in the large hall, interspersed with supporting

pillars of wood. Sunlight could not enter this hall which had no windows, but the sombre dimness inside was brightened by the scintillating play of light on the polished wood of the pillars, on the gleaming brassware, the tarnished silverware and the shining stainless steel ware. The children, their faces decorously subdued, were eagerly waiting to be served. The men were, most of them, without their shirts, as was the custom at meals. The sacred thread seemed like a marker between the generations. None of the younger men had it. A commonplace enough picture; but I felt as if I was looking at something that did not exist, something that was on the brink of dissolution. And it became a thing of beauty, like anything ephemeral.

And yet, I had seen it myself, as clearly as if under a microscope, the rot behind this deceptive facade. Envy and bitterness. Greed and anger ... a slow, smouldering anger. And malice and meanness. I saw it even now, when Vithal was displaced for the third time, this time by Sunanda-itya's six year old Gopi. And why not? Gopi was one of the family. While Vithal was

'Who is Vithal?' I had asked Kaki.

'An orphaned student. A pauper your Kaka picked off the streets and brought home. He stays with us, but eats in different homes on different days. When there's nowhere to go, he eats with us. I don't mind, a Brahmin boy can be useful in so many ways, but Vithal is' she shrugged in contempt. 'He's buried in his books the whole day. Not of much use to us. And never a word of gratitude.'

What did this explain about Vithal? His imperturbable air of dignity? His single track mind that kept him at his books all the time? His intelligence that

could grasp a thought, an idea, almost before it was expressed? No, neither Kaki nor anyone else, not even Kaka to whom he was just a lame dog, could see all this.

But Vithal was an outsider. The bitterness within the family was much worse. My two weeks at home had shown me that if the family was united at all, it was in this . . . a readiness to revile the others, to misunderstand, to see the worst. There was Hemant . . . I had found him writing formal letters announcing Akka's death to friends and relations. Seeing the pile of cards, I had asked, 'Can I help?'

He had shrugged and said without looking up, 'If you want to.' As I sat down opposite him, he went on, 'Sharad was to have helped, but God knows where he's gone. Zooming around, I expect, on that borrowed motorbike. Anyone more irresponsible than him would be hard to find!'

'I've almost forgotten this script,' I tried to steer the conversation away from complaints. 'What a nice hand you have, Hemant!'

'What do you expect? That's the one asset of a clerk, isn't it?'

'Is it? I don't know.'

'How can you? The qualities and virtues of a clerk are things that don't enter your life. Your're far above them.'

'Why do you talk that way?' I was nettled at last. 'If you hate your job so much, why don't you give it up?'

'And do what?' He gave me a look of scorn. 'Don't forget I have a wife and two children. The way these women pestered me to get married then! It's a trap . . . that's what marriage is.'

A trap? Or a cage? Maybe the comic strip version

of marriage a cage with two trapped animals glaring hatred at each other . . . isn't so wrong after all. And it's not a joke, but a tragedy. But what animal would cage itself?

'You know I'm not even a graduate. Sumant is luckier. He was able to graduate.'

'You could have done it too.'

'That's Appa's version, is it? I must say he has a convenient memory. I can still remember his saying to me when I failed my first year in college, "I can give you only one more chance. I can't afford any more." And when I asked Akka to help me out, she said, "Why do you need a degree? Take up a job and start earning. I'm sure Madhav can get you a job." And for once, Madhav-kaka was prompt in helping. "You can still graduate by going to evening college," he said.'

He shrugged and threw one more letter on the pile. 'It never worked somehow. And now, there's Sharad. Everyone's pet. Have you seen his clothes? Akka used to pay for them. He knew how to wheedle the old woman all right. And mother as well. He doesn't do a stroke of work in the house. Yet no one asked him to stop studying when he failed once. And Akka, who didn't give me a paisa, agreed to spend thousands on Mini's wedding. Well . . . !'

It left a bad taste in my mouth. Later, I saw the same bitterness in Vinayak-kaka in spite of his air of bonhomie.

'So long since we met, Indu. God, you were only a kid then. And look at you now! I find it hard to believe this is really that same shy, awkward, rude, disobedient niece of mine.'

Had I really been all that?

‘What do you say, Kamala? And look at my three, Indu. Tell me, would you have recognised Shobha?’

Shobha, the eldest, had been a skinny, whining four-year-old when I had left home. There were no traces of that child in this plump, overgrown girl. In fact, all the children had been metamorphosed into unrecognisable adolescents.

‘Have you ever seen such bouncing, healthy girls, Indu? Aren’t they good advertisements for their father as a doctor? Tell me, Indu?’

Kamala-kaki had snorted loudly. ‘Boasting about their size when you should be worrying about it! Don’t forget you have to start looking for husbands for them in a few years. And you don’t even have any money to offer as bait. Can you believe it, Indu, he thinks he can get his daughters married just like that?’ She had snapped her fingers loudly.

‘Oh, if you’re speaking of money You’re certainly unlucky there, Kamala. You have a husband who doesn’t know how to flatter and fawn and make others pay for his daughters’ weddings. I’d much rather my daughters were spinsters.’ He said the word as if it was a dirty one. ‘What do you say, Indu? You’re like me, I’m sure.’

I had stifled my desire to laugh hysterically. I hadn’t had to flatter and fawn, certainly. But I had said nothing to either of the couple who were now, in mock-serious tones, blaming themselves for having only girls.

‘Akka kept all her softness for boys. They say even Madhav’s Sunil got something out of her the last time he came here.’

Sumitra-kaki’s talk was another variation on the same theme. She had come upon me sitting on the washing stone in the backyard, near the swamp in which the

banana trees grew. The banana trees had always seemed a miracle to me. Growing there in that filth where the gutters from the kitchen and bathroom emptied themselves, they stood straight and proud, an unsullied, tender green, sparkling in the sunlight. Seeing Sumitrakaki with a bucket in her hand, I had asked in surprise, 'Washing your own clothes?' Very conscious of her status as a government officer's wife, 'the dignity of labour' was a phrase she often used, but never lived up to. But then, her life was like that ... a succession of empty platitudes, lived with the assurance of being different, superior and exclusive. After all, her father had been a Civil Surgeon, ending up as a Director of Medical Services. And her husband a top ranking Civil servant. And she herself had been educated in a 'convent' and spoke English most of the time. And her children were trendy, mod and sophisticated. Recently, for some reason, she had accepted me as a member of her exclusive club and spoke as if we were allies against the rest of the family who were, of course, just boors.

'I have no choice.' She made a face. 'I can't bear my clothes getting mixed up with everyone else's.'

Yes, she was like that. I remember Kaka once telling me, 'When a guest leaves, she washes out everything ... as if he had the plague. Or TB.'

And it was she who had told me once, when we had met in the cloak room of an exclusive auditorium during the interval of an English play that had been a hit on Broadway and the West End (and so we applauded it madly, if politely) ... she said, 'Oh, Indu, do you use these public toilets? Aren't you afraid of getting some infection? Or "those diseases"?'

While I had been wondering whether to enlighten her on how one got 'those diseases' ... certainly not

through public toilets . . . she had gone on, 'I never use any public toilet. And if I'm forced to, I manage to avoid touching anything there.' And this had left me with such a tantalising desire to know how she managed to do that, that it had put everything else out of my mind.

I got off the stone, hollowed in the centre with the thousands of clothes that had been pounded on it, and she poured water on it and cleaned it before heaping her clothes there.

'Why didn't you tell me you were coming here, Indu?' she asked, deftly soaping her sari. 'We could have travelled together.' 'Oh, mine was an on-the-spur-of-the-moment decision.'

'How did you get a reservation then?'

'I didn't. I travelled without it.'

'My God, you are wonderful. I could never do that. I've been spoilt from childhood, I suppose. My father, he never travelled except by First, and somehow I've got used to it.' She briskly scrubbed the sari, pushed it aside and picked up another garment from the bucket.

'Tell me, Indu, how do you like this idea of Mini's marriage?'

'I don't really know, Sumitra-kaki.'

'I think it's stupid. Have you seen the boy, Indu? No, of course, you haven't. I came for the engagement ceremony. God, he looks an idiot! No education, of course. And the whole lot of them . . . so terribly uncultured.'

'Cultured' was one of her favourite terms.

'And for that boy they're willing to pay Rs. 10,000 dowry. Cash, mind you! Plus all the wedding expenses. I thought Akka had taken leave of her senses. When I

tried to say it to her, she said I was jealous. Me! Jealous of that! My girls can get better matches any day. Why, there was an offer for Lata a few months back. Very well-to-do people with a prosperous family business. They were dead keen on Lata. Wouldn't take "no" for an answer. But I... we refused. They may be rich, but they don't belong to our class. They didn't have our kind of culture, if you know what I mean.'

I had heard the other version from Kaki.

'They were trying for a boy for Lata some time back. Very rich people, I believe. But they wanted Rs. 20,000 as dowry. And then Sumitra had the nerve to come to Akka.' Kaki had smiled her rare smile. 'You should have heard Akka. "What's wrong with you people? Your husband has been earning a good salary all along. Don't tell me you haven't saved up enough for your daughters' marriages! Expenses! Don't talk to me of expenses! If you had spent less on saris and paints for your face and lips and nails... you wouldn't have had to ask others now." They say it broke off finally because of the dowry.'

'I've heard they asked too much dowry,' I said bitchily. Maybe I was one of the uncultured myself to talk this way.

'Dowry? What nonsense! Who told you that? Mini's mother, I suppose. My God, the way these people spite us. It's unbearable. No one but me would put up with it. They can't bear the fact that we live comfortably, that our children are well educated. Have they any idea of our responsibilities, our expenses? I tell you frankly, Indu, its because of "him" that I'm patient. Really, why should I take it from these people... considering my family and what my father was? I was brought up differently, I tell you. And I shouldn't

speaking ill of the dead, but Akka's tongue was just poison. Sunil had come here some time back, just to meet everyone. And you know what Akka said? "What do you want now?" Just imagine! The poor boy was so hurt. Why should he want anything? He can get a job any day, but he's too independent-minded to fit into a job. "I'm not like you," he tells his father. He's cut out for other things. You know he's doing his Business Management?"

I had difficulty repressing a smile. 'Yes, I've heard of it.' It was Sharad who had told me about it.

'Business Management!' He had guffawed. 'They say that as if he's studying in one of those big national institutes. Actually he's in a private institute where you pay so much money and at the end of the year they give you a diploma that's not worth the paper it's printed on. But he couldn't get admission anywhere else. I believe Madhav-kaka was blamed for this. Until he turned round and said, "What do you expect a third class B.Sc. to get?"'

Lunch was getting over now. Madhav-kaka beckoned to me. 'Go and check that the buckets are ready in the backyard. They'll be coming out to wash their hands now.' As I moved away to comply, he hissed, 'And don't forget the towels!'

I smiled. A mind for detail. The perfect civil servant. And Kaka, who picked up his dhoti to wipe his hands and face. And Father, who took anything that came his way. Families! I had just finished making the arrangements, when they started coming out. Shyamrao was one of the first. I had avoided him till now, but seeing me, he came straight to me.

'Indu, I wanted to see you ...'

'Now!'

He looked round and smiled. 'No, later. I have to talk to the others now. You met her?'

'Who? Akka? Yes, I came here a day before she died.'

'Oh!' He stood there frowning, his dhoti raised and tucked between his knees, scrubbing his hands and face under the water I poured out for him.

'That's enough, Indu. No, I have my own towel.' He let his dhoti fall down and dried his face and hands.

'All right then, Indu. I'll see you before I leave?' He smiled at me and I nodded. A tiny man but with all the self-conscious dignity of the professional man. As a child, I had been awed by his air of importance. Even now it seemed to me odd to be standing there, talking to him on equal terms. I couldn't rid myself of the feeling of sliding back in time and becoming once again a girl in an unbuttoned dress and bare feet, stammering out, 'Yes, Shyamu-kaka' and 'No, Shyamu-kaka' to his pompous questions. But this had been happening to me since my return, the past and the present telescoping into one another, so that I did not quite know where I was.

I went into the house avoiding the hall, ugly now with all the aftermath of an eaten meal. It disgusted me to see the strewn plates, the scattered remnants. And yet, for a whole lifetime, the women patiently cleared up the mess with their bare hands after each meal. And women like Kaki even ate off the same dirty plate their husbands had eaten in earlier. Martyrs, heroines, or just stupid fools?

The door of Akka's room was ajar. I peeped in. It was dark inside with all the windows closed. There was the same musty smell within which had clung to Akka and her clothes all her life. Then I noticed, in the gloom, a shape on the bed. Someone was sleeping there.

'Who's there?' I called out, my voice high and quavery.

'Indu?' It was Atya's voice, drowsy, slurred and relaxed.

I let out my breath in relief. 'Atya, you frightened me. Why are you here?'

'My headache.'

'Have you taken something?'

'Yes, and I've had a long sleep too. What's the time? My God, they must have finished lunch. I must get up.'

I pushed her back on the bed. 'No, don't. They're managing fine. You can play truant for once. Let Sunanda-Atya do your share for once today.'

'Sunanda!' Atya laughed. To her, Sunanda was still a little girl who couldn't be trusted to do anything. 'But Indu, were you scared when you saw me sleeping here? Did you think I was Akka? You were never scared of her when she was alive. She doesn't frighten you now she's dead, does she?'

'Can I massage your head, Atya? I've become an expert now. Jayant has headaches like you. Then I have to sit and massage his head like this until he goes off to sleep.' I felt her hand on my wrist for a second. 'Are you happy with him, Indu?'

'Happy? Who can say that? But I know I can't be without him.'

'How glad I am, Indu, it's all right. I can remember Akka saying, "Such marriages never work. Different castes, different languages ... it's all right for a while. Then they realise ..."'

'Akka, Akka,' I said bitterly. 'The oracle spoke and I suppose the rest of you applauded her wisdom.'

'Don't talk that way, Indu,' Atya's voice was unusually sharp. 'You know that whatever she did was for

our own good. She wanted everyone in the family to be happy.'

I began to giggle. 'Oh, did she? Do you really believe that, Atya? No, there was only one thing she wanted. And that was to dominate. I wonder what kind of a life she led her husband.'

'Atya ...' A face peered in. 'Indu, you here too? I was looking for you everywhere.'

It was Mini, her sari tucked in at her waist, her hair tied up in a severe knot, who entered.

'Come and have lunch, Indu. We're all waiting. Atya, you too.'

'I can't eat, Mini. Not now, anyway. You know that, child. But you go, Indu. Go and have your food.'

'No, I don't want to eat either.' Mini hesitated, looking uncertainly from me to Atya.

'Go on, Mini,' I urged her. 'Take that message back. We're not coming. We will eat when we want and if we want. A Declaration of Independence.'

Mini giggled. 'My, Indu, you are in a mood today, aren't you? Okay, I'll go and tell mother that. Don't blame me if she comes here and drags you out.'

'She won't,' I said confidently. 'She'll say, "Let them do what they want. It's up to them. I can't escape work, anyway. That's all I've done ever since I entered this house."'

'Indu!' Atya expostulated.

'I won't tell Mother that,' Mini said placidly as she went out.

'Poor Mini,' I said for some reason.

'"Poor Mini", "Poor Atya"... But you never think, "Poor Akka", do you, Indu?'

'Why should I?' I asked surprised by Atya's unwonted energy. She was sitting up and glaring at me.

‘Why should you ? And why shouldn’t you ? You know nothing about her at all. If you knew . . . You were saying something about Akka’s husband. What do you know about him ?’

I shook my head. ‘He’d become ancient history by the time I grew up.’

It was then Atya told me Akka’s story. It was the first time I heard it. Now I know how strangely inadequate was my knowledge of Akka. And how strange too my ignorance of the fact that my knowledge was incomplete. And to hear it then. . . . It was as if the knowledge of the woman had been preserved for me all those years to come upon me at that moment, when it meant so much more to me than it would have done at any time before. At that moment, an understanding of what Akka was, and why she lived the way she did, why she behaved the way she did, was somehow necessary to me. I was groping in the darkness and without this bit of light it would have been worse, far worse.

But it is only now that I can think out all this, only now that my understanding encompasses all this. Then, when Atya told me the story, I absorbed only the words, the story and not the essence of Akka herself. That seeped into me later, minute drop by minute drop, so slowly, so imperceptibly that I never knew I had absorbed it. I thought of this story innumerable times afterwards. And, whenever I did, it came back in Atya’s words.

‘She was just 12 when she was married. And he was well past 30. I remember him still. He was a tall bulky man with large, coarse features. And she . . . she was small and dainty, really pretty, with her round face, fair skin, straight nose and curly hair. Six months after her marriage, she “grew up” and went to her husband’s home. What she had to endure there, no one knows.

She never told anyone. Our grandfather, her father, was a man who kept himself aloof. No one could approach him easily. And her mother, our grand-mother, died when she was a child. But I heard that twice she tried to run away.... a girl of 13. Her mother-in-law, I heard, whipped her for that and locked her up for three days. Starved her as well. And then, sent her back to her husband's room. The child, they said, cried and clung to her mother-in-law saying, "Lock me up again, lock me up." But there was no escape from a husband then. I remember her telling me before my own marriage was consummated, "Now your punishment begins, Narmada. You have to pay for all those saris and jewels." But my husband was, thank God, a decent man.

'Her husband... You know how men were in those days, specially when there was a lot of money. He had a weakness for women. How could a frightened child satisfy him? He always had mistresses. And Akka could never give birth to a living child. Not surprising, considering the kind of life she was leading. But every time she had a miscarriage, her mother-in-law blamed her for it and made life hell for her. And then, when Akka had been married for more than 15 or 20 years, he took up with one woman. I don't know who she was... I was a child then, and they spoke of such things in whispers, but children have sharp ears. I heard that he went crazy about her. He would have brought her home but for fear of his mother. But there was nothing he wouldn't do for her apart from that. He even tried to give her Akka's jewels, but she brought them here and kept them with Father. Once he, her husband, came here to claim them, and there was a terrible quarrel. But he was for some reason, frightened of Father and

because of this, he didn't take that woman into his house even after his mother's death.

'And then, one day, he had a stroke. I told you, didn't I, he was a hefty man . . . a giant of a man? It took six men to carry him home. He couldn't even wiggle a toe. He lived nearly two years after that. Akka looked after him . . . it was no joke . . . but she kept him spotless. I was there for some time. I was sent to be of some use to Akka. He couldn't speak, I remember. But he used to try. And the sounds that came out of his throat . . . they were horribly frightening. They terrified me so much I used to get nightmares. But I was too ashamed to confess it to Akka. She herself was so calm, so much in control of herself and the whole situation. Often when Akka was doing some household work, she left me alone with him. And I found out that by smiling at him and patting his hand, I could stop him making those sounds. But sometimes nothing could stop him. He would just go on and on. As if he was trying to say something.

'One day Akka found out what it was he was trying to say. How she found out, only God knows! Maybe it was a guess. He wanted her, that woman, his mistress. And Akka asked him, "Is that it? Is it her you want?"

'And his face . . . it was all twisted up on one side, but his eyes brightened. And then Akka said, "If that's what you want, you can go on wanting it. She won't come here. I won't let her." And then he began again, those terrible sounds that were not even human. And Akka, calm and cool, said, "Listen to me. It's my turn now. I've listened to you often enough. She came here. Twice. She wanted to see you. She cried and begged to be allowed to see you just for a short while. I threw her out. You'll never see her again."

'And Indu, I'll never forget it, not until I die . . . that

man, that giant of a man, began to cry. Tears poured down his face. He cried like a child. He couldn't even wipe his tears. And I began to cry too. I couldn't help it. But Akka . . . she just looked at him.

"That night, I woke up to hear Akka crying. "Akka," I called out, "Akka". There was no reply. "Akka, what is it?" I said, in a panic. I thought, you see, he was dead.

"Then she spoke. "Nothing, child."

"But you're crying, Akka. Why are you crying? What's wrong?" And she began to laugh in the middle of her sobs. It was . . . even now I can't tell you how odd it was. And she said, "Every night I've spent in this house, I've cried like this. And tonight, for the first time, someone is asking me what's wrong. It's funny, more funny than any joke. Go to sleep, child."

Atya stopped. She couldn't go on. I think she was crying. After a while, she said, 'So don't judge her, Indu. Don't judge. You know nothing about her.'

'Nothing. Except that she must have hated me to do what she did.'

'And what has she done?' Atya wiped her face with her sari.

'She's given me all her money. She's left it all to me.'

* * *

And then Atya said a strange thing. 'Poor Indu,' she said after a while. 'Poor Indu. But your shoulders are strong. Akka knew that.'

And there was Kaka calling out, 'Indu, are you there?' 'She's here,' Atya replied.

'Narmada, you here too? What are you two doing sitting in the dark?'

He stooped as he entered the room. 'What's the matter? Headache again?'

He did not look at me. 'Kaka,' I whispered. 'Shyamukaka told you?'

Somehow, for some reason, the childish diminutive I had used for Shyamrao, slipped out.

'Yes.'

It was a subdued, very un-Kakaish voice. And then suddenly he burst out laughing. His natural loud laugh.

'Come and see their faces, Indu. Come and have a look. Akka certainly gave us all a shock. I had thought ...' He wiped his face with the end of his dhoti. He's nervous, I thought. He's putting on an act. 'But, I'm glad, Indu. I'm really glad. Come, Shyamrao wants to see you.'

When we went into the hall, Sharad was there. On seeing me, he bowed low, flinging out his arm, and bringing his hand, palm up, towards his chest. 'Here comes the heiress. Welcome, Madam.'

I could have kicked him. Instead I smiled and said, 'Why, thank you, Sharad.'

And Kaka snapped, 'Stop it, you idiot.' And looked at me anxiously. And it was not Kaka, but a stranger, anxious to placate, eager to please.

So that's how it's going to be, I thought. That's how it's going to be.

As I walked through the main street of the town, I wondered at myself. Nostalgia was completely absent. In fact, looking at the groups of students standing outside the college, my old college, it was hard to imagine that I had been one of them myself just over 10 years back. It was not that I had moved away both in space and time. It was more as if, at the moment of my leaving, something had snapped, so that I had nothing to do at all with the girl who had once, like these girls, stood there.

No, I smiled to myself. Not like these girls who stood in tight little groups, away from the boys, who stood in tight little groups of their own. The two groups never touched except through rude stares, covert glances and whispered innuendoes. While I . . . ?

‘What have I done, Akka?’ I had demanded angrily.

‘Standing there in that corner alone with that boy . . .’

‘But Akka, that’s the library,’ I had tried to be patient, to explain. ‘It’s full of corners, anyway.’ Trying to be gay and whimsical now, I had met a stone wall of refusing-to-understand. ‘And we were just talking. Is that wrong? It’s not as if we were holding hands, or touching and kissing . . .’ Akka had closed her eyes, a pained look on her face.

‘That’s enough of such talk. And even if you did nothing, it’s bad enough being talked about. Why, three people have spoken to me about it since yesterday. And to your Kaka as well. No girl in our family has ever been talked about. You have to promise such a thing won’t happen again.’

‘I won’t.’

It was as if I had been accumulating. 'I won'ts' since my birth. Now it had become a mountain of a negation, giving me an immense strength to withstand.

'I haven't done anything wrong. Nothing I need be ashamed of.'

'I don't know where you get it from. Your father was such a quiet boy,'—she had eyed me with her shrewd, calculating look—'until your mother trapped him.'

Ever since I had known it, there had been to me something sacred in the love between my father and mother, who had overcome the then almost unsurmountable barriers of caste and lived a tragically short but intensely happy life together. Akka's words had been profanation and desecration. The same day I had written to Father and made my plans for leaving.

Naren's room was at the other end of the town. I had obtained his address deviously, for some reason not telling anyone, not even Old Uncle, I was going to meet him. As I opened the gate of the house, it whined. Instantly, two female faces appeared in the front veranda and stared at me unsmilingly, unblinkingly through the grille. This was a large, old fashioned house like ours, but better maintained. I walked round to the back, to what was termed 'the out-house'. This was a long narrow building, with a veranda that ran the whole length of it, punctuated by three doors and three windows. One of the windows was open and loud music streamed out through it. I smiled. Naren had always liked his music loud and always made a nuisance of himself over it. What surprised me, however, was the song. It was a devotional song.

I knocked loudly on the door with my fist, conscious of the two faces which were now peeping at me through an identical mesh in the back veranda.

'Push the door, it's open.' Naren called out. He was lying on a carpet on the floor, legs stretched out full length, three pillows beneath his head. As he saw me, his expectant look turned into a brilliant smile, as if I was the one person he had been waiting for. Then he put his finger to his lips and gestured to the floor. I sat down and looked round.

One steel bed. One rickety table and chair. One cane shelf over-stuffed with books. One discoloured carpet on the floor. And Naren lying peacefully on it. Naren, I knew, was one of the most restless persons in the world. Yet, there were moments when he seemed to be completely at peace with himself. Like now, when he radiated not only peace, but a tranquillity which permeated me as well. I relaxed until the song ran down. He reached across me and switched the tape off.

'Well?' He turned to me.

'Getting pious in your old age, Naren?'

'Oh that song! That's different. Not piety, certainly.'

'Then what's in it for you?'

'Have you heard those words, Indu? I'm sure you've heard grandfather sing them many times. Listen, I'll sing it again to you.'

Unselfconsciously he began and I now realised that it was Naren himself I had heard earlier.

'"If it pleases you, oh Lord,"' he began, and how wooden the words sound in a foreign tongue, '"this dead stump will sprout again."'

'Got that?' He pointed an admonishing finger at me. 'And this ...'

'If it pleases you, oh Lord, poison can turn into nectar.'

'Well, Indu, how do you suppose one gets faith like that? Imagine really believing that ... and there's no

question at all, belief is here. Why can't we get it, Indu? Why can't I?"

'Because, my dear sir, we think. If we didn't . . .' I saw his face. He was dead serious. I tried again. 'Why are you after faith now, Naren?'

I did not know that then, at that moment, he was revealing to me something that he normally carefully hid from the world. If I had pursued that conversation then, I would have had so many clues in my hand. It was later, when we once again discussed our saints of old and their devotional songs . . . one of Naren's deep interests, as I had by then realised . . . it was then that I got a faint shadowy idea of what Naren was groping for.

'Strange you have nothing of Meera,' I had remarked on going through his collection.

'Meera,' his smile had been tender and amused. 'Listen to her words and you'll know that she was, more than anything else, a woman in love. For a woman in love, neither love nor faith in a loved one are too difficult of attainment.'

Are they, Naren?, I had thought sorrowfully. How little you know women.

But all that was much later. Now Naren sat up straight, picked a magazine off the table and swatted vigorously at a mosquito on my arm with it.

'Forget it,' he said and I could sense that he was offended. 'You know, Indu, I read some of your stories some years back. I like one of them immensely.'

'Which one?'

It was so long since someone had said that to me. Someone as genuine as Naren. But whose fault was that? How long since I had written something I liked myself?

'What was it called? I forget now. It was about a

child's who's disliked by her father. You know the one I mean.'

'Yes, I do. I sent it to four magazines who rejected it before it was accepted by the fifth. One of the editors even told me, I remember, that it was no story at all. A story, he instructed me, pompous ass that he was, should entertain, educate, or have a moral.'

'And is that why you've written nothing worthwhile since then?'

'Who has the time, Naren? It takes me anything from three months to three years maybe to write a story. Then I'm told it isn't acceptable. And, don't forget, I have a full time job as well.'

'Your magazine,' he said, suddenly lying down again, 'I don't like it. It has no soul.'

'Why not?'

'Is there anything it believes in?'

'Of course. In taking the line of least resistance and in increasing sales.'

'And knowing that, you're happy working there?'

'Why not? It's a job. Gets me so much money a month. What's wrong with that?'

'Nothing.'

And with deliberate nonchalance, he turned away from me. He would have turned to other topics, other arguments as well. But I would not let him. I had to talk about it, to justify myself.

'It's better than my previous job, anyway. Working in a women's magazine.'

'What was wrong with that?'

'Nothing, really. But everything. Women, women, women . . . I got sick of it. There was nothing else. It was a kind of narcissism. And as if we had locked our-

selves in a cage and thrown away the key. I couldn't go on. Better this than that.'

'I'd have thought it would have been better to write your own stuff,' he replied equably. But his eyes were not as mild as his voice. They provoked me though I had not come to quarrel with Naren.

'What the hell shall I write about, tell me, Naren? Women's lives and frustrations? Family life and domestic quarrels? Love with a capital L, and marriage as the ultimate happy ending? Or may be I'll get bolder and write of menstrual pains and the pangs of childbirth, the ecstasy of orgasm'

'Stop it, stop it,' Naren waved the magazine in front of my face as if fanning down my flames. I drew a deep breath. He looked at me silently for a moment, then asked, 'Want some water? There it is, on the table.'

I looked so doubtfully at the earthen jug that Naren added, 'Or do you drink boiled water?'

I glared at him, poured out a glassful and gulped it down.

'Come on, sit down,' he spoke soothingly as if to a child. I sat down near him. He picked up my hand and said softly, looking into my palm, 'Tell me, Indu, why do you fight against your womanhood so much?'

'Do I?'

My womanhood . . . I had never thought of it until the knowledge had been thrust brutally, gracelessly on me the day I had grown up.

'You're a woman now,' Kaki had told me. 'You can have babies yourself.'

I, a woman? My mind had flung off the thought with an amazing swiftness. I was only a child. And then, she had gone on to tell me, baldly, crudely, how

I could have a baby. And I, who had had all the child's unselfconsciousness about my own body, had, for the first time, felt an immense hatred for it.

'And don't forget,' she had ended, 'for four days now you are unclean. You can't touch anyone or anything.'

And that had been my introduction to the beautiful world of being a woman. I was unclean.

'Yes, you do. You know you do,' Naren spoke softly, still staring into my palm, as if he could see the essence of me there.

Yes, I did. If not, why would I write so often through the eyes of a man? Why had I been so pleased when a friend had told me, 'If I hadn't known it was you who had written that story, I'd have thought it was a man.'

Yes, it was true. I felt hedged in, limited by my sex. I resented my womanhood because it closed so many doors to me. Naren pulled me down so that I lay on the carpet beside him, his face close to mine, so close that I could not see him at all.

'Why do you deny the fact that you're a woman?' His voice had changed, it came from somewhere deep inside him and I felt a corresponding thickening in my own throat. This was a Naren I had never known.

'You can't deny this ...' he laid his hands lightly, teasingly on my breasts, 'or this ...' they moved downwards to my waist, my hips.

I gazed at him unflinchingly while he went on, '... and you can't prevent a man from wanting to do this, either' and moved his face, his lips towards mine. His face, his eyes they were all blotted out now. I lost all my senses, except one so magnified it was as if little nerve ends had sprung up all over my body. And I was, yes, responding to him with ardour and warmth when I realised who, it was.

'No, no,' I cried out angrily, trying to push him, still pinioned by his arms.

'Why not, Indu?'

His face moved away from mine, his arms released me. His eyes were hard now, almost opaque. I had seen him like this sometimes in childhood, fiercely exalted, unpredictable, perverse, terrifying. Yet not as terrifying as the stranger I had seen a few moments earlier.

'Why not, Indu? Are you such a faithful wife that even a kiss is taboo? Are you so pure?'

'Stop that,' I said harshly and pulled myself away from him. I stood up and he let me go. My sari came out of the petticoat it had been tucked into and cascaded down to the floor. We looked at it and both of us burst instantly into laughter. Mine had a touch of hysteria in it.

'Looks like the rape scene in a Hindi movie,' he grinned. 'I told you I was the big, bad villain, didn't I?'

'It isn't quite right,' I muttered, picking up my sari and making pleats in it. 'It should have been the choli.'

'What?'

'Villains in movies go for the choli,' I explained, tucking in my pleats. Thank God for synthetic material. Uncrushable. You can lie on the ground with a man and get up uncreased. Nothing shows.

'I'll be a villain any way I like,' he said and tugged lightly at my sari again, pulling out all the pleats I had made.

'Oh, don't be childish, Naren. Let me go.' I sat down in a temper, close to tears.

He ruffled my hair as if soothing me and said softly, 'I made a mistake. Next time, I'll loosen your hair. That's my weakness. A woman's hair spread all around her face. And mine.'

I laughed, my temper forgotten. 'And how often have you indulged that weakness of yours?'

'Not as often as I'd have liked to.' He seemed suddenly bored with the conversation, with me.

'You amaze me,' I said. 'I don't understand how you can enjoy that. Many women. I'm essentially monogamous. For me, it's one man and one man only.'

'That's how it is with you, is it, Indu?' He stared at me with the unabashed curiosity of a child. Who wanted merely to know. Not to judge.

'Yes.'

Why was I feeling so vulnerable? What had Naren done to my shell?

A breeze came in through the small uncurtained window set high up in the back wall, and with it the scent of the champak. No home here was complete without a champak tree in its garden. The large leaves hid the small golden flower completely, but the flower triumphantly made itself known by its fragrance. The air was redolent with it.

'Do you know that nursery rhyme, Naren? "Mary a little lamb", etc., etc.?'

'You forget, I haven't had your advantage of an English education. I'm one of the natives, educated in . . . what do they call it? . . . yes, the vernacular.'

Father, who had never shown much interest in me as an infant, had suddenly asserted himself when I was to go to school. 'She must go to an English school,' he had told Kaka. 'What if I decide to take her away from here? If she's studied in an English school she won't have trouble joining any school anywhere.'

Father had never claimed me at any time. All that he had achieved was setting me apart from the others.

'Please,' I now interrupted Naren impatiently, 'spare

me your complexes. Will you listen to me? You know the rhyme, don't you, in spite of your vernacular education? Everyone does. But do you know how it goes on?"

'No. Tell.'

I quoted the words to him in a sing-song manner like a child reciting a nursery rhyme.

"What makes the lamb love Mary so?"

The eager children cry.

"Oh, Mary loves the lamb you know,"

The teacher did reply.

Sounds simple, doesn't it? And logical. But, oh, how impossible! How improbable! And how untrue!"

"Then why did he marry you?" Naren scanned my face with no sympathy in his own.

'It's not that he doesn't care. It's more like... like... we're on different levels. You know the stage setting they have for some plays nowadays? It's like that. We're on different planes. He chooses his level. And I... I try to choose the one he would like me to be on. It humiliates me. And Naren, it was I who proposed to him,' I said dolefully.

At that Naren began to laugh. His whole body heaved with amusement.

'What's so funny about it?' I asked in asperity.

'Nothing. I was remembering you as a child. You haven't changed. Not much,' he added with pity. 'But what's wrong then, Indu?' he asked with a sudden change of tone.

'I don't know.' I put my head on my knees and stared at the carpet unseeingly. 'Nothing really, when I try to rationalise. But..... You know the word "deflowered" they use for girls, Naren? I thought of it when Jayant touched me for the first time. Because what I

felt was so much the reverse ... I felt as if my body had' I looked up at him and smiled. 'I remember I even thought of a good phrase. Or was it something I'd read somewhere? I don't know, but I told myself my body had "burgeoned into a flower of exquisite felicity".'

They speak of awkwardness, clumsiness and fumbling. It had not been so for us, Jayant and me. I had, for some time, loved Jayant. But between the idea and the reality there is an immeasurable distance. To see, to feel a real man was so far removed from the idea of love as it was to me then And yet, gradually the experience had fallen into place, into those slots of vague longings and definite aching emptiness that had once shamed me. And, now that fulfilment was possible, it seemed so natural. And perfect. But there was, even then, a small crack in the perfection. Jayant, so passionate, so ready, sitting up suddenly and saying, 'No, not now,' when I had taken the initiative. A crack then. A chasm now? But I drove away these thoughts. Naren who had been watching me silently, his eyes inscrutable, smiled wryly at me.

'And did you applaud yourself for finding that phrase?'

'And Naren,' I went on, ignoring his words, 'my response to him was so natural, so much beyond me and outside me ...' I stopped speaking, picking up strands of the frayed carpet. My throat, for some reason, hurt with a pricking pain. '.... And he ... he was shocked.'

I looked straight at Naren and some tears that I had not known were brimming in my eyes, split over straight on to the ground.

'And now I know ... it shocks him to find passion in

a woman. It puts him off. When I'm like that, he turns away from me. I've learnt my lesson now. And so I pretend. I'm passive. And unresponsive. I'm still and dead. And now, when you tried to kiss me, I thought ... this is Jayant. So that's all I am, Naren. Not a pure woman. Not a too faithful wife. But an anachronism. A woman who loves her husband too much. Too passionately. And is ashamed of it.'

I was sitting on the floor, my dishevelled sari spread all around me, my hands on my lap, not bothering to wipe my tears. It was Naren who wiped them for me.

'What's there about him, Indu?'

'I don't know, Naren. I wish I did. A man like any other. Many others. And I was so proud of my logical and rational thinking. But there, my trap was waiting for me after all.'

Someone had begun an angry monologue outside. It was a woman's voice, ugly in anger. Pots and pans were clanged together noisily. A child raised a voice in a sudden loud wail and it was hushed just as suddenly. People we did not know surrounded us, Naren and me, with fragments of their domesticity.

Naren leaned back against the wall and fished a cigarette out of his pocket.

'Throw me the matches, Indu. Behind you. One for you? You don't smoke? All the Indian woman's virtues, eh? You're lucky. But, speaking of traps, Indu,' he lit his cigarette and drew in a whiff of smoke, 'did I tell you I almost fell into one myself? And you know what it was? Give you three guesses.'

'You know I never was one for these guessing games.'

'Altruism. The one truly altruistic gesture I made in my life. You know what it was? Oh, sorry, sorry. I'll tell you. I offered to marry Mini.'

'What!' I was utterly flabbergasted. Seeing my face, Naren began to laugh, then choked and coughed.

'The truth,' he said when he could speak. 'I really felt sorry for her ... the way they were desperately parading her before every eligible man. And then, being refused for one reason or another. So I said to Kaka, "I don't mind marrying her."'

'And what did Kaka say?'

'Kaka? He likes me. But what say does he have? As for Kaki ... she's never liked me. She eyes me dubiously. You know, Indu, we Hindus tell ourselves we're the most tolerant people in the world. But if you ask me, our tolerance is reserved for outsiders. Within the fold, there's no place for deviation, for the misfit. I'm 33 now ... or is it 32? ... and not yet married. And so I must be, in some way odd. That was Kaki's view. But, actually, she didn't count either. It was Akka.'

'What about her?'

'She asked me, "How much do you want?" I ask you ... the one truly altruistic gesture in my life! And the old witch says, "How much?"'

'And what was your reply?' I asked him eagerly. I thought it was a fascinating story, a fascinating episode, each person acting incredibly true to type.

He shrugged. "'I don't think I'll be much of a burden on you", I told her. "My needs are simple. Two sets of clothes. Two meals a day. Apart from tea and cigarettes, I'm quite cheap to maintain, really. Unlike the other son-in-law of the family ... Sunanda's husband."'

'Really, Naren!' I spluttered with laughter. 'You were Akka's torment, I think.'

'On the contrary, she enjoyed me. I was hoping she'd

leave me all her money. But you beat me to it, you opportunistic, mercenary young woman.'

'So you know about it,' I said dully.

'Of course. What do you take me for? I keep abreast with the news.'

He got off the floor, crushed his unfinished cigarette in a dirty saucer, and going to the bed, sat cross-legged on it.

'Why are you so aggressive about it?' I flung at him peevishly.

'Aggressive? Why not? I'm accusing you. You leave home swearing eternal enmity against the old woman. And she hates you too. And then you come home after ten years and suddenly she dies, leaving you all her property. Come on, Indu, come clean. What did you do? Undue influence? Poison?'

'I wish I had poisoned her,' I said viciously. 'I'm sure she knew what she was letting me in for.'

'And what has she let you in for?'

'You know, Naren, I can almost understand Akka now. I mean, when they cringe and fawn and talk like they do, I feel I could rub their noses in the dust. And it's a wonderful feeling, holding all the answers in my hand. Will Mini get married? Will Sharad become a doctor? Will Sunil go into business? Will Vasant-kaka get his partnership? Will Sumant get his flat? Will Vinayak-kaka buy that house? Will Kaka have his heart broken? Ask Indu. Only Indu knows all the answers to all these questions.'

'Is that all?' Naren asked me placidly as I came, breathlessly, to the end.

'No.' My voice was harsh. 'There's us. Jayant and I. Will we get our bungalow in the suburbs? Will we go abroad? Or will we,' and now Naren looked at me in

alarm, 'do that thing we could never afford so far ... have a child?'

'And what does Indu say to that? Throw me a cigarette, Indu. And the matches. So that leaves out only grandfather and me, does it? Tch, tch, surely we must do better than that. Grandfather could never bear my being beaten by any of your family. I must think of something.

'What do I want, Indu?'

I shrugged. 'You should know.'

'Maybe it's you. You, with all that money thrown in. Why go after the eggs? I'll settle for the golden goose itself. Sorry to call you a goose, Indu. But, don't you think it's a splendid idea? Why didn't I think of it before? Imagine getting you, all that money, and seeing the family turn green. No, not green. Black, with hatred. But I told you I was the big bad villiain, didn't I?'

'Oh, don't be an idiot, Naren,' I said crossly. When he wanted to be exasperating, there was no stopping him. 'I have enough nonsense to listen to without your joining in.'

'Who says it's nonsense? Take me seriously, young woman. I have my eye on you. By the way,' he went on with a sudden switch of subject that was so typically Naren, 'what was that about Kaka's heart breaking? Why should it break?'

'What an egotist you are, Naren!'

'Me, an egotist! I like that! Who was it who wrote a poem called ... now, what was it? ... wait, wait, I'll get it in a moment. Whitman, yes, you were reading Whitman. And you called it, little plagiarist that you were, in addition to being an egotist A Song of Myself. Now, how did it go? It was full of capital

letters, I remember. And the words were the words, the words . . .’ He clicked his fingers in impatience.

‘Wait,’ I forestalled him. ‘I’ll tell you. I can remember a bit of it.

“The Sun sets in a Fiery Orange Glow

All for me

The Clouds pile up in Dark something Abandon

All for me

The Rain falls in Straight Silken Sheets

All for me”

I can’t remember any more.’

Naren chuckled. ‘The most glorious egotism, eh, Indu?’

‘Or the most superb self confidence?’ I grinned back. ‘Where has it all gone? But what a wretch you are, Naren. You have a memory for the most inconvenient things. Haven’t you stored up any nice memories of me? As to why I called you an egotist, it’s because you are so involved with your own dear self, you know nothing of what’s going on with others. Don’t you know it’s quite likely the house will be sold?’

‘What house? Whose house?’

‘Kaka’s house. Our house. Kaka was telling me about it. He has been finding it difficult maintaining the house. And the others refuse to help. They say, “We don’t live there, why should we help?” And now Akka, who used to contribute, has gone. And there’s a good offer for the house. Everyone is eager to sell and get his or her share of the pound of flesh. Everyone, except Kaka, who’s breaking his heart over it. And wherever I go, I can feel his eyes wistfully following me. And I know what he’s thinking. He wants me to help him out.’

‘And are you going to be damn fool enough to do it?’ Naren interrupted me harshly.

That was one of the times when I hated Naren.

On the way back I wondered ... the same telegraph wires, humming the same tune. The same trees, with the same crows cawing their silly souls, if they had any, out. And yet it all looked different. The change was in me. Suddenly I understood all those poets and writers who had gushed about the grass being greener, the sky bluer, and the flowers more beautiful ... all because of love.

But that didn't apply to me. It was not *that* disease that was incubating inside me. And anyway, love, that's a word I don't really understand. It seems to me an overworked word, overburdened by the weight we put upon it. I love a book, a word, a sari, a curry, a dog, a child, a man. God, how hopelessly inefficient to use the same word for such different emotions, such varied reactions. Why, it had even been used to me once by an anonymous voice on the telephone, that had then gone on to more explicit obscenities.

What I feel for Jayant ... can I compress all of it within this word? It is so much more, so overwhelming a response of the whole of me to him. Sometimes I wonder if I will leave him one day and live by myself. The only way in which I can be myself, my whole self again. I have often toyed with the idea. I even worked it out into a short story once, in which a young woman leaves her husband and goes away. And when a third person, a common friend, asks her why, she says, 'Because I love him too much.' And the friend, not understanding, goes away thinking her ... what? Crazy? Stupid? Deceitful? I could never get the ending and left it alone. But how many would understand what I was trying to say? Naren, perhaps. He would understand. If not, why did he avoid Old Uncle so resolutely?

And now, at least, it came back to me, how I had felt when Naren had touched me. And how Naren had looked when I had rejected him. And I thought of Jayant and how vulnerable he was. I could shatter him with withdrawal. And so, I had to pretend, to cover my reactions, act out a pleasant willingness that grated on me. With Naren, I would never have to pretend. He would not be affected by my rejection. But this very hardness of his, this very not-caring ... this was not what I wanted. I wanted involvement, not detachment. And still, when Naren had touched me, I had felt as if I had found out one more piece of the jigsaw puzzle. And where would that take me?

As I reached home, two figures detached themselves from the fragrant bush of the night queen. One of them said, 'Indu? Where were you all this while?'

It was Sumitra-kaki's Lata. And Mini was with her. 'Everyone's been hunting high and low for you. No one had seen you. No one knew where you'd gone'

Mini was crushing a tulsi leaf in her hands. As she came close, the aroma of the crushed tulsi came with her.

'Where were you, Indu?' she asked.

'I'd gone to see Naren.'

'Naren!' It was as if I'd said a bad word. But that was Lata, not Mini. And it was Mini whom I asked, 'Who wants me and why?'

'Shyamrao was here. And Shankarappa. And Kaka and Madhavkaka wanted you.'

'Oh!'

'But Shyamrao is coming tomorrow afternoon. And he wants you to be home'

'You will be home, won't you? They can't do without you. And surely Naren can ...'

'So young,' I said. 'And so false.'

'What?'

'Nothing.' I looked at Lata's face. In the twilight, it looked soft and gentle.

'Indu,' Mini's voice broke in, 'you know you missed your evening tea? Mother was saying ...'

'I know. "She needn't think she can have tea any time she wants." But Mini, I want it now. And you will make some for me, won't you?'

There was a tiny pause. Then she said, 'All right.' And went in. As I followed her I thought ... There! I can do it too. It isn't very difficult, is it? See, Akka, I can play your game as well. Domination it comes easy once you know the way.

6

Going upstairs to the library, I was surprised by the reluctance that I found within myself to enter. Over my cup of tea yesterday, Mini had told me everything I wanted to know about what was to happen today. 'They want to settle all the money matters. And about the property as well. I think they're going to have a partition. And they want to know what you're going to do with Akka's money.'

She had said all this in the manner of a detached observer. Which astonished me when I knew that her wedding was one of the things hanging in the balance.

There was a subdued buzz of voices within the library. Family conclaves . . . they had been part of my childhood. Summer vacations, when the family gathered together, had invariably had one such conference. As a child, however, I had been remote from it, both physically and mentally. Though, even then, there had been something in me that had thrilled to the drama of it all . . . the atmosphere of secrecy and exclusion, the raised voices behind closed doors, the whispered hissing of women in dark corners. And now, I was participating in one myself. I had an odd sense of being an interloper, a child who had sneaked into a forbidden place. As if someone would, at any moment, turn round, discover me and say . . . What are you doing here? Out you go!

But if my presence was incongruous, there was someone else with us, whose being there was even more strange. Father, who had, to Akka's disgust and displeasure, all his life fought shy of such occasions, was one of us. 'You can't avoid being one of the family,' Akka had once angrily declared.

'No, I can't,' he had replied with composure. 'But there are things I can avoid. And I intend doing so as long as I can.' Why was he here now? He had arrived unexpectedly last night with the most superb nonchalance, though it was well past midnight. As usual, he had given no explanation of his arriving at that odd time, or of his being with us at all. Nor had he excused himself for not coming earlier. To me he had said, 'I met Jayant last week.'

'And how is he?'

'Oh, wonderful, wonderful, wonderful.'

I could have murdered him for his air of cheerful candour as he sat there on the mattress on the floor, his feet

tucked under him, having a last smoke before going to bed. But he seemed as unconscious of my mute response of anger as he had been earlier of the trouble Kaki and Atya had had on his arriving at such an odd time. They had run around in circles, getting him a meal, hot water for a bath, making up a bed for him. Yet what had I expected to hear? That Jayant was pining for me? It is confusing when you can be rational about your own irrational feelings.

The large hall had always been dignified by the name of 'the library', though there was nothing more than one large cupboard with a peculiar hotch potch of books . . . mostly paperbacks bought by various people to while away railway journeys . . . to justify the name. I had never seen anyone reading or writing in this room at any time. But then, how many people in the family read anything at all, apart from the daily newspaper and a magazine or two? Father, who had been examining the books in the cupboard intently as if he had never seen them before, now shut the door with a large creak which made all the others turn to him in irritation, and came to me with a smile, saying, 'You know, Indu, when we were kids, this was the room of terror. When Father called us here, we knew we were in for it. God, how scared we used to be! I forget now whether it was Madhav or Vinayak who once wet his pants'

'Sssh, Father, you're disgusting,' I said sternly, trying to curb my smile. 'And do be serious.'

Immediately, like a chastened child, Father smoothened his features into a sedate gravity and looked intently around him. Only the men of the family were there. Even Akka in her heyday had been excluded. As the arguments went on, I realised the wisdom of

excluding the women. There was anger, bitterness, even rancour, but the discussion did not trail away into the sidelines of personal issues. Nor were — let me mix my metaphors — dead horses flogged too often.

Nothing uncharitable was said to me, either. Except once, when Sunil, unable to control himself, burst out with 'I think it's damned unfair. Why should all of Akka's money go to Indu? We have as much right to a share as she has, if not more. She has no right at all, if you ask me. She isn't part of the family now, is she?' I looked at Sunil in surprise and approbation (I preferred this to the hurtful innuendoes) while Sharad clapped his hands and said softly, but not as mockingly as he would have liked to seem, 'Hear, hear.'

Immediately both Kaka and Madhav-kaka turned upon their respective sons.

'Stop fooling, Sharad, must you always play the fool?'

'Sunil, you have no right to say such things. Keep out.'

'Yes, but he's right, isn't he?' Vasant-kaka gave me a placating smile, as if eager to emphasise that this did not mean that he bore me any animosity. 'Not that I dispute the fact that women should have a share now. But to give everything to one person does seem unfair.'

'As a matter of fact,' this was Vinayak-kaka, 'it's so unlike Akka, I'm wondering whether she was in her right mind. She had been sick for some time. Who knows how that affected her mental balance? What do you say, Anna?'

Kaka put his cap down beside him ... he was wearing it as if in recognition of the importance of the occasion ... and scratched his head vigorously. He shrug-

ged. 'I don't know. I'm not a doctor. But to me she seemed the same as she always was.'

'The same malicious, trouble-loving, trouble-creating, old woman.'

Kaka turned to Hemant with an angry flush on his face. 'Let's not start calling the dead names now.'

Father, I noticed, was looking from face to face with the frank ingenuousness of a child enjoying a grown-ups' quarrel. When and where did you achieve this poise, Father? Tell me the secret. I know what they want me to say. Let's share it, they expect me to declare I don't want all of it. It's not fair. And it is not fair. Akka has played a dirty trick on all of us. Or, has she? Shyamrao, who had been silent till now, broke in.

"If you're thinking of contesting the will on such grounds, Vinayak, let me tell you, you've no chance. No chance at all. Akka was very much in her right mind. I can vouch for that. It's all Indu's. No question about that at all. If she gives anything to anyone, I'd call it generosity. Not fair, or just, or anything like that.'

There was a silence as everyone swallowed the unpalatable fact. It was Father who broke it by turning to me, a dazed look on his face. 'Why, Indu, I never thought of that. It's all yours now. Akka's money and property. Why, you're a rich woman.'

I put my face down on my knees and choked with hysterical laughter. No one else laughed. They watched in a stony silence as Father patted me ineffectually, too vigorously, making me choke again. I looked up to see Madhav-kaka saying, 'Here, drink this.'

I drank the water and recovered my composure, while Madhav-kaka went on speaking.

'Let's stick to the point. All this is a sheer waste of

time. What's done is done. We won't discuss that any more. Shyamrao tells us that what Akka had done stands. Okay, we take his word for it and leave it alone. Now, let's go on to the next thing.' Thank god for civil servants. Agendas and files and minutes ... they all have their places in the pattern of life.

'... And before I do, let me make my own stand clear. I think Akka has been unfair, specially to Anna. He's the most affected. She knew how he was situated. She had promised to finance Padmini's marriage. And now this. Now it all rests with Indu. Padmini's marriage can take place only if Indu keeps Akka's promise. We've got to find out whether she will. And this house. Anna can't really afford to maintain this place. Akka was helping him. Now, who will? I can't. I have my own family to think of. I have two daughters to be married. Same with the others, I should imagine. So what?'

'I told you about Shankarappa's offer,' Shyamrao began when Kaka turned fiercely on him.

'Shyamrao, not that again. I told you not to speak of it. Never to speak of it. And how you can lower yourself to speak to that fellow ...! I kicked him out of here. What, that fellow whose bottom was always peeping out of his torn shorts whose father didn't have the guts to enter our house ... but he knew his place, unlike his son ... How dare that fellow talk of buying our house?'

It was magnificent, it was like a thunderbolt, a bolt from the blue, an electric shock ... anything surprising, stunning, unreasonable, irrational ... was Kaka's savage vehemence. But Shyamrao was unaffected by it.

'Look, Anant,' he spoke calmly, 'forget the past. You can't live in the past. You have to live in the present.

And in this present, Shankarappa isn't a dirty kid wearing torn shorts any more, but a respectable, moneyed man with a flourishing business and the prospect of becoming our next MLA. And he's made, I must say, in spite of your abominable rudeness to him, a very good offer.'

'Yes, it is a good offer.' Madhav-kaka agreed.

'We should snap it up. What are we waiting for?' Sumant asked.

'Yes, yes, I know. Snap it up. Snap it up.' Kaka glared about him. 'Sell it to him. Let him demolish the house. What do we care about as long as we get our share of the money? And what about us old people? What are we supposed to do? Lie down by the roadside and die? Or will someone put us in the cattle pound? Or sell us to the butchers? Who cares? Yes, sell it, sell it.'

While all of us stared at him aghast, Kaka buried his face in his dhoti and gave a fierce honk.

'Who's Shankarappa? And what's all this about selling the house? Will no one tell me?'

For once I blessed Father's naivete. While Shyamrao told Father all about it in his flat, unemotional tone, Kaka recovered himself. He cleared his throat and looked about him in a shame-faced manner. As he caught my eye, he gave me an abashed smile. But I didn't respond. I couldn't. For the first time, I had realised something. I looked at the long narrow room, with its polished floor, its arched windows through which the sunlight streamed in. I saw, as if for the first time, the niches in the walls full of odds and ends, the pegs on the wall on which the men had once hung their turbans and now their caps and coats and folded dhotis. Demolished. It would cease to exist.

Would it? The wall would crumble, the roof would crash down. The woodwork would be neatly piled up in lorries and carried away. But what of the feelings, the emotions, the passions the house had sheltered? Would they not linger here, where they had had their birth, their life? If not, where would they go? I had been a fifteen-days-old motherless infant when I had been brought into this house. I had lived 18 years in it. Now, all these 18 years compressed themselves into one moment of painful intensity and I lived those 18 years all over again.

The enchantment of waking up in the morning to various sounds that somehow formed a harmonious whole. Birds chirping in the windows. A child crying. (Sometimes the child was me.) The Primus hissing. The tinkle of cups and saucers. Akka singing. And then, the magic of the evening hours, when the first lamp was lit for the gods. The lights gently twinkling in all the rooms. Women sitting at ease for the first time in the day, stretching out their aching legs in front of them. Story-telling-time . . . children lying with heads pillowed on warm laps, listening with a drowsy intentness, when the whole didn't matter, but each word was significant and meaningful. Men returning home, shedding their slippers, washing their feet, and settling down with large contented sighs. The feeling of ease, content and indolence embracing the whole house. And the huge front door, which no child could ever push the whole way, standing wide open the whole day, so that people just walked in and became part of the family. A feeling of welcome that didn't have to be said in words, smiles, dinners and drinks. This was home. Where one lived. Not stayed.

And suddenly I was back in the present, surrounded by the buzz of angry voices.

'It's our home. Grandfather built it. Can't we make some sacrifices for it?'

'Are you prepared to make the sacrifice?'

'Yes, as much as I can. But how much can one person do?'

'It's easy for you. You have no responsibilities. Let me be frank. I can't spare anything.'

'And why not sell the house when we can get a good price for it?'

'I agree. Its foolishness to miss this chance.'

'Yes, yes, I'm a foolish old man. Put me in an asylum and do what you want.'

It was Madhav-kaka's voice that finally pierced through my stupor.

'Well, Indu, why are you so silent? You're the most important person here. We're all waiting for your decision. You must tell us what it is.'

I looked at them all . . . Madhav-kaka faintly mocking, Vinayak-kaka hostile, Kaka trying hard to keep the appeal out of his eyes, Father troubled and anxious for me. What could I say? 'What can I do?' I turned in relief to Shyamrao, whose face was blank and impersonal. 'Can I buy the house myself? And maintain it as well?'

'You could.' He looked doubtfully at me. 'But if you did, you would have to pay at least what Shankarappa is offering. Which means . . . yes, I doubt if you could finance Padmini's marriage as well.'

'Mini's marriage . . . that's settled, is it? You're all agreed that Mini should marry that man?'

'Why not?' Vinayak-kaka gave me an owlish look through his glasses.

'Yes, why not? The perfect couple. So say the horoscopes.'

'No.' It was Madhav-kaka. 'Not perfect. But what couple could be perfectly matched? Tell me, Indu ... you choose your own husband. Are you a made-for-each-other couple?' He enunciated the words as if making a burlesque of them, making them sound what they were ... ridiculous.

But I ... I could not speak. If only I had the talons of a bird, the claws of a tiger, the poison of a cobra

'Madhav,' Father put his hand on mine, 'you know what Indu really means.'

'And what does she mean? Tell me, Indu?'

All heads swivelled to me. I had to gain control over myself. I couldn't show the cracks in my armour. I had to speak. Show no weakness ... wasn't that how Akka had ruled? But did I need Akka's methods?

'You people ... you've thought of everything ... the families, the communities, the stars, the gotras, everything'

'Yes, is that wrong, Indu?' Madhav-kaka interrupted me. 'Marriage itself is a difficult enough business. For two people to merge into one identity, it's ... almost an impossibility. But given certain things in common ... language, customs, rituals background ... all this makes it easier.'

' $2 + 2$ makes 4.'

'Yes, $2 + 2$ does make 4. I don't know why you intellectuals,' he smiled and I thought ... I wouldn't like to be his subordinate, 'disdain that equation.'

They were all watching us as if it was a duel.

'Oh, that equation is fine for Maths. But not for humans, Madhav-kaka. You're leaving out that great incalculable ... human emotions.'

'And where do they take us? But I won't argue with you. You can,' he grinned at me, 'have the last word if you want to. The right person for you to argue with is Anna . . . Mini's father.'

'Kaka,' I turned round to him, 'why don't you marry Mini to Naren?'

'Naren!' It was an explosive sound from Old Uncle who hadn't opened his mouth till now. He stared at me for a full moment and said it again, 'Naren?' This time it was a question.

'Yes, why not?' I stared back at him unsmilingly. And then went back to Kaka. 'He had once offered to marry Mini, hadn't he? And it was Akka who had refused. Well, there's no Akka now. No one to say "No". So, what about it? He won't ask you for money. The marriage ceremony needn't cost you much, either.'

'Indu . . .' Old Uncle got to his feet, his hands shaking as he tried to find his glasses.

'Yes, Old Uncle?'

'Come with me. Come out. At once.'

'All right.'

We walked out of a silent room. I closed the door gently behind us and smiled at Old Uncle. 'What are you up to now?'

'Come to my room, Indu. I want to talk to you.'

For the umpteenth time since my return, I felt a child again as I walked with him through the paved courtyard, past the mango trees, the drumstick tree and the curry leaf tree to Old Uncle's room. He drew back the bolt with a screeching sound.

'I must oil this,' he muttered. I smiled. He had been saying this ever since I could remember.

Unlike the main house, it was hot inside here. The tiled roof caught the heat and spread it over us like a

warm blanket. I threw open the windows. A dragonfly flew straight at me, perched momentarily on a window bar with all the grace and rigidity of a ballet dancer, and then flew away again, straight and purposeful. A crow cawed harshly. 'Sssh, go away,' Old Uncle waved his hands at the bird and clapped feebly at it. The crow ... an inauspicious bird. The crow nonchalantly flew away.

'Sit down, Indu. Sit down.'

He moved round with the nervous fussiness of the old, with wasteful, unnecessary gestures as he removed his shirt, his cap, put away his glasses and tidied the bed for me to sit on. I sat on the bed, my feet drawn up under me and stared into the calm confident face of Swami Vivekananda. The large photograph of the Swami in his usual heroic pose provided a backdrop for Old Uncle's collection of gods.

'Old Uncle,' I said suddenly, 'Is it because of him...?' I pointed to the Swami, 'that you chose Naren's name?'

'Of course. Didn't you know?'

'He looks as if he's found all the answers,' I said wryly.

'Who? Naren?' Old Uncle gave a startled look. I shook my head. 'Oh, you mean the Swami. But Naren thinks he has all the answers too. Rather, he thinks you don't need any answers at all. Tell me, Indu, who are your heroes? I don't mean you personally. But all of you. Your generation. We had Tagore and Gandhi, Vivekananda, Aurobindo ... and so many more. Who are yours?'

He looked eagerly into my face. I moved against the wall and leant on it, making place for Old Uncle to sit beside me.

'We don't have any nowadays. It's the day of the anti-hero, don't you know?'

'That's bad. That's bad. Better to have some, never mind who. Even those terrible people Sharad is always reading about and talking about. Those stars. What terrible muck is written about them, Indu. And youngsters like Sharad read and believe every word.'

I sat straight up. 'And how do you know what muck is written about them?'

He gave me a shame-faced grin. 'I've just glanced though one or two of Sharad's magazines. Occasionally. It's ... it's ... really beyond me how people can want to read all that rubbish. Even the language is mixed garbage. It's quite incomprehensible.'

Remembering Old Uncle's chaste reading habits, I laughed out loud at the thought of him reading the gossip film magazines.

'Serves you right for trying to read them. Or were you really enjoying looking at those big busted female stars?'

Old Uncle suddenly chuckled. 'Have you been to Madhav's house, Indu? Have you seen that boy Sunil's room?'

'Have you?' I asked in sudden suspicion. 'Have you been there?'

He understood me perfectly. 'I? No, not I. Do you think I'd go there and not visit you?' he asked me in a gentle reproach. 'I heard of it from Anant. He told me the boy's room was full of pictures of these women. All of them so .. so ...' he groped for the right word.

'Say breasty, Old Uncle,' I prompted. 'One can't put that delicately.'

'Yes, well, well, well. Anyway, Anant said it was like being in a cowshed before milking time.'

I chortled. 'Kaka in Sumitra-kaki's flat! That's certainly an odd situation.'

Old Uncle grinned his toothless smile that gave him a marked resemblance to Gandhi.

'You should hear his stories some time, Indu. I believe the poor fellow used to remove his slippers as soon as he entered the flat. You know, like we do here. And he used to leave them in the drawing room. You've seen Anant's chappals, haven't you?'

Old Uncle chuckled again. I smiled sympathetically. Kaka's chappals were a family joke. Also an institution. There was only one cobbler in town who could make them to Kaka's satisfaction, both strong and cheap. It was also part of the contract that if they gave way within a year, the cobbler had to provide free repairs. Add to this the fact that Kaka had extra giant-sized feet... and one had to smile at the thought of those chappals in Sumitra-kaki's drawing room.

'And naturally Madhav's wife didn't want those disgraceful objects in her spick and span drawing room. So, whenever he left them there, she would whisk them out of sight. And Anant had to go and ask her for them each time he wanted to go out. And once, as she was having a bath, he went out just as he was, in his bare feet. And came back to find her entertaining some very sophisticated ladies. Anant tells me you should have seen them staring at his bare feet. Their midriffs were bare and their navels showing... but they behaved as if showing bare feet was a disgrace. And those white sheets on the bed, he says, used to frighten him so much, he had to remove them before going to bed. "I just had to touch them," he told me "for them to become dirty." No, Indu, he belongs here in this place. Like me. And Narmada. We don't fit in anywhere else.'

And I... I have turned about and made myself comfortable here now. But that's only for a time. This is an interlude. I don't really belong here any more. And yet I don't fit into the world I have left behind me, either. Where then do I belong?

'And yet, there's no place for Naren here,' I interrupted Old Uncle.

He shot me a wary glance. Then his head dropped down. 'No, there isn't. But that's my failure, Indu. It's I who have made him that way, so that he doesn't fit in anywhere.'

Self flagellation... you wonder how they can do it. But they do. That beggar on our road in Bombay... one who scourges himself by making deep cuts on both legs with a blade. And the blood flows copiously. A little later he appears with both legs neatly bandaged. And when the cuts heal, he does it all over again. And you wonder... why does he do it?

'Why doesn't he stay here, Old Uncle?'

He shrugged. 'Who knows? He doesn't tell me. I've never asked him, actually, because I know he won't tell me. That's one of the worst things about getting old. People treat you like an idiot. They tell you nothing.'

I began to laugh. 'Why, Old Uncle, you sound like old James Forsyte. And yet, you know you've been a father confessor to most of us. To me, anyway. You shouldn't complain.'

Old Uncle beamed at me approvingly. 'James Forsyte? Yes, I did sound like him then, didn't I? So you read it after all, eh, Indu? I remember your telling me when I asked you to read it that it was too dull. That's a family, isn't it, Indu? The Forsytes. How well that man has described it.'

'Old Uncle,' I said firmly and loudly as if he had suddenly gone deaf, 'what do you think of this idea of Naren and Mini? Isn't that what you wanted to talk about? Isn't that why you brought me here?' It was as if he drew a curtain over his face.

'What do I think?' He grimaced. 'And what does it matter what I think? Do you think Naren cares about what I think? But Indu, you're wrong if you think he really meant it last time. It was only his way of getting back at the family. He hates it, God knows why. How could I say this there, Indu, in front of all of them? But I must warn you ... don't take Naren seriously. He ... I wonder sometimes if he's serious about anything at all!'

Old Uncle looked like a cartoon of a miserable man, lips dragged down, chin drooping. 'When I told him about the house being sold, he said, "Let it be." And when I said, "What about the family?" he said, "Yes, what about the family?"'

'Yes, what about it, Old Uncle? I'm asking you now.'

His lips tightened in a grim line. His eyes lit up as if someone had lighted a candle in them. But his hands shook. So did his chin. He was too old, really, for this kind of a temper.

'The same thing, the same question! What do you think of, Indu? Nothing but your own selves? What does this matter and what does that matter? But when I ask you what really matters, you can't give me a reply. The family ... it's all right to sneer at it. But tell me, what have you got to put in its place? What will you have in its stead? It gives us a background, an anchor, something to hold on to ...' His whole body shook in his agitation.

'Old Uncle,' I spoke soothingly, 'I don't deny the

family. But this ... this large amorphous group of people with conflicting interests ... a family like ours now ... it has no meaning. Didn't you see them today? Didn't you hear them today?"

He got up from the bed and began to walk up and down that small room in which he had spent nearly half his life, with short jerky steps.

"Then, what's a family, Indu? A husband, wife and children? But what when the children grow up and go away, as they are bound to do? Is it only a husband and wife? But that too need not last for ever? It's easy enough now to dissolve that tie? So, what's left? An individual? Is that what we should live for ... one's own self?"

"Isn't that the ultimate truth? That's what really matters ... one's own self."

He looked at me in amazement and sat down as suddenly as if I had pulled out his legs from under him.

"If you really believe that, I'm sorry for you, Indu. But tell me, what do you really believe in?"

"You mean, Old Uncle?"

I couldn't be angry with Old Uncle. He meant too much to me. He had been too many things to me.

"People had different things at different times. Things to believe in. There was the tribe, the clan, the community, the family. Since people began to think, there have been so many 'isms' as well. For us, it was patriotism. Now, what have you got, child? Do you believe only in success? One must earn so much, spend so much ... is that all that matters? Tell me, Indu, what do you want?"

I knew the question was not personal. And yet, it hit me like a blow in my middle. What did I want? Success at first. It was impossible, unimaginable for me not

to succeed. Not to have been the best would have been unbearable. And suddenly one day, self consciousness had set in. And doubts. Doubts ... they castrate you. (Query ... can a woman speak of being castrated?) They destroy your self-confidence. And there's always a why for whatever you do. So that the doing of it, the succeeding in it, is not enough. And so, I had found myself on the verge of a complete bankruptcy. What I had was nothing. What I had to have, I did not know.

And at times, there was in me, a sense, not of futility, but of utter vacuity. So that all the things we did, all the things that had loomed so large, so important in our life, became ridiculous and unreal. I felt foolish, as if all that we were doing were the senseless antics of foolish children. That we could be brave and bold and assured because the lights were on and we could hear our parents in the next room. But soon the lights would go off, the voices fade out and our games would become what? Nothingness in the midst of nothingness.

It was not mysticism either, that led my thoughts this way, for I could not believe in the other world. How could I, when this world itself ... this one I could see, hear and touch ... seemed so unreal?

But these were moments, moods I would overcome. For a time. And then, they would return again and again and again. Destroying my certainty, my confidence, my assurance. And I could say nothing of this to Jayant, for he would call it all nonsense. And his rejoinder, his comfort would be those three words, which for him, solved all our problems, 'Don't be silly.' Now, what could I say to Old Uncle?

'I don't know, Old Uncle' I said, as angry as him now. 'I don't know what I want.'

In a flash, his anger was replaced by concern. He peered anxiously into my face as if I was the child who had come to him with her problems and hurts. At what age had I grown away from him? When had I started looking on him as a harmless, but feeble old man?

'Why, Indu, what is it? Tell me, child, are you happy?' That question again.

'Happy?' My face felt heavy and rigid as I tried to smile. 'Have you ever heard the word being used in the present tense?'

He patted my hand gently, still gazing into my face. 'Marriage ... it has been good for you?'

I felt my face flush, become hot. 'If you mean, is it the right person for me, yes, it is. But marriage ... it makes one so dependent. I don't know about men, but' my voice trailed away.

'But that's unavoidable, Indu. Inevitable, rather. Why, the whole world is ... where did I read this? Huxley, I think. That the whole world is made up of interdependent parts. So why not you?'

To give all of yourself, to expect nothing in return ... how many of us can do that? Meera ... if there had been psychoanalysis then, wouldn't they have psychoanalysed her, cut out her obsession, rooted it out of her? Faith, love, devotion ... do they always have to be unbalanced, obsessive, unreasonable?

Meanwhile Old Uncle was going on chattily, happily forgetting my problem.

'And you know, Indu, he also says that if all the bacteria in the world were to die, the rest of life would be unable to exist. The thought excited me when I first read it. There's meaning in it for me. For all of us.' He saw my face.

'But I'm boring you, Indu. What were we talking about? What was I saying?'

Why grudge him his happy amnesia? 'I don't remember.'

Old Uncle sighed heavily. 'I don't understand you children. To me, life seems simple. You work, you earn a living, you have a family, you look after them, you are cared for ... and what more can one want? But you And look at Naren. He counts me out completely.'

His eyes suddenly filled with tears. It frightened me. I got up and moved towards him. 'Please, Old Uncle.'

Briskly he lifted the end of his dhoti and wiped his eyes. 'Don't worry, Indu. Tears come as easily to the old as they do to children. They mean nothing.'

Nothing?

'Sometimes I hope I never have a child.'

He let his dhoti fall and stared at me in consternation. 'Why?'

'To care for anyone too much ... it's all pain. A punishment.'

Now it was he who was comforting me. 'That's not right, Indu. That's the coward's way. Attachment ... we can't escape it. It's the law of life. You can never protect yourself against love.'

Never? What a frightening thought! And what then of my dream, my ideal of detachment? I don't know why, but my mind keeps harping on this theme of detachment and loneliness. Will I never reach that stage ... no passions, no emotions, an unruffled placidity? My recurring daydream, into which I retreat at times of stress ... me, lying in bed, wearing glasses and reading, tranquil, detached, unshakeable.

'So you would rather suffer for Naren?' I asked cruelly.

'Is there any choice?' His shoulders dropped. 'And maybe, it's all my fault. I spoilt him, I know. Never forced him to do anything he didn't want to. Now, he's incapable of living by any rules. It's as if he has no ballast. Gives up good jobs for no reason at all. Wastes his time doing nothing. If only he would...'

'.... get married, settle down, have children,' I completed the sentence for him.

'Yes, yes, mock at an old man if you want to. But when you get to my age, you'll understand. It's the only thing that matters. It means continuity. It means I'll never die. Have you read *Cancer Ward*?'

Old Uncle could still surprise me. 'Have you, Old Uncle?'

'You remember the man who's been operated on? He's delirious and keeps muttering ... "Not all of me shall die." A quotation from Pushkin, I believe. Not all of me shall die. That's how it is. That's the hope that keeps us going. That makes us willing to let go finally. *Not all of me shall die*. There shall be something of me left.' I listened to him in silence. He got up and said, 'Well, well, well, it's all the human ego. What does it matter, anyway? Just the ego. Give me my coat, Indu. And my stick ... just behind you.'

I helped him into his coat. 'Where are you going?'

'To see Naren.'

'I thought he was the outcaste.'

'Not to me, Indu. Never to me. We have very little to say to each other. I find him an enigma and he finds me a bore. But still My cap, Indu.'

'Are you going to ask him about Mini?'

'About Padmini? I?' He shook his head vigorously.

'I'm the wrong person for that. And I don't want to get involved. At least,' he gave a wry smile, 'that's what I tell myself. But I know ultimately I will. The human predicament . . . where have I heard that phrase, Indu? Where is it from? I forget too easily nowadays. But that's what it is. In spite of the hurt, the suffering, the humiliations, you go on getting involved. That's the human predicament.'

7

Two old men playing cards. Absorbed in the game. Intent on it. As serious about picking up or discarding a card as if it is a life and death matter. I should write a story about it. Or better, a play. Make it symbolic. Two old men playing cards while the house is falling about their ears. Make them symbols . . . of what? I don't really know myself.

For all writers there comes a time when they ask themselves . . . why am I writing? What am I doing this for? And they've got to find the answer, or else they're sunk. Finished.

But, for most writers, that time comes when they've gone some considerable way. For me it came too soon. I had written earlier with a gay abandon, a kind of innocence that had carried me along thoughtlessly. And then, suddenly one day, everything had dried up in me. Why was I writing? What was I doing it for? And,

when this happened, it was impossible to go on. Impossible not to go on, either, because it was still the only thing for me.

'Old Uncle, not that one,' I burst out involuntarily, noticing him discarding one card of a pair.

'Sssh.' I was confronted with two offended faces.

Kaka put his finger to his lips, and shushed me loudly, while Old Uncle shook his head reprovingly. But I observed that he gave the discarded card a sad look all the same. I stifled a laugh. And then, remembering how seriously they took their game, I relapsed into seriousness and silence, leaning back against the fat cushions that had stood against the wall as long as I could remember. The cushion covers were one of Kaka's extravagances. He gave them to the dhobi each week, for which reason they were, most unusually for this house, clean and white.

Sharad appeared in the door behind the two players. He beckoned me. There was something conspiratorial about his gesture that warned me to get up quietly. Neither Kaka nor Old Uncle looked at me as I went out.

'What is it, Sharad?'

'It's Naren. He wants to see you. He's waiting in Old Uncle's room. It's all very hush hush. Nobody else is to know.'

Sharad was enjoying himself hugely.

'Okay.' I said.

Sharad kept up with me as I went down the stairs. 'Has he come to collect the loot before taking Mini off our hands?' he asked me, his face solemn, his eyes dancing. Naren and Mini... I had dropped the idea in their midst and left it at that. Nothing had been said about it since. The family, Father had told me later, had instead argued interminably about selling

the house and dividing the rest of the property, after Old Uncle and I had left. Partition had finally been decided upon and Shyamrao had been instructed about the drawing up of an agreement.

I, as a daughter, was of course excluded from this matter.

'Sharad,' I said with asperity, frowning at him, 'you talk too much. You're too young still to meddle in such matters.'

"Oh, Indu-akka, I'm disappointed. I never expected to find you so old-fashioned. I thought you went in for new and bold ideas. I was always told you were a radical. Don't you know that power now lies in the hands of youth? Do you know we've kicked out two Vice-Chancellors so far?"

'Huh!' I snorted contemptuously. 'Pawns, that's what you really are. Don't tell me you've been fool enough to be taken in by the idea that you've done anything. All that talk about power being in the hands of youth is just a verbal sop. You're being used by others, you know.'

'But, really, Indu, instead of giving all that money to that roving waster, give it to me. Just try me, I say. I need it for a much better purpose. A noble one. Don't you want to help me to become a doctor? Once I'm a doctor, I'll even look after Mini in case she remains a spinster.' I turned my face away from him to hide a smile. Sharad got away with too much as it was. Even the normally unyielding Kaki was like a piece of plasticine in his hands. 'Have some confidence in me, Big Sister,' Sharad went on. 'Think it over before you decide.'

I didn't bother to reply. He stood in the back door watching me as I went to Old Uncle's room.

Naren was inside, standing near the table, idly rifling the pages of a magazine. He turned round as I entered and it came upon me with a shock that he was in a white flame of fury. He gave me a blank look as if he had never seen me before. Then he burst out.

'Wha ... wha ... wha ... what kind of a game are you trying to play? Who do you think you are?' He was shuttering, as he had always done when angry. And we had mocked him, ganging up against him, all of us, Hemant, Sumant, Sunil, and yes, Mini as well.

'What are you talking about?' Was it going to be a slanging, abusing match between us as it had been when we were kids?

'Talking about me marrying Mini. Who are you to decide? Just because the old woman gave you her money, has that given you the right to control my life?'

'But, you ... you ... you ...' I stammered in my turn, not mocking him, but unable to help myself, so taken aback was I by his anger.

'I ... I ... I ...' he mocked me now. 'I what?'

'You said you'd like to.'

'Circumstances have changed.' He spoke with a pedantic dignity that I'd have laughed at if I hadn't been so angry myself.

'What circumstances?'

'None that you know anything of.' He spoke airily, the heat and tension suddenly gone out of him.

'And how did you come to know about this ... this idea of your marrying Mini?'

'I have my sources. And that does not mean grandfather. Oh, I know the whole idea. Let Naren marry Mini so that Indu can save Akka's money which would otherwise have been spent on the wedding. And let Indu give the money to Kaka so that he can rescue this

old monstrosity of a house. Why,' he turned to me, savage again, 'are you so intent on perpetuating something that needs to die a quiet death?'

'Perpetuating, perpetuating,' I gladly mocked him now. 'You talk like a Marxist. And why, by the way, aren't you one? It's the right thing to be one now, isn't it? You're all dressed for the part anyway.'

He smiled at me for the first time and it was a smile that made you feel you could forgive him anything. It was amazing how fast he could get rid of his anger. 'I was everything once. Not any more. I'm too old for such things. And too lazy as well. Parties, groups, families, committees . . . don't you know they're all the same, Indu? It's each for himself or herself. When self interest comes in, everything else flies out of the window. But let that go. Let's get back to the point. How could you be so stupid, Indu, as to imagine me and Mini together?'

'Why not?'

'Because . . . because' It was worth everything to see Naren at a loss.

'Oh, hell! You should know, Indu, I don't have to spell it out for you. If it were you now . . .'

'I'm married,' I said primly, trying to repress a smile.

'I know. To a man you had to propose to. Tell me, Indu,' he moved closer to me, still speaking in the same tone, not lowering it, 'if you had left it alone, would he have done it himself?'

'I don't know,' I replied shortly.

'You're not a woman who would appeal to most men, are you, Indu?' He stared dispassionately, directly, into my face, 'One couldn't call you good looking, really. But there's something about you . . .'

'Charm,' I prompted him helpfully.

'Charm! Ough!' It was an inelegant, but conclusive sound dismissing the word, the concept. 'There's no such thing. It's a figment of writers' imaginations. No, what you have is different. You're like a ... like ... like ... I don't know what,' he confessed candidly. 'Yes, I do, too. You're like mango pulp with salt added to it. Gives a tang to the mango pulp, doesn't it? Not many like it that way. But I do.' Love me, like me, care for me, appreciate me ... Oh god, will we go on crying for the moon eternally? Will never be free of these pressures?

'What are you up to, Naren?' I asked him, my voice thickened with the something that was choking me. 'What's all this in aid of?'

Naren ... amoral, fickle, irresponsible ... would I lose grip over myself because of him?

He looked at me, gravely. 'I don't know, Indu. You remember,' he went off a tangent again, 'how all of you used to combine against me, calling me an outsider? I was never part of your family. Poor grandfather, only a poor dependant! I can still remember Hemant taunting me when I called his father "Kaka". "He's not your Kaka," Hemant hurled at me. At times I hated grandfather for staying here. "Let's get out of here," I used to cry sometimes. But he never heard me. It seemed terrible then to be an outsider. Not to belong ... it was a crime, a punishment. And then I thought ... I'll show them. I'll show all of you. My triumphs always meant ... that I'll show them. Now they'll admire me, envy me, accept me. And when I got my job, my first one,' he grinned at me, the seriousness falling off his face like a piece of peel, 'I remember how pleased grandfather was. I knew what it was. I had beaten Hemant and Sumant. I was making up for the slights, the hurts, the

rebuffs. And yet, he would never admit the slights, the hurts, the rebuffs. And one day I asked myself, "What am I trying to do? Why the hell should I do something I don't like, to impress people I don't care a hang about?" And that day, Indu, I knew I was free. I didn't want to belong. I didn't want to be envied. I didn't want to be admired. I just wanted to live the way I felt, the way I desired.'

Simplicity of will ... I had seen it in Naren. But could even he find things so simple?

'And so?' I asked him.

'And so ... don't imagine I want anything from your family. Or, anything to do with your family. As for you ' It was strange, the look he gave me as he went out of the room. An alter ego ... isn't that a chimera we chase throughout our lives? I had thought I had found my alter ego in Jayant. I had felt that in marrying him, I had become complete. I had felt incomplete, not as a woman, but as a person. And in Jayant, I had thought I had found the other part of my whole self. Not only that, but total understanding. Perfect communication. And then, I had realised this was an illusion. I had felt cheated. But, can perfect understanding ever exist?

'You don't understand me,' ... we had so often flung the words at each other. And one day I had realised that what we were saying was ... 'Don't judge me. Don't criticise me. Just appreciate me. See only my virtues, not my vices. My strength, not my weakness.' This is what we want. And we call it perfect understanding.

Since then, I had stopped saying those words to him. How could he understand me? Most of the times I can't even understand myself. 'I don't know why I do things.' Wasn't it Haldane who said that? And it's true

not only about motivation, but everything. And now here was Naren. It was impossible to understand him. What did he want? What did he want of me? A child came into the room and said shyly, 'Indu-atya, Ajji wants you.'

It was Vishu, Hemant's son. He stood outside the room and, before I could reply, ran away. It was difficult for me to be easy or comfortable with children. Perhaps they sensed it. It was not that I disliked them. The fact was, I did not know how to approach them. I could never assume a superior, all-knowing, patronising air with them as I saw other adults do. I could not act sure and confident, as if I knew all the answers. I could not, in other words, act god for them. Would I be able to do so with my own children when I had them?

No, I corrected myself, not 'when I had them' but, 'if I had them'. Having children ... it isn't something you should think and plan about. You should just have them. And yes, I smiled to myself, end up like Sunanda-atya. Pure, female animal.

I found Kaki in the smoke-blackened kitchen in front of the wood fire, her sari pulled up to her knees, her bare legs stretched in front of her, blowing at the fire through a black iron pipe. An old woman was sitting in front of the other fire, rolling chappaties. There had always been a nameless old woman, invariably called Kaku, to help in the kitchen. This could be just one more of them. Yet the gnome-like face that peered at me from under the red sari that covered her shaven widow's head, looked faintly familiar.

'Here she is, your niece, now,' she said, stopping her work and sitting back on her haunches to give me a frank, unabashed stare.

"Oh, there you are, Indu!" Kaki, knocking two sticks of wood together, said. The flames flew up for a moment, then settled down to a steady height. 'Where were you?'

Atya, who was at the other end of the long kitchen . . . there were fireplaces at both ends, one for the morning meal with all its elaborate rituals, the other for the simpler evening meal . . . looked up and said, 'There she is. Did you recognise her, Kaku?'

'Of course!' The old woman spoke contemptuously. I knew these women had their own standards for judging people. Nothing about me . . . my academic distinctions, my career, my success, my money . . . none of these would impress her. To her I was just a childless woman. To get married, to bear children, to have sons and then grandchildren . . . they were still for them the only successes a woman could have. I had almost forgotten this breed of women since I had left home. Now, seeing them was like discovering a new world. Each one of them, riddled with ignorance, prejudice and superstition, was a world of darkness in herself. And, even more amazing was their ignorance of their own darkness. It was almost superb.

'I remember her all right. But she won't remember me. Once they grow up, they forget everyone. Young people nowadays are heartless.'

'How would she remember you, Kaku?' Atya spoke placatingly. 'After all, it's nearly twenty years now.'

Kaku . . . what was her real name? Perhaps, she had no name at all. These women . . . they are called Kaku and Kaki, Atya and Vahini, Ajji and Mami. As if they have to be recognised by a relationship, because they have no independent identity of their own at all. And, in the process, their own names are forgotten. How does it feel not even to have a name of your own? There are

women who are proud of having their names changed by their husbands during the wedding ceremonies. To surrender your name so lightly But what's in a name? I'm Indu. Indu. Indu. After a while, the name becomes meaningless, like any other word after constant repetition. As meaningless as Kaku.

'What's your name?' I asked her suddenly.

Three faces stared at me in amazement. 'I just told you, Indu ...'

'Oh!' Atya smiled in understanding. 'You mean her real name?'

'Do you have one?' I asked, purposely cruel. 'Or have you forgotten it?'

'Forgotten my name! What a thing to say! You think because you're clever, all the others are stupid. Of course, I know my name. I have not just one, but two good names. One given to me by my father when I was born, and the other by my husband when I got married. Both holy, sacred names, mind you! Not like these modern names. What do you mean?'

'All right, Kaku, go on with your work,' Kaki said dryly, peering into the vessel she was stirring. The kitchen was both dark and airless, the only light coming from a small grilled window set high up in one wall. And two glass sky-lights in the soot-blackened rafters. I had to insist. Maybe she had really forgotten both the names. What if she had? Why should it matter to me? But somehow it did.

'Yes, but you haven't told me what those names are.'

'Ganga ... there, can you get a holier name? That's my name in my father's house. Actually, it was my grandmother who chose it. She had just returned from Kashi. What a welcome they gave her! I heard the story later. Going to Kashi was a real pilgrimage in those days.

Now, you just sit in a train and reach Kashi. What merit is there in such a pilgrimage ?'

'And your other name ?' I prompted her.

'Another holy river ... Kaveri. My mother-in-law chose that one. Both good and holy names. But what's the use ? There's no one left to call me by my name anymore ! My sister died last year. They're all gone now.'

She jerked the end of her sari from round her waist and wiped her eyes. In the process, her head came uncovered. That bare skull, with its short hairs, looked somehow, not only indecent, but obscene when bared. And I understood why Kaka had, when Atya was widowed, so stoutly resisted the idea of her becoming a shaven widow. He had won, but at the cost of Atya's status. She was now a second class citizen in the kingdom of widows. The orthodox would not eat food cooked by her.

I could see Kaki winking at me and gesturing imperceptibly towards the door. I guessed she wanted me to go out of the kitchen. I left and she followed me immediately.

'Phoo !' She wiped her tired, sweating face with her sari. 'Once that old woman starts speaking, she never stops. But at least she comes and helps us whenever we need her. It's so difficult to get help nowadays. Not that she's doing us a favour by coming here. She needs the money and the one square meal we give her. Her daughter-in-law denies her even that. Come here, Indu, I want to talk to you. I didn't want to speak in front of her. She's got the sharpest ears and the longest tongue in town. Your Kaka calls her All India Radio.'

We went into the small puja room. Some idiosyncrasy had urged grandfather to give it a white tiled floor. The tiles even extended halfway up the walls, giving the

room the white antiseptic look of a toilet. But the odours were unmistakable. Flowers. Incense sticks. Sandalwood. Oil lamps.

Kaki hesitated at the door. 'Are you all right, Indu? Can you come in?'

I knew what she meant. Was it one of those times when I was unclean and barred from the puja room?

'Yes,' I replied shortly, overwhelmed by memories of my girlhood when I had raged against the rules which had made me an outcast three days in a month.

'I won't be a girl then,' I had exclaimed in a fury once. And Sunanda-atiya had laughed. Triumphant. Saying, 'You can't help it. There's nothing you can do about it.'

'It's so difficult to know these days,' Kaki complained plaintively. 'Nobody observes the rules any more. Even Sumitra . . . whenever she comes here, she always says, "I just finished." You can fool people, but you can't fool the family gods.'

Atiya came in holding a vessel of hot milk with a wet rag and said, 'Well, have you asked her?'

'About Naren? No, I was just about to. Is it true, Indu, that Naren was here? What had he come about? Was it something to do with Mini?'

Atiya put the milk in a corner and squatted there, staring up patiently at me. 'What did he say?' she asked me, her eyes apprehensive.

'He says . . . ' What had he said? ' . . . he doesn't want Mini.' Had he said that?

'Thank God for that!' I looked at Kaki in surprise. 'Really Indu, how could you have imagined that I'd give my daughter to that vagabond? That fellow without a job, without money, without a home? Why, the last time

he said something about it, I was so furious with him, I'd have slapped him if I'd met him.'

'But, Kaki ...' People amaze you. You think you know them and they say something or do something which shows you were fooled. Kaki had never shown any positive antipathy to Naren at any time. She had been the same with him as with everyone else. And now this

I had the same sense of being cheated I had as a child, when I had believed an adult and found out later that I had been deceived.

'.... You mean to say you prefer that fellow Akka chose ?'

'Of course. How can you even compare the two ? Look at that family, that house ... have you seen it ? It's even bigger than ours ... their lands ? My daughter will be mistress of all that. He's the only son, you know.'

'I thought ... I mean, Kaka said ... if we didn't spend on Mini's wedding, I could ... I mean, we could do something about this house'

Kaki's eyes blazed at me. She spoke in an angry hiss. 'This house ! Who cares about it ? It's my daughter I'm thinking about. Don't let us down, Indu. Akka had promised us. If we let go this chance, we may never get one half as good again. And the house ...'

'If it goes, Kaki ?'

'It goes. You think I'll shed a tear ? Since I came into this house, my lot has been work, work, and yet more work. As long as we live here, there'll always be parasites. People come and stay here as if they have a right in this house. As if they have some claim on us. Is it our duty to entertain these people and their families all the time ? And who has to foot the bill afterwards ? Us. Because we've committed the crime of living here. The

others get fat salaries and come and stay here like big lords. But when it comes to simple things like paying the taxes or the electricity bills . . . oh, let Anna pay. After all, he's the one staying in the house, isn't he? None of them even share in the work. Am I everyone's servant? And, after slogging for all of them, what do I get? "You've stolen my silver vessels."

'Forget that, Vahini. Sunanda is just a silly girl,' Atya interjected, but Kaki couldn't stop. 'And, "You've taken all the income from the lands this year." And then. "What, is this all that the mangoes brought in this year?" Such words! I'm fed up. Indu. Let them all rot.'

'But, where will you go, Kaki?'

'A small house.' A tender, wistful look came over her face. It astonished me. I had never seen her look that way. Except, sometimes with Sharad. 'With a small kitchen. Gas to cook on. Shining pots and pans lined on shelves.'

'Kaki, I never knew . . .'

'Who knows anything about me, child? Has anyone ever asked me what I want? That's why I'm telling you. . . . ask Mini what she wants. It's not good enough you saying, or her father saying . . . let her marry Naren. Ask her what she wants.'

And then she turned to Atya as if dismissing me and the subject entirely. 'Have you left that old woman alone in the kitchen? You know her. God knows how many things will go into the folds of her sari before we go back. I don't put it past her to drink some of the buttermilk. I'd better go back fast.'

Atya and I smiled at each other in the silence Kaki left behind.

'Well, Atya, do you want a small house and kitchen too?'

'She ... Vahini ... wasn't born in this house. She doesn't have the same feeling for it that we ... Anant and I ... do. If I had a wish, I would say ... let me die here where I was born. Our father died here. And mother. And Akka. It's all right for Vahini ... she has sons and can say with them without feeling an intruder. Where can I go? My brothers, thank God, have been so good to me I've never felt unwanted here. And I belong here. Nowhere else. This is all Hemant's doing.' Atya gave me a mischievous smile. 'He's been filling up his mother with stories of how he'll buy a new house the minute they get money from the sale of this one. And how comfortable he'll make his mother in that new house. Provided, of course, they give him all the money they get from this sale. Well' Atya got up heavily, holding the wall for support.

'Where's Sumitra? She should at least come in time to set the plates. Find her, Indu. And Mini.'

'Mini ... yes. I must talk to her.'

'After lunch, Indu. After lunch. You know what your Kaka is like. He'll be yelling at all of us if lunch isn't served within ten minutes.'

I found Mini on the terrace after lunch. She had washed her hair in the morning and was now drying it in the sun. She seemed to be in deep contemplation and didn't see me until I called out her name. The look she gave me was curious. Neither welcoming nor hostile. Just blank. I felt equally blank myself. What could I say to her?

When we had been young, there had been too much of a gap between us ... not so much in years really, for she was just four years younger than I was ... but

otherwise. Mini had always been very much of a girl, the way a girl was expected to be, helping the women with small odd chores from a very young age, waiting on her father and brothers and being generally docile. Our worlds had rarely touched. Now it was too late to exchange girlish confidences. But surely I could talk to her. Tantalisingly, I had found Mini an enigma since my return. Was she really one? Or did the sphinx-like silence conceal nothing?

‘Does Mother want me?’ she asked me.

‘No. I do. I want to talk to you.’

She wrung her hair out like a wet cloth and drops of water fell on the cement floor. It was so heated that the drops sizzled and evaporated in a moment. I shaded my eyes against the glare, while Mini who had been up here longer, merely screwed up her eyes.

‘But not here. It’s too hot. Let’s go down.’

Obediently she followed me, stopping once at the door to say, ‘You remember, Indu, how we used to come up here for the champak flowers? And how brave you were, walking on the parapet, leaning forwards to pluck the flowers?’

I laughed. ‘Showing off! Just showing off. I liked to imagine myself a daredevil. I used to be scared to death really. But I could never reveal that.’

‘And Indu,’ Mini went on chattily as we walked down the cool, dark stairs, ‘the funniest thing was that you never liked the flowers at all. You always gave them to me.’

‘Did I?’

I stopped and stared at her, seeing her as a small child, her small dark face blazing with pleasure as I gave her the flowers. ‘Yes, now I remember it. But Mini, where are you going? I said I want to talk to you.’

'I suddenly remembered something myself. Kaka wanted me to cut up some supari for him. And I forgot all about it. I better do it now before he starts shouting at Mother for his supari.'

We went downstairs into what was technically Kaki's room. It hadn't changed in all the years since my childhood. The same ancient cupboards of dark wood, the same trunks piled up in a corner, the same photographs lined up on the wall. Mini pulled down a large brass tin. 'Here's the supari. Where are the nutcrackers?'

As she rummaged in the shelves, I held my breath. And then she emerged with the same brass nutcrackers I had seen as a child. I laughed aloud. Mini stared at me in surprise. 'What?'

'Nothing. Is there another pair, Mini? Can I help you?'

Now she giggled. 'Another pair? I was lucky to find this one. But you can dry the paan for Kaka. Here ...' She brought out a flat brass tin. 'And here ...' she poked in the cupboard again, '... a towel to wipe the paan.'

And so, there we were, the two of us doing what I had done so many times as a child. Miraculously the technique came back and I was as expert and brisk as if I had never given off doing it. Place the towel on your lap, wipe the paan once this way, once the other side ... and into the box. And Mini snipped snipped away industriously at the supari until a small brown mound grew between us.

'Do you know, Mini,' I said after a silence, 'that there are some workers in industries who spend a whole working life doing the same small bit of work over and over again? Just that and nothing else. Imagine you're

a worker in a car factory. Your job is drilling some holes in a metal sheet. And you do just that and nothing else all your life. You never even get to see the car of which your sheet is a part. What do you think you'd feel when you were dying and trying to sum up your life ?

Mini giggled, covering her mouth with the end of her sari to hide her uneven teeth.

'You think the most peculiar thoughts, Indu. What's the point of thinking of such things ?'

'The point . . . ? You mean, you never think unless there is ?' She shook her head, giving me a scared look as if she knew what was coming.

'What about your marriage ? Is that one of the things there's no point in thinking of ?'

'Why should I think of it ? I'm past 24. I have to get married. What else is there to think about ?'

'But Mini . . . marriage is It means living with a man. You have to listen to him, endure his habits, his smell, his touch, his likes, his dislikes. You have to sleep with him, bear him children. Can you do all that with this man ?' She put the nutcrackers down gently, and picking up her still wet hair, knotted it at the base of her neck. Mini's palms had two red lines where the nutcrackers had cut into them. I lifted the nutcrackers. They were heavy. Mini loosened my fingers and took the nutcrackers back from me.

'What choice have I, Indu ?' she asked me, resuming her snipping. Snip snip . . . the supari fell between us. Millions of girls had asked this question millions of times in the country. Surely it was time they stopped asking it ? What choice have I ? Surely it is this, this fact that I can choose, that differentiates me from the animals. But years of blindfolding can obscure your

vision so that you no more see the choices. Years of shackling can hamper your movement so that you can no more move out of your cage of no-choices.

'But Mini, are you getting married because there's nothing else you can do?'

'Of course.' She gave me a petulant look. 'Look, I've jammed my finger.'

And so she had.

'Leave it alone for some time.'

She watched her finger where the blood was forming an angry red clot under the skin. She licked at it like a child.

'Leave it alone, Mini.'

Obediently she put her hands in her lap.

'And you didn't answer my question.'

'Of course I'm marrying him because there's nothing else I can do. I'm no good at studies. I never was. I went to school because ... I had to. And then to college because Akka said I must go. Boys prefer graduates these days, she said. So I went. But I failed and it was a relief to give it up. There's only one thing I'm really good at ... looking after a home. And to get a home, I have to get married. This is not my home, is it?'

'Isn't it?'

'You know it isn't. Ever since we were small, we were told ... "You'll be going away one day to your own home." They said it to you and me, never to Hemant or Sumant or Sharad or Sunil.'

'But Mini, will any man do? Doesn't it matter who he is?'

'I'd better get on with this. Mother will be angry with me if Kaka asks for supari before I finish. Any man, Indu? Yes, any man. Any man who says "yes". You don't know what it has been like. Watching Kaka

and Hemant and even Madhav-kaka running around after eligible men. And then, sending the horoscope and having it come back with a message, "It doesn't match". And if the horoscopes matched, there was the meeting to be arranged. And Mother and Atya slogging in the kitchen the whole day. And all those people coming and . . . staring and asking all kinds of questions. And if we heard they were old fashioned people, I would dress up in an old fashioned manner and they would say, "She's not modern enough." And if I dressed up well because someone said the boy wanted a smart wife, they would say, "She's too fashionable for us." Or too short. Or too tall. Or too dark. Or something. And Kaka trying to laugh and talk to those people, while his eyes looked so anxious. And I, feeling as if I had committed a great crime by being born a girl. To make your parents look like that And, then, they would say, someone else in the family wants to see the girl. So we would have to go through with it all over again. And finally, if everything was fine, there was the dowry. You know nothing of this, Indu. You're lucky. You escaped all this. And now, when someone has agreed, can I refuse and make Kaka go through all of it all over again? Just because the man isn't'

'Isn't what?' I asked, after waiting for her to complete her sentence.

'Oh, I don't know. And I don't care. He'll look after me. And no one can say to me, "How old are you? And not married yet! What a pity!" I'm tired, Indu. I don't care what kind of a man he is. Once we are married, and he becomes my husband, none of his faults will matter.'

The Indian way. The husband. A definite article.

Permanent. Not only for now, but for ever. To be accepted. Stop.

'Marriage as a catalyst, eh?'

I said the words in English and Mini stared at me blankly. 'What does that mean, Indu?' she asked naively. 'I've forgotten all the English I learnt in school. You were always so good at it. Now you even talk in your sleep in English. Last night you were saying ...'

'Yes?' I felt a tremor within me.

'In English ...' she said accusingly, as if pinpointing my crime.

'But what?' I asked impatiently.

'Oh, something very funny. Something like ...' she switched over to her thickly accented English. '... "it's not fair. It's not fair."'

Not fair. Not fair. Odd how one relives bits of one's life in one's sleep. But, why that moment and why that phrase? I could recall it so distinctly. Jayant and I at the end of one of our moments of love. And I, aghast at my total self-abandonment, had cried out, 'It's not fair.' And Jayant, staring at me in bland astonishment, moving off me without asking me why I said that and what it meant. I tried to push away the thoughts and images. Mini was looking curiously at me.

'So you want to marry him, Mini?'

'Yes,' she said with an unexpected firmness. Then, as if frightened by her own temerity, appealingly, 'If you agree.'

'You mean if I pay.'

'It's the same thing.'

'And Naren?'

A smile twisted her lips. 'Naren?' She said the name questioningly. And flung back her head and laughed. Her hair came loose and cascaded down to the floor.

‘Oh, he’s never serious. He’s always joking about everything.’

Watching her hair, I was reminded of Naren’s words, ‘That’s my weakness. Next time I’ll loosen your hair.’

8

I had been home for three weeks now, but already I felt as if aeons separated me from the person I had been before I came home. The ten years I had spent away, had, on the other hand, been compressed to nothing. I had fitted myself without an effort into the pattern of life here; which was, in its essentials, the same as it had always been. Meals and rituals formed the centre of life, surrounded by a penumbra of trivial activities of which gossip was the most important one. Decision-making had no place at all in this design for living that I had adopted. I had, very simply, shrugged off the thought. I knew, of course, that this could not continue for long. But, in the meantime, it was a respite. And I maintained a determined silence over all the matters I didn’t want to think of. Strangely, the family met my mood and abstained from speaking anything but the commonest trivialities to me.

Madhav-kaka had, however, in his usual authoritative manner, breached the silence before he left. He had taken me aside and said, ‘There is something I have to

say to you. Sumitra wants me to mention this. I don't know whether I should but ...'

He was silent and I knew he was nerving himself to speak. He was a proud man and it humiliated him to ask favours of anyone. Then abruptly, as if ashamed of his dithering, he had shot out the question. 'Has Sunil approached you for a loan?'

'No.'

'For some reason, Sumitra seems to think he will. You know he hasn't achieved anything so far. A third class B.Sc. ... what does it mean? Even the girls have done better. I know his chances of getting a good job ... why, any job at all ... are almost nil. Anyway, the point is this. He now says he wants to start some kind of an agency with a friend of his. He wants me to lend him ... lend?' the scorn in the word was almost an annihilation of Sunil ... 'some money for the purpose.'

'And can't you, Madhav-kaka?'

'I could but' His nostrils flared, his lips tightened and I could sense his anger. '.... he's got involved with a girl. A Christian girl, I am told. He denies it, but I'm afraid it's true. And if he can make himself financially independent, Sumitra's afraid he'll marry the girl immediately. She says she's sure he'll approach you for a loan. He knows you hate all these conventional ideas.' Again that smile. How could a smile be so devoid of mirth? 'And she's scared you'll oblige Sunil just to spite the family. Because, you know, none of us approved when you got married. And so I thought,' (he had recovered all his aplomb now and was speaking, as he always did, with the ring of authority behind his words) 'I would let you know all the facts. If you still want to go ahead and help Sunil ... that's up to you, of course. I have no right to say

“don’t”. But I’d like you to think of all this before you decide.’

‘I will,’ I promised, thinking angrily, wretchedly . . . why do you involve me in your affairs? What has it to do with me whom Sunil marries? But even as I thought it, I knew I was involved. And the choice had not been mine. It was Akka who had thrust it on me. And, galling though it was to submit, I had no other alternative.

As Madhav-kaka left me, he added, ‘You will have to let us know soon. About the house, I mean. If it has to be sold, it should be done fast.’

So many itching palms Poor house, what chance have you? As for Madhav-kaka, I sensed his disappointment in me, if not actual disapproval. I felt I had somehow failed him. Perhaps he had expected me to consult him about my plans. It was a family tradition, wasn’t it, that Madhav-kaka was consulted before anyone in the family took any important decision? Perhaps he had even expected me to disclaim Akka’s legacy, or, at least its exclusiveness. But his bland face told me nothing and I could only guess.

With Madhav-kaka’s and Sunil’s departure, we became a much depleted family group. Earlier, Father had disappeared in his usual unpredictable manner, telling no one where he was going and why. Naren had not been seen, either, for the past few days. Vinayak-kaka and his eldest, Vasant-kaka, and Sumant and his family had also left. With their going, a strange melancholy clung to the house, as if this was the prelude to the final dissolution.

But Kaka had not given up hope. He approached me with an elaborate air of ‘it doesn’t really matter to me.’ Why dissemble with me? But that’s how it is. We’re always ashamed of our deepest emotions, as if there is

something shameful in total commitment. Do I not with Jayant, hide my real emotions and urges and shelter behind a facade of caring-but-not-so-terribly-much?

'Have you said anything to Naren, Indu? You know, about what you suggested the other day? I've thought about it since and it doesn't seem a bad idea at all.'

'But Kaka, last time you refused him.'

'I know. But that was ...' — he made a wry face; Akka's virtues were already evaporating — '.... Akka's idea. Maybe he was ... maybe he is angry with us about that. But no harm in asking, is there? Ask him, Indu. Ask him.'

'Do you honestly feel he is the right man for Mini?'

'Right man, right man,' he exclaimed irritably. Then, recovering himself with an unusual self-control, he went on, 'Who can guarantee who's the right man? After all, we can do only so much. The rest depends on the girl's luck. And Naren ... why not? He's a good boy. I told you I always liked him. A little irresponsible, maybe. But once he's married and has a wife and kids, he'll settle down. I know he will. After all, he's a clever boy. Well qualified too. No reason why he shouldn't' His voice trailed away.

Oh Kaka, transparent as glass and fooling yourself you're deceiving me!

'Kaki's dead against it,' I said wryly.

'She?' Anger burned in his eyes for a moment. 'These women are so small-minded, they'll spoil the cooking to starve those they dislike. They don't care if they starve themselves in the bargain. She grudges the fact that the burden of the family falls on me. She thinks it's because we live here. But tell me, Indu, can it ever be otherwise, wherever we live? I'm the eldest. I can't get away from that. And it isn't true that the

others never help. Madhav helps whenever he can. And Vinayak . . . ? How can I expect anything from him ? He isn't earning very much, and he has three daughters of his own. Your father has helped out once or twice. We brothers . . . we understand one another. But the women . . . God, how they dislike one another !'

It's this kind of a living, I thought. Living too close, too entangled with one another. So that if you move, you're bound to hurt someone else. And if they move, they hurt you. So many diverse pulls, so many conflicting feelings. And yet, surprisingly, it was still a family. How long it could continue to be one, without Akka's cohesive force behind it, was problematical. There was only Atya now, and Kaka, struggling to keep the fabric of the family intact. And Old Uncle, who had never mattered at any time, and mattered even less now. But they had something in common, these three; something that kept a concept like this family alive. A lack of the sense of 'yours' and 'mine'. And this, in an age which said . . . *assert your self*. Don't suppress it. Let it grow and flourish; never mind how many things it destroys in the bargain. No wonder these people were just anachronisms now, struggling to survive in an increasingly alien, hostile environment.

But there was yet another person as passionately against a break-up. It was Sunanda-Atya. And in her the motive was simple and uncomplicated.

She came to me when I was reading a letter, a child on her hip, panting from her climb upstairs. She had the pallid, slightly concave face some anaemic women have. This same pallor had been taken for a 'fair complexion' in her youth. It had given her a husband at the young age of 16; and that husband, the first man she had been proposed to. Lucky girl, they had called her

then. Specially when her first child had been a boy. Poor Sunanda-itya I had seen photographs of her as a girl in the family album. A slim, long-faced, large-eyed girl with a look of virginal innocence. The innocence, if it had ever been there, had long since turned to guile. She was, I often thought, the eternal female. A female, not as she was meant to be, but as she became in the process of adapting herself to her circumstances and environment. Cunning, greedy, devious and unscrupulous. Yet, how could she have been otherwise? As a child she had learnt that, being a female, she could neither assert, demand nor proclaim.

'Sumitra-vahini was looking for you, Indu,' she said now, letting the child slide down from her hips. The toddler staggered off to the window, and she sat opposite me, her protruding eyes staring vacuously at me.

'What for?'

'I don't know. They never tell me. And I never ask them.' She shrugged her shoulders in an elaborate unconcern. 'I think it's something to do with Shyamrao. I heard he had come to give you the keys of Akka's safe.'

'Akka's safe? What has it to do with me?'

'Why, all her jewels are in it. They're all yours now, aren't they. Hey you, what are you trying to do, you nuisance? Fall out of the window?'

But she didn't stir. It was I who brought the protesting child back into the room.

'And Indu,' Sunanda-itya whispered, 'take charge of the key at once, hunh? Don't let them do to you what they did to me. I was a poor innocent then. My own mother's silverware. I wonder they don't feel the burden of such a sin. But there, you can get away with anything if you're callous enough. But you always pay

for your wrongs. That's what I say. And it's true. Look, how much trouble they had getting Mini's marriage fixed up. And I hear,' she came closer still, her voice just a breath in my ears, 'that 'she' has converted some of mother's silver into things to give Mini at her marriage. Have you heard of anything more shameless?'

'She' . . . that was Kaki. And the silverware . . . it was impossible not to smile at the thought of the feud still raging between the two women. As a child, I had seen minor skirmishes, guerilla warfare, pitched battles and a full scale war being fought on the same issue . . . the silverware which grandmother was supposed to have promised her daughter Sunanda on the birth of her first son. Unfortunately, grandmother had died before Sunanda-itya's Krishna was born. And when, on his birth, Sunanda-itya had staked her claim, Kaki had refused to hand them over, disclaiming all knowledge of such a promise. Kaki's sticky determination not to let go was as astonishing as Sunanda-itya's dogged persistence. When Kaki had, with what she perhaps considered great magnanimity, gifted one solitary silver tumbler to Krishna on his naming day, Sunanda-itya had silently accepted. But soon after, the same tumbler had been presented by her to Sharad during his thread ceremony in a magnificent gesture of protest. Sunanda-itya's motto was : All or nothing.

'And now 'she' thinks she's achieved something great by fixing up this match for Mini. I didn't say anything then, out of respect for Akka; but if they had asked me, as they should have done if they had any idea of courtesy, I'd have told them it isn't at all a suitable match. Our grandfather and our father were not ordinary people. And all my brothers so educated and well placed. None of those people ever went to school, and

now they behave as if they're doing us a great favour by consenting to marry Mini. The amount of fuss that was made over them when they came here to "look at Mini" ... it was disgusting. Even Anna ... I expected something better from him at least. Can you imagine, Indu, I couldn't get a glass of milk for my little Leela that day !'

There was a sudden loud howl. The child had fallen down flat on his face. Sunanda-itya got up reluctantly, and half-heartedly smacked the child.

'Didn't I tell you to sit quiet ? Stop it, now. Stop it.' But the child wouldn't give over. She sat down once again, the child on her lap, and opening her buttons, pushed a flaccid nipple into his mouth. The child took a long shuddering breath and began sucking with loud noises. I shivered involuntarily. Distaste for the female functions ... I hadn't got over it as yet.

'If you ask me, Indu, it isn't worth it, giving all that money to that family. Mini is like my own daughter and I'm speaking out of genuine affection for her. Instead of spending so much money on that marriage, wouldn't it be better to spend it on this house ... our father's house ? When I think of how he loved it And now they talk of pulling it down.' She covered her face with her sari. 'I can't bear to think of it, Indu.'

I was astonished to find her emotion genuine. When she uncovered her face, I saw that her eyes were not only wet, but frightened and desolate. And I knew why. For her too, this house was a refuge. It was her security against a life with an irresponsible husband who had long periods of joblessness. I felt sorry for her.

'How is Vasant-kaka ? Is he in a good job now ?'

She let go her sari and with it, her grief as well. She was back into battle.

'A good job? Of course he is. Only thing, he's not been able to get a good house for us as yet. You know how particular he is that his family should have the best. Just any place won't do. That's why I'm staying here temporarily. Actually, Indu, the fact is ... and this is only for your ears, I haven't told anyone else about it, you know how spiteful they are the man he's working for at present is so pleased with him, he's offered him a partnership. All he needs to do is to put in some capital. I did ask Akka about it and she had promised me ... almost promised, I mean'

I had heard the story. 'What!' Akka had exploded. 'Give that money to that waster of a husband of yours! I'd rather throw it down the drain.'

'.... and then she died. But that's just my luck. Anyway, forget about it.'

Yes, the seed has been sown. Let's forget about it for the present.

'But what I really wanted to talk to you, Indu, was about my Krishna.'

'What about him, Sunanda-atya?'

'You know, Indu,' and how placating her tone was now, 'I think Akka was a wise woman leaving her money to you. At first, like all these others ... yes, all of them; you should hear them talking when you're not around. Sumitra-vahini was saying ... "She pretends to be disinterested in money, but has anyone heard her say a word about giving a paisa of that money to anyone else?"'

God, it hurts! To hear such words ... it's like being flayed alive. I'm no fool, nor a child, either, but a grown woman. I know the crust is most often deceptive. And yet, to find rottenness within each time it leaves a scar. Each betrayal is the first betrayal, each treachery

the final one. Where is the armour that will protect me from such wounds? When will I find it? To be detached

‘Yes, as I was saying, like all these others, I was a bit upset too, at first. But “he” made me think otherwise. You don’t know what a good opinion he has of you, Indu.’

I know. My knowledge dates from the time I was 15. And you, Sunanda-atya, were in your . . . which bed of childbirth? I was learning to ride the bicycle. And he, your husband, my uncle, had offered to help me. I had accepted the help gladly, until I had felt his ‘helping hands’ giving me the age-old messages of male to female. At 15, you’re woman enough to have an instinctive knowledge of male hunger, and child enough to panic at being the object of it. I had avoided him ever since.

‘But then, that’s how “he” is. Never talks ill of anyone.’

‘About Krishna?’ I prompted. The child had fallen asleep, mouth open. Sunanda-atya’s sari had slipped down from her shoulder, baring her pendulous, large-nippled breast. Gently I covered her with her sari.

‘What is Krishna doing now?’

‘Doing?’ She sighed heavily, theatrically. ‘That’s the thing. You know he failed his SSC twice?’

I shook my head.

‘He did. And it isn’t his fault really. He’s a clever boy and he worked hard. But they failed him by just a few marks. It’s shameful. So many boys, not half as good as him, passed. But what can you expect these days when you’re a Brahmin?’

It staggered me. ‘You mean, they deliberately failed him because he’s a Brahmin?’

‘Of course!’

'Surely, Sunanda-atya, you don't believe that yourself?'

Her lips came together in an obstinate line. 'I know it's true. It's just one more of the things they're doing to us. God knows how much more we will have to put up with. And Old Uncle says . . . "We have to pay for the sins of our ancestors." It's fine for him to be philosophical. He doesn't have to bother about jobs and money. He knows he'll always get enough to eat and drink in this house. Oh, he's comfortable enough, all right.'

I thought of all that Old Uncle had done for the family. All that he meant to it. And I was possessed by a diabolical anger. Sunanda-atya, luckily oblivious of the emotions she had stirred in me, went on.

'Anyway, that's why Krishna refused to appear again. He know they'll fail him this time too.'

I had been hearing of this bogeyman 'they' since my return. 'They' refused us jobs; 'they' refused us promotions; 'they' refused us admissions; and now 'they' were failing us in our exams. 'They' had become the scapegoats for our failures, our weaknesses, our faults. Injustice . . . yes, it does exist. But can you escape the consequences of past injustices? Can you disown your inheritance? We are burdened with the sins of our ancestors who, with their arrogant assumption of superiority, made others less than human.

And one thing was clear to me . . . it is the weak, the incompetent, the undeserving who sit and moan. There are others who effortlessly scale the walls of injustice, who overcome barriers by ignoring them. If I have any doubts about this, I have only to look at Vithal. He is an arrow, a bullet, shot by an expert marksman. And what advantages did he have?

It was Old Uncle who had told me Vithal's story. Vithal's father had been a professional cook, hiring himself out for festivals, weddings, funerals. A dour, grim man who rarely spoke and never smiled, there was a streak of cruelty in him that came out in his relations with his meek silent wife. The boy, as a child, had been a frequent spectator of scenes in which the father had worked out his sadistic anger on the mother for the merest trifles. And then one day, when the man was out on a job, the mother just disappeared. She had not even bothered to cook a meal for the child. When the man returned after a three day job, he found the boy starving. The mother never returned. And neither the boy nor his father ever mentioned her name again.

Now the man started on the boy. Not a physical cruelty ... it was as if that instinct had fled with the wife but of a different kind. He kept the boy perpetually by his side, even when he was working. And the boy was chained to his lessons. As the man rolled and pounded and cut and stirred, he kept a jealous eye on the boy. (18 times 14? 77 buffaloes, each sold for Rs. 867 ... how much altogether?) After a year of this the boy ... almost a moron now ... ran away. For a few months he lived like an animal, getting a few scraps wherever and however he could. Kaka found him outside a shabby restaurant one day, scavenging in the dustbin. Realising from his scared thread, which had somehow stayed with him all the while, that he was a Brahmin, he had taken him home. And he had stayed there, doing odd jobs, being fed like any stray animal, until Old Uncle had found him poring over a book one day and asked, 'Can you read? Do you want to go to school?'

Nothing could hold him back after that.

But Sunanda-itya was still speaking of her Krishna. 'I'm out of my mind about that boy. His father plays it cool, but how can I blame him? He has his own problems. Indu, can't you give me some advice?'

'How can I advise you, Sunanda-itya?'

'Whom else can I ask?' she said querulously, her face lengthening till it looked like an exclamation mark. Whom else? Who else had Akka's money?

'There's Madhav. But you know him. He isn't helpful at all. He was not like this before. It's his wife. No, there is no one I can turn to, Indu. You must help me. If he had a little money, he could start a small shop of his own. He's good at repairing things. Or if his father becomes a partner, he could find room for the boy there.'

'Indu . . . !' It was Sumitra-kaki's voice.

Sunanda-itya sat up, an amazing change in her. She looked alert, hostile, prepared for God-knows-what.

'I'm here, Sumitra-kaki.'

She gave us both a curious look. 'Goodness, I've been looking for you all over the house. What are you both up to here?' She gave a small laugh to show she didn't mean it. 'Come out here, Indu. I have something to say to you,' she went on confidentially.

I was not going to let her use me as a pawn in her game. 'What is it, Sumitra-kaki? Is it about the key of Akka's safe? I hear Shyamrao gave it to you?'

Sunanda-itya looked gleeful. And Sumitra-kaki gave an uneasy laugh.

'Oh, so you know about that. It seems to me even the walls in this house have ears.'

She flashed Sunanda-itya a meaningful glance. Sunanda-itya tried to look unconcerned.

'Yes, it's the key. I have the list as well and he would like you to check it. And, your Kaki says, if you'd like

to do it now, come down. Both she and I are free at the moment.'

Akka's small safe was in a tiny room off her bedroom. It had been a 'holy of holies' place, with no one but herself allowed inside. The only other person I had seen entering the place had been Akka's husband's half-witted niece, Kusum, an orphan who had been with Akka for years. She had been Akka's servant, companion and scapegoat . . . all in one. She had later committed suicide, and rumours had inevitably taken away her chastity and made her pregnant. Now I wonder whether it was Akka's personality that had driven her into that well. But, characteristically, Akka had shown neither grief nor remorse.

The word had gone round with an amazing swiftness that Akka's safe was to be opened, and all the women managed to crowd inside that small dark, airless room. I wondered at the amazing magic jewels held for women. The love of a child for baubles? Or that 'looking-for-security' again? But the gasps of admiration and delight as I pulled out the pieces one by one told me it was something more elemental than that. Even Lata and Geeta, their faces lit up by a genuine animation, chattered and admired with sincerity. But Sumitra-kaki's coos and smiles were obviously artificial. And Kaki had a wooden look on her face.

'That necklace, Indu,' Atya, sitting by in her usual detached manner, suddenly exclaimed, 'it was given to Akka by her father, our grandfather on her wedding day.'

'Yes, and she had promised it to Mini on her wedding day,' Kaki said.

'Really!' That was Sumitra-kaki. 'Very odd and unlike Akka to promise away something of her own. What

she once said to me was . . . "Whatever came to me from this family will go back to it." She had a strong sense of justice. That's why all the jewellery she got from her in-laws she gave away to her nephews. And these . . . she meant them for her daughters-in-law, I'm sure. Not the daughters. The daughters would take them away from the family'.

'Well, neither of my daughters-in-law got anything,' Kaki said emphatically.

'God knows! Maybe she was waiting for Sharad to get married, so that she could give all three of them at the same time. They would each have had one third of a share, of course. My Sunil's wife would have been lucky. One whole share.' Again that unconvincing laugh.

'And people like me who have no sons would sit with our mouths open and catch flies, I suppose,' Kamala-kaki burst out.

Kaki, in the same flat and level monotone, simultaneously said, 'Your Sunil . . . depends on what kind of a girl he marries, doesn't it? Suppose he marries a Madam, what will she do with our kind of jewellery?'

Mini, sitting next to me, hastily interjected with, 'Look Indu, aren't these pearls lovely! Let's see how they look on you. You never wear anything.' She held them round my neck and her hands went to the back to do up the clasp. I sat still and silent, letting her do it.

'Yes, Indu never wears anything,' Sunanda-atya said with a smile for me. As if we were allies. 'What does she need such things for? Her education is her real jewellery. It's only poor fools like us who need all that.'

'Fools!' Kaki's voice was heavily loaded with sarcasm.

I could no longer be silent. 'I never had any jewellery. Maybe that's why I never wore it. Now that I have

such a lot of it, perhaps I'll make a regular thing of wearing it.'

There was a shocked silence. In the dim light it was difficult to make out the faces, but the very air in the room was charged with consternation. Was I serious? The question hung tangible in the air. Does she mean it? Then what about my Mini, my Lata, my Geeta, my Shobha? It's not fair. It's not fair.

I kept a deadpan face. It was Sumitrawati who broke the silence with a business-like, 'Well, that's enough of staring and admiring. Let's check the things, shall we? I'll read out the list and one of you can put the things away. Indu, please see that it's all right.'

As we began, one by one the women got up and left. Finally it was all done and I was left alone, the keys of the safe clutched in my wet palm. After a while, Atya came back saying, 'Indu? Still here? And you forgot to put away the pearls.'

'Let me wear them, Atya. Let me wear them until they tear them off me.'

And then Atya put her arms round me and I was sobbing against her in an angry grief that would not dissolve into easy tears. Atya patted my back, stroked my hair, and made soothing murmurs. But I knew she could not help me. She could only offer me the comfort of her presence and that was neither lasting nor enough. It could not solve my problem either. For, how could I tell Atya of the letter I had received from Jayant? The letter I had been reading when Sunanda-Atya had disturbed me.

'I don't understand you, Indu. What's the problem? Surely you don't have to get involved with the problem of every Tom, Dick and Harry in the family? What have they ever done for you? Not one of them bother-

ed to see if you were alive or dead these last ten years. Shake the dust of that place off your feet, my dear, and come home soon. We can make our plans when we are together.'

Plans ... shall we buy an Ambassador ? Or a Fiat ? Shall we go in for a house ? Or a trip abroad ? Shall we buy a carpet or a new painting for the drawing room ?

That night after dinner I walked out to the tulsi platform at the side of the house ... my favourite spot in times of trouble as a girl. There was a full moon. The silvery radiance of the light outside dazzled me as I came out of the dimly lighted house. The moonlight seemed to have cast a spell of silence over the world. All sounds were not only muted, they were transmuted into silence. Even the croaking of the frogs merged in with the stillness.

I heard a cough nearby and jumped. There was someone on the other side of the tulsi. It was Vithal, I saw, reading in the moonlight.

'Vithal ! Can you see well enough to read ?'

He smiled at me. The smile made him look years younger, like his own younger brother.

'It's good enough. I've heard them say sometimes that I waste too much electricity reading at night. So, whenever it's possible, I read out here.'

He wasn't complaining. Just stating a fact.

'How can you concentrate, Vithal, with all these pin-pricks ?'

'I have to. I have no choice.'

Once again he was simply stating a fact. I have no choice. And how simple that made life seem !

I went back to my place on the other side of the tulsi. Vithal read on steadily, sometimes repeating something to himself in a low murmur. The smell of the raat-ki-

rani was wafted to me on the breeze. The turmoil and distaste that had filled me slowly began seeping out of me, leaving me full of a conviction that had been unknown to myself, steadily growing in myself all these days.

Here, in this house, in this family, was a role waiting for me. A role that I could, perhaps, act out more successfully than the one I had tried until now. For, had I not, so very often, felt myself just a mouthing, grimacing puppet, dully saying the lines I had to, feeling, actually, nothing? Had I not felt myself flat, one-dimensional, just a blurred figure merging into the background? Whereas here, I would stand out, sharp and clear. I would be most emphatically myself. Indu.

I played with the idea and it filled me with as much delight as any beloved toy had had during childhood.

I would buy the house and make Kaka and Atya happy. But Kaki? And all the others?

I would persuade Mini to forget this man, this marriage and soon arrange for a much better match for her.

But Mini ... ?

I would live here in this place which was my home and do the kind of writing I wanted to do.

And Jayant? And I? And all those unborn children of ours? I would look after the old, help the deserving, (yes, Vithal, you little know, as you sit reading quietly there in the moonlight, because they grudge you their electricity, how I hold a glorious future for you in my hands!) scorn the weak (yes, Sunanda-atya, nothing in this for you) and ruthlessly turn my back on the useless.

I would dominate, as much as Akka had ever done, but more discriminately, more judiciously. It would not be my likes and dislikes, but merit that would count.

And by doing this, I would (maybe, why not?) free myself of all doubts, all pressures. And now I remembered how I had once, as a child, in an idle hour played with an ant that seemed doggedly bent on getting some place. And I, equally determined that it should not go there, had pushed it back again and again. And that silly ant, not understanding, getting more and more wildly confused, had turned round again and again, trying to get back to its original road. And gleefully, triumphantly, I had pushed it back thinking... You have to do what I want.

For some time I sat there enjoying my dreams. Had I laughed once? I must have, for Vithal had looked inquiringly, curiously at me, peering round the tulsi, and when I had stared back, saying nothing, he had gone back to his books once again. And I felt I was on the brink of an adventure that would change the course of my life. And not mine alone, but so many others as well. Yes, there lay the wonder of it all. Not my life alone, but yours, Kaka, and yours, Mini, and yours, Vithal....

I felt full of an effervescent excitement I could scarcely contain within myself. I could no longer sit still and, getting up from my place, began moving about in the garden, hardly aware of where I was or what I was doing. It was when I stood leaning against the broken down gate that I saw him.

'Naren!' I exclaimed. And, irritable because I had been shaken out of my thoughts, 'and where were you all these days?'

In the moonlight his face had a peculiar ghost-like pallor. But he seemed, in some way, neater. Then I noticed that he had trimmed his beard and cut his hair. His clothes too looked whiter and less dingy; but that,

perhaps, was due to the gleaming moonlight. His face, however, was sombre until he saw me. Then he smiled.

'Isn't it wonderful to be greeted by such words? I feel like an old married man coming home to a loving wife. "And where were you all these days?" And in that tone! Wonderful! Tch, tch, Indu, I thought you were a virtuous Hindu wife.'

'Don't be silly,' I said in asperity. I had been drawing my fingers across the rough wood of the gate and a tiny splinter had pierced a finger. I sucked at it in exasperation. 'It was what anyone would say to you. Why, even Old Uncle didn't seem to know where you were!'

'And how should he when I hadn't told him myself?' Naren replied equably. 'But now I'm back. Where is he? Is he in?'

'I suppose so,' I said indifferently, my thoughts darting elsewhere. Strange how I had left Old Uncle out of my calculations. And Naren too. What would I do for them? Surely there had to be something, something I had a sense of deflation as I fumbled over the thought. Suddenly my toy seemed dull and unexciting. All my pleasure in it began oozing out me.

'Let me get in, Indu? Why are you guarding the gate so zealously? The new guardian of the family, huh? Stepping into Akka's shoes . . . or chappals.' Hastily I stepped aside, while he went on. 'Not that this gate ever kept anyone out. Or, anyone in either, if they wanted to get out. Who's that? Vithal, is it? Good. I wanted to see him before I leave. I have some books for him.'

'And where are you going?'

'Back to work. My holidays are over.'

And leaving me he went to Vithal.

Going ? Why did I feel at once like a deserted, abandoned child ? Why did it always have to be someone else for me ? I felt foolishly, ridiculously angry, like a pampered child suddenly left on its own, finding out that grownups have other and more engrossing interests after all.

Looking at the two of them, the man and the boy, each feature sharp and distinct in the clear moonlight, I had a strange feeling of having done all these things before. And then, the something that had been haunting me since I came here out of the house, came upon me with a rush. I had once, some time, somewhere, stood like this, watching these two persons. And I had felt then as I was feeling now . . . desolate and an outsider. Even the soft subdued sounds of the night sprang at me from some hidden crevice in my memory . . . as if they had been stored there for long, waiting for my coming here, for this moment, to return to me. And, in that earlier time too they had been what they were now . . . accompaniments to a hidden torture.

And there was another feeling in me too, a feeling of moving along a preordained road. As if what was happening, what I felt would soon happen, was something outside my volition. And there was nothing I could do but be passively carried along.

And then I heard laughter. It was Vithal laughing. I shook off my eerie fancies and came back to reality. Vithal laughing. And Vithal's father . . . that silent cruel man I had never seen. The man whose wife and son had both run away from him. And Vithal, unscarred it seemed, by the ravages of a childhood like that.

Unscarred ? Didn't most of us have scars we never revealed ? Except Naren, who wore his proudly like an old soldier wearing his medals. Unless that was another

elaborate camouflage too, like hiding a thing by keeping it in the open. Then I could bear it no more. 'Naren,' I called out, my voice, to my shame, high and shrill, like a petulant child's. 'Naren, come here.'

To my surprise he came. He saw me standing there, and as if there was something forlorn in my face that touched him, his voice, when he spoke, was unusually soft and gentle. 'What is it, Indu?'

Indu. My name. And yet, it could have been 'my darling', or 'my love' or any other endearment the way he said it. I had been 12 or 13, I think, when I had heard Madhav-kaka say to Sumitra-kaki, 'I'm sorry, darling, I'm late.' 'Darling'? I had been as shocked by the word as if I had seen them kissing in public. Endearments were only for babies and very young children. But adults?

Now, I had imagined that I had learnt to take everything in my stride. Endearments, kisses, caresses, even foul abuse ... nothing could shock me any more. And yet, at Naren's words, at the sight of Naren's face as he looked at me, the response of that prim, ignorant child came back to me. I controlled myself with an effort and said, 'Nothing. Nothing at all. I just wanted to know when you're leaving.'

'Maybe tomorrow. Maybe in a day or two. But I have to see grandfather first.'

'Will I see you again?'

His face, almost ascetic in its gauntness and severity, softened. He put his two hands on my two shoulders as if that was answer enough and turned away from me. Vithal, I saw, was engrossed in his books once more. I was glad of that. I didn't want anyone to see my face. I was afraid of **what it would reveal.**

Early morning . . . you wake up, aware of the shape, the feel, the taste of your own body. The whole of you becomes one aching emptiness. You want to touch and feel, to be touched and felt; finally, inhabited. You turn round to meet the warmth, the hardness, the intimate contact of another body. Then you realise there's only you. And you feel cold and alone and bereft.

Abruptly I got up, flinging the covers off my body. It was, I immediately sensed, far too early to wake up. There were no early-morning-sounds downstairs. Which meant that even Kaki and Atya, the earliest risers, were sleeping. But I could not lie in bed any more. What ancient guilts still lie in us, I wondered, that make us, even today, associate bodily desires with guilt and shame? Sometimes I could understand why ascetics resorted to scourging themselves. But can you make peace with your body by self-flagellation? I doubt it.

I got up wondering if I could read. But switching on the light in the hall would mean waking up everyone. Then I remembered how often I had, as a child, gone up to the terrace to read, to get away from the others, to muse over my dreams, brood over my wrongs. I climbed the stairs and my hands went up in the dark to pull down the chain looped over the hook. But the chain lay down, limp and slack. The door was unbolted. I pushed it and went out.

The rough cement floor hurt my bare feet. Occasional touches of velvety softness under them were, I knew, the scattered petals of the champak. The tree itself was just a shadow now, mysterious and elusive. But the frag-

rance, as if determined to proclaim itself, was strident and rampant.

I stood leaning against the low parapet, when a voice behind me said, sleepily slurring over the words, 'Who's that?'

I shied like a startled horse and whirled round, unable to speak, my voice caught in my throat. It was, for a moment, sheer panic. But only for a moment. Even as I began to say, 'God! How you scared me!', Naren spoke.

'Indu, is that you?'

'It is. And what are you doing here? I thought you scorned to accept the hospitality of this house?'

'What am I doing here? I should ask you that.'

He sat up suddenly in one of his lithe movements and pulled up his blanket around him, covering even his head. Now the hooded crouching figure was no longer Naren, but just one more of those early morning figures, crouching into itself for warmth.

'What are you doing here? Stamping away like a thousand horses. How do you expect a man to sleep with all that clatter going on?'

'Tch,' I clicked my tongue in mock exasperation. 'And I with my bare feet! Anyway, I asked you a question first. What are you doing here?'

'Sleeping. Or, rather trying to.'

'Yes, but why?'

'Grandfather's room is too hot.'

'That's not what I meant. I mean ... I mean ... how is it that you ...'

As I fumbled and stumbled, Naren gave a loud cavernous yawn, and patted his bed. Bed? It was, I now saw, just a straw mat. And his blanket was Old Uncle's old

shawl. And his pillow, the cushion from the chair in Old Uncle's room.

'Come and sit down here, Indu. Gives me a crick in the neck looking up at you. And stop probing. I'm here. Can't you be satisfied with that? Grandfather couldn't sleep last night and I sat up with him until late and' He shrugged and yawned again. 'And why are you here at this unearthly hour? Couldn't sleep, eh? You know, Indu, you look about 14 in that outfit.'

He had his cigarettes and matches by his pillow. He now pulled out one and lighting it, put it into his mouth and took a deep breath.

'Phew!' I said in disgust. 'First thing in the morning. Fouling the air. Why do you smoke so much, Naren? Don't you know what you're heading for?'

'SMOKING IS INJURIOUS TO THE HEALTH.' He said the words softly, but I could see the capitals. 'Cancer, eh? Do you believe in something called destiny, Indu? Sometimes I do, and I know mine isn't cancer.'

'Destiny! You're just a lazy, irresponsible fellow with umpteen bad habits.'

'Such as ...?' Giving me no time to reply, he went on, 'As to why I smoke, the truth is I do it so that some woman can have the pleasure of reforming me. All women are reformers at heart. Look at you now ... all out to reform Indian womanhood.'

As if Naren's words, satirical, only half serious, were a trigger that suddenly released the truth, I knew in that instant what it was that my life had lacked. It was the quality of courage. I looked back in derision at myself and saw that courage had come to me only in rare moments of blind anger. But that was not enough. What I needed was a steadfastness, and where would I get that?

'Why so thoughtful suddenly?' Naren's eyes crinkled in a smile.

'Nothing,' I said. Then again more fiercely, 'Nothing.' This was my secret, my struggle.

'Look me in the eyes and say that, Indu,' he said putting out both hands to turn my face towards his. His blanket fell off his head and without the cowl the face looked thin and angular. And his eyes

And, all at once I was, no, not just moving along that road, but *there*, where I had feared I would be. The place I had known I would reach. I had been half-afraid, half-joyous. But now there was nothing but a certainty. And Naren was in it too. For, as if he saw on my face what I saw on his, he got up, throwing the cigarette down on the floor where it lay smouldering for some time, and walked to the door that led to the staircase. I sat where I was, watching the cigarette end dulling, a grey ash forming over the red glow, and heard the grating sound of the chain slipping over the hook. And then he was back. And now as I looked at him, I found in myself a crystal clarity of vision. So that everything I saw was highlighted as if I was watching through the focussing lens of a camera. Each minute detail was picked out for me with precision and then magnified a hundred, a thousand times.

And, for an instant, as if the lens had misted over, obscuring my vision, it was not Naren but Jayant. Jayant whom I wanted, and in the same moment, hated for wanting so much. And as if Naren had seen through the same lens, he said, 'No, no, no.' And then it was Naren again. Saying, 'Indu.' And again, 'Indu'.

But this time the word was neither an endearment nor a caress; it was a challenge. And then, only then, he came closer and put his arms round me. Now I could

no more see nor think, but only feel. And there came to me an understanding of the relief that comes from defeat, from death.

I lay down impelled by his thrusting body, feeling at first a passive languor. Oh, blessed, blessed hardness. An ecstasy filled my body and I could not be still any more. There was a joyous sense of release, of passion I could experience and show and participate in. I clung to him convulsively, marvelling that I did not have to hold myself back. And when it was over, we lay back, both of us, exhausted and shuddering. I said 'Thank you, Naren.' And languidly he lifted a hand to my hair and smiled at me. Later, he lay floppily, untidily, as men always do, in a kind of supine bonelessness. While I felt in myself an intense desire for activity. I got up and began to tidy myself. Naren, who lay watching me through half closed, drowsy eyes, said, 'You look like a bird smoothing its ruffled feathers.'

'I wish I could say the same of you,' I retorted.

'The hostility of the female after the act of love,' he murmured.

And I laughed. But softly. 'I must go. I need a bath.'

At that he opened his eyes and smiled at me, 'Do you know, Indu, that your obsession with cleanliness marks you out so distinctly to be what you are? It's as distinctive as the shaven tuft of a male was a hundred years ago.'

'Is it?' I replied equably as I went out.

He did not stop me. Nothing had changed downstairs. There was no movement, no sound anywhere. Mini, who had been lying with her face pillowed on her left palm, still lay in the same position. I can go back and lie on my bed, I thought, and it will be like erasing the intervening period and what happened between Naren and

me. But deliberately I went to my bed and began folding the covers. I don't need to erase anything I have done, I told myself in a fit of bravado.

And then I went down and tried to do what Atya had done every day of her life since I could remember light the boiler. I had seen her do it so many times and it was, I knew, wonderfully, marvellously simple. Take a pat of dried cowdung, pour kerosene over it, put it on the perforated tray that goes into the base of the boiler, light it and pile some chips of wood on top. And . . . *Voila!* as Monsieur Poirot would say . . . the conflagration!

But, when Atya came down, roused I suppose by the unusual sounds in the bathroom, she stared at me and the mess I had made in consternation.

'Oh . . . ? Indu ! What is it ? What are you trying to do ?'

'Trying to light the boiler,' I said, struggling between tears and laughter. 'Can't you see ?'

She clicked her tongue reprovingly as she came into the dark bathroom. 'And why should you do these things ? You should have woken me up.'

'I thought,' I said humbly, feeling like a chastened child, 'it was easy.'

She laughed. 'Easy enough for me. I do it every day. But you people In your house'

'Click.' I mimicked the pressing of a switch. 'And in five minutes the water is hot.'

'Is it ?'

Her eyes were wondering but incurious. Five minutes later she had the boiler lit so that the flames jumped and danced, inhabiting the dingy room with weird shapes and shadows.

'You can have your bath now,' she said, touching my

smudged face with a smile. 'You've made yourself dirty.' I wondered whether the words held a double meaning for me. But I pushed the thought away with deliberate composure. No, there was nothing I couldn't wash away.

Later, feeling fresh and clean, I went into Old Uncle's room. Naren was there, reading the newspaper and I joined them. And there was no awkwardness between us. I could sit there with Naren as easily as I could leave him a little later and wander back into the main house.

I went upstairs to the terrace again in the lull that comes over a house just before lunch-time, when children leave their running about and play quiet games, and men doze. And I wondered whether it was the same instinct that makes a criminal, they say, go back to the scene of his crime, which made me go up again. But I had committed no crime. Why did we make such a monstrous thing out of this?

I stood there, leaning against the parapet as I had when Naren had called me. Downstairs, in the front yard, I could see Sharad and two of his friends, one of them on a motor bike. The sounds of their talk, their laughter, the phut phut of the motor bike which they had kept running ... all these came to me faintly as if I was, in fact, miles away. On the other side, I could see Kaki circumambulating the tulsi, hands folded, lips moving. And I was part of all this, yet distinct from it. It was one of those moments when I felt raised above all humans, with a joyous sense of power within me. There was nothing I couldn't do. Words, phrases, sentences, fell out of nowhere into my mind and arranged themselves with a beautiful precision, like ballet dancers. And I was filled with an exalted sense of con-

fidence within myself. But there was someone who came into all these thoughts, part of whom was Naren and part Jayant, whom I did not want to think of now. I let go the thoughts, dropping them into a slot, where I knew they would lie safe until I wanted them again.

That evening, Naren, Sharad and I played cards in Old Uncle's room, a game children play, with all the intensity and excitement of children. I felt lighthearted and liberated from something. Naren fell into my mood and Sharad was his usual self, so that the three of us were hilarious. But Old Uncle, who should have been pleased to see us so gay, and to have Naren with him, sat glum as if burdened by some great anxiety. It irritated me, fitting so ill into the pattern I was determined to create, that I avoided looking at him. But all at once he shot out at Naren, as if this was what he had been brooding over, 'And why are you still here? Didn't you tell me yesterday that you would be leaving today?'

'Between yesterday and today lies a whole lifetime.' Naren said pompously, theatrically. Sharad gave a silly yelp of laughter at that, but I didn't laugh. I stared at Naren, who looked back, bland and unconcerned. And then I laughed too.

But the mood did not last long. Slowly, imperceptibly the gaiety fell away from me, until, when I got into bed, I had shed all of it. And now, I thought, the enormity of what I have done will come home to me. Adultery... what nuances of wrongdoing... no, it needs the other, stronger word... what nuances of *sin* the word carries. I will now brood on my sin, be crushed under a weight of guilt and misery. But, instead, perversely, my mind began, coldly, analytically, to think of what I had done. I thought of all this with a kind of

remorseless logic, a detached objectivity, as if I was thinking of some other person.

Through the open arched window that looked down into the front enclosed courtyard downstairs, I could hear voices. Kaka, and yes, Atya. Later Kaki joined them. There were long pauses between the words as if they were sitting in a peaceful companionableness that needed no words. And this time, I, who was not part of it, did not feel an outsider. On the contrary, it was all very soothing and lulling, the murmurs giving me the same feeling of security a child gets out of hearing its parents' voices in the next room. And the aroma of the cigarette that Kaka was smoking ... he always smoked one at night before going to bed ... came to me like a friendly, comforting presence. Later I heard footsteps and then the cr ... ee ... ee ... ak ... as someone ... it had to be Atya ... closed the large front door. Metallic sounds followed which meant that the chains and bolts were secured. And then silence. Reassured, I slept.

I came out of a confused dream that I was at home and that I woke up to realise it was only a dream. And that I was not at home but in the hostel, aching with home-sickness. And once, I sobbed aloud in sheer misery. And then I really woke up. Yes, I *was* at home. This home, which I alone had the power to save. And there was something I had done ... something I had to do But what? I felt hopelessly frightened and confused. And out of all the confusion one thought stood clear ... I had to talk to Naren. Could I? Dare I?

I tiptoed out of the room and went up again, this time not fumbling with the bolt, just pushing the door open. I carefully bolted it behind me and looked around. I could see no one anywhere. 'Naren,' I called out in a fearful whisper. 'Naren?'

He was there. How had I missed him? He sat up immediately as if he had known I would be coming and had been waiting for me. I went to him and he put his arms round me wordlessly. And knowing him for what he was . . . irresponsible, unreliable, fickle, amoral, I clung to him as if he was a pillar. It was years since I had cried that way . . . a soundless, violent shuddering. At last it was over, and Naren gently eased an arm away. I could feel him groping for something. I drew myself away, wiping my eyes, blowing my nose. 'A cigarette?' I asked him, my voice sounding hoarse and rasping after all that crying.

'Yes.'

I heard the sound of the match, then the glow in the dark as he lit the cigarette. He patted his pillow and said, 'Lie down.'

He covered me with his blanket, Old Uncle's shawl, with the gentle carefulness of a doting mother, and lay down beside me, close, but not touching. His body was already familiar to me . . . its odours, its contours, its feel.

'I told you, didn't I, Indu, that I was the big, bad villain?'

I could feel the smile behind the words. He would not let me exaggerate my emotions.

'You told me,' I tried to match his mood, 'but I hadn't bargained for seduction.'

We were talking in whispers, conscious of the family sleeping in the house, though they would never hear us. 'Seduction? Who's seduced whom?'

'Naren!' I sat up bolt upright, throwing the shawl off me, staring down at his still body, dimly outlined in the starlight. 'I don't believe in love.'

'No,' he agreed placidly.

'There's no such thing ...'

'No,' he agreed again.

'.... not in real life, anyway. Only in books and movies.'

'And who writes them?' Naren sat up and held my hand in a hard, cruel grip.

'What?' I stared at him stupidly.

'These books which project this sham ... who writes them?'

'I don't know. Not I, anyway. I swore to myself I never would.'

'Never write of love?'

'No.'

He looked into my face for a moment, then with a small smile, released my hand and lay down again.

'Okay, so you don't believe in love.'

'It's a big fraud, a hoax, that's what it is. They tell you it's the greatest thing, the only thing in life. And you believe them and fall into the trap ...'

And become humble and dependent.

'Such a beautiful, comfortable trap, my dear,' Naren said and I could see he was laughing at me. But I didn't care about his mockery. Not any more.

'Beautiful? It's false. And how can anything false be beautiful?'

'And what's the truth?'

'The sexual instinct ... that's true. The maternal instinct ... that's true too. Self-interest, self-love ... they're the basic truths. You remember *Devdas*? I saw it with some friends. They sobbed when he died for love. But I could have puked. A grown man moaning and crying for love! God! How disgusting!'

Naren's arm pulled me down to him.

'What do you expect from Jayant, Indu? What is it you want from him that he can't give you?'

My voice felt suffocated with grief and rage.

'I expect nothing from him. Nothing. Not from him, nor from you, nor from anyone else.'

'You're lying. You do expect something from him. Something he's unable to give you. And because you can't get what you want, you're having tantrums like a spoilt child.'

Spoilt child? How will you understand, Naren, you who have never had to fight, to turn aggressive, to assert yourself? How easily it comes to you, just because you are a man. For me

As a child, they had told me I must be obedient and unquestioning. As a girl, they had told me I must be meek and submissive. Why? I had asked. Because you are a female. You must accept everything, even defeat with grace because you are a girl, they said. It is the only way, they said, for a female to live and survive. And I . . . I had watched them and found it to be true. There had to be, if not the substance, at least the shadow of submission. But still, I had laughed at them, and sworn I would never pretend to be what I was not.

Then I had met Jayant. And I had found out that he too expected me to submit. No, not expected. He took it for granted that I would. And I did it, because, I told myself, I loved him. As if that justified everything. As if the word took away the taint from the deed. And remembering how I had surrendered to him, step by step, I realise now, that it was not for love, as I had been telling myself, but because I did not want conflict. The hideous ghost of my own cowardice confronted me as I thought of this . . . that I had clung tenaciously to Jayant, to my marriage, not for love alone, but because

I was afraid of failure. I had to show them that my marriage, that I, was a success. Show whom? The world. The family, of course. And so I went on lying, even to myself, compromising, shedding bits of myself along the way. Which meant that I, who had despised Devdas for being a coward, was the same thing myself. I had killed myself as surely as he had done.

'What is it, Indu? What do you want from him?' Naren's whisper went on tormenting me.

'No. No. No.' I pummelled him on the chest with my fists and for the second time that night, burst into a storm of weeping.

But that too passed away. And I felt calmer, quieter, clearer. As if I had passed through the agony of suffering, of apprehending death, and now found the peace of it. Now I could talk. And I did. I spoke to Naren about the house. And the jewels. And Mini's marriage. And of what Jayant wanted me to do.

'To turn my back on them. But I can't do that, can I, Naren? I've suddenly realised that. Akka . . . I thought she was just an interfering old woman. But she was more than that. She was a prop. One of the strong. A family . . . it's like any other group. There are the strong and the weak. And the strong have to dominate the weak. It's inevitable. And Akka thought I was one of the strong ones. That's why she put the burden on me. And now, it is an obligation. I have to carry the burden. And to do that, I have to be hard. If I'm soft, I'll just cave in. Can I just put down the burden and walk away, Naren? Can I enrich only myself? I can't, Naren, I can't. This is my family. These are my people. And yet . . . I hate them. I despise them. They're mean and petty and trivial and despicable. I had always told myself . . . I won't be like them. I won't live like them. And

I thought . . . I've got away. But to what, Naren? To what have I got away? Is that any better than this? Is there no more to life than this? Are we doomed to living meaningless, futile lives? Is there no escape? I'm afraid, Naren . . . I'm afraid . . .'

Naren put a large firm hand on my mouth and said, 'Sssh, Indu, Be quiet, girl. Be quiet.'

Exhausted, I leaned against him, silent. Gently he put his hand on my hair. And this time he did what he had once said he would. He loosened it with the solemnity, the earnestness of a priest performing some rite. And then, when he had done, he passed his hand through it again and again, investing the action with more passion than he had shown me so far. Then he sighed. I did not ask him why he sighed, nor did I question him about his thoughts. What was happening between us was complete in itself. It needed no commentary, no explanations.

Afterwards we lay silent, apart from each other, not touching. My body was conscious of the hardness of the ground under me, the unevenness of the straw mat on which we lay. But I had no desire to move.

When he spoke next, it was like a teacher lecturing to a student.

'I have a theory about contact, Indu. I mean literal contact. People touching each other. We always need it. Babies crave to be touched by the mother, a parent. Then we move away from the family to generalised contact. Have you seen boys and girls going about, their arms round each other? Later the craving gets a focal point. You want to be touched by, to touch, one person of the other sex. It gets magnified and exaggerated beyond proportion. Only that person and as often and as long as possible.'

'Why are you telling me this?'

'You were speaking of love. I wonder whether it isn't another word for human contact. A simple explanation.'

'Perhaps,' I said, not caring to pursue that idea then.

'As a child,' he went on in the same level, impersonal tone, 'you hated to be touched. I remember it distinctly.'

'Perhaps it was because I never had a mother.'

'We have *that* in common.'

His tone was still more flat and dull and I had a moment of absolute despair. What had I done? What had I got into? And then I got up and softly unbolting the door, walked down the dark stairs quietly to my bed. I lay down on it and pulled my blanket to my chin. And fell asleep. It was as easy as that.

10

I went down to find Father sitting cross-legged on the floor in front of Atya, drinking his coffee. Father, as if determined to be contrary, drank only coffee while the rest of us drank tea. But Atya, by a miracle, as it seemed to me, had coffee ready for him whenever he wanted it. Now, she turned her head as I entered and said, 'Here's your Father, Indu, back from his travels.'

'Travels? What travels? And could I have some coffee too, Atya, instead of tea today?'

'Give me that cup, Indu. How's the coffee, Govind?'

'Wonderful!' Father took a loud appreciative sip. 'Truly wonderful.'

‘What travels, Father?’

‘Met a friend of mine. We were together in ... yes, primary school. And now we met after ... how many years, Narmada? God knows. Anyway it was a wonderful reunion,’ he grinned. ‘And he insisted I go and stay with him for a day or two. He works in the paper mill and lives in the colony they have over there.’

‘So you went?’ Father’s easy compliance never ceased to surprise me.

‘Ah, but you know where the paper mill is, Indu! In the middle of the jungle. So Govind had to go to get photographs.’ Atya laughed. Father’s way of earning a living was still a joke to the family. Something they couldn’t really believe in.

‘Got any?’

‘Some.’ He straightened himself out of the uncomfortable crouch he had to adopt when sitting down. He had lost the habit, really, of sitting on the ground. ‘I thought of you very often when I was there, Indu. I was just telling Narmada about it. Bamboo all over the place there.’ He waved his arms expansively. ‘And, you know, Indu, there’s something really wonderful about it. The way it grows again and again after it is cut.’

‘So? Why think of me because of that?’ I accepted the cup Atya gave me, wondering what was coming. Father was rarely irrelevant, even if he sometimes sounded like it.

‘It’s for you, my dear, all that miracle of abundance. To make paper so that you can write on it.’

He saw my face and asked, ‘What’s the matter?’

‘Nothing. I was thinking of the way we use paper. The kind of things we write on it. It suddenly seems a kind of desecration.’

That, if any, was the moment for Father to say

something to me. But he didn't. He let it pass without comment. But when we were by ourselves, he asked me, 'What's the matter, Indu? You look so . . . so . . .' he groped for the right word, his fingers making a grasping gesture, then shrugged his shoulders, shook his head, and let his hands fall down to his sides, as if giving up. But he hadn't, as his next words showed. 'And when are you going back to Jayant, Indu?'

Back to Jayant . . . not back home or back to Bombay. Father's flashes of shrewdness that belied his apparent naivete always took me unawares. But then Father was a man full of surprises. 'Do you know, Indu,' Naren had said to me, 'your father is the most wonderful thing to have come out of your family?'

Wonderful thing? Whenever I see the word adamant, I think of Father. Does it mean hard like a diamond? I don't know, but that is what Father is, despite his seeming softness, his apparent helplessness. How else could he have parted with me, a fifteen-days-old motherless baby, to the family he hated and despised? He had not even come to see me until I was more than a year. But that, perhaps, was because I was a girl. If I had been a son . . .

It was a tradition in our family that girls were left to their mothers; that a daughter was exclusively the mother's business. When his girls were in school, Madhav-kaka had never known what class they were in. But Sunil's education was so scrupulously and harshly supervised by him, that Sunil had turned deceitful, with the connivance, of course, of his mother. Only Vinayak-kaka, I had recently heard, had not only shown an awareness of his daughters, but even, so fond was he of the youngest, that he knew how to plait her hair and tie a bow in her sash. The women had earnest-

ly disapproved of this deviation from the normal Hindu male role. 'It just shows ...' they said.

'Shows what?'

That Kamala-kaki was somehow inadequate as a wife and mother.

'How is Father wonderful?' I had asked Naren truculently, thinking of all this.

'He's so complete a person. There's no piece missing in him. No piece in the wrong place.'

And strangely, Jayant had said the same thing to me once.

'I don't know, Father,' I told him now, wishing I could sound more sure, more certain of myself. 'I may leave in a few days. My leave expires in a week, anyway.'

He left it at that. Most wonderful thing to come out of the family? Maybe you're right, after all, Naren. To be so detached and objective with your own daughter ... it's a rare gift. Perhaps we should make it a rule that children should be brought up, not by their parents, but by strangers. Perhaps that's the only way of ensuring better relations between parents and their offspring.

And yet, that same afternoon, it was Father who, by his interference, brutally reopened the cicatrice on the face of the family.

We were having lunch, when Father looked round and said, 'But, where's Naren?' Didn't someone say he's staying here? Why hasn't he come for lunch?'

There was a silence. Then Kaka spoke, awkwardly, 'I don't think he's in.'

'Yes, grandfather, he's there. In Old Uncle's room.' Vishwas helpfully offered. 'I saw him there.'

'Go and ask him to come for lunch then,' Father spoke unusually sharply.

The child had obediently got up, when Old Uncle said, 'Sit down, Vishu. Sit down. You needn't go.'

The child looked uncertainly from Old Uncle to Father, who said, 'Why not?'

'He won't come. He's already had his lunch.'

'Where?'

Old Uncle shrugged, his face purposefully calm and blank. But I could see his hands quivering.

It was Sunanda-atiya, sitting in one of the rooms off the dining hall, who replied with alacrity, 'He goes and eats his food in a hotel, Govind-anna. Don't you know he never eats with us?'

'But why?'

Father was a mischievous child, persistently trying to stir up trouble. And yet all of us knew it was not that. All of us? God knows! I knew it, anyway. When had I last seen him like this?

'What is this, Anna?' Father turned to Kaka. 'Isn't that boy one of us? How can you all sit here ...' he pushed away his plate with an angry clatter '... when that boy ...!'

It was Kaki who answered him, banging down the large brass tray of rice she had brought in for serving. 'And what should we do? Fall at his feet and beg him to come here? You people come once in a way and think you can teach us ...'

'That's enough!' Kaka said.

'And everything we do is wrong ...'

'I said that's enough!'

'Yes, assert yourself, assert yourself, now at least. It's never too late for that,' Father spoke each word with

as much emphasis as if it was a nail he was driving home with a hammer.

'Govind-kaka, my mother's right,' Hemant interrupted him. 'You know nothing of what's going on here. You know nothing of how that fellow ...'

'Fellow? What fellow? Doesn't he have a name?' Father could scarcely speak for rage.

'Call him Naren, Hemant.' Sumitra-kaki the 'cultured' peacemaker. Joining in the battle with a pretence of soothing others. 'But, it's true, he's a difficult person.' She made an amused face as if she was remote from all this bickering. 'I should know. I tried to help him once, to get interested in him, but ...'

'Oh yes, when he had a good job, yes, then he was welcome. And it was "come and have lunch, with us, Naren", "come and have dinner with us." Nothing was too good for Naren then. Why, he was eligible even to become a son-in-law, wasn't he? But once he gave up his job and showed he wasn't interested in getting another like that ... then, he became a difficult person!'

I was aghast. Old Uncle speaking that way! And Sunanda-itya, unforgiveably, I thought, laughed.

Sumitra-kaki, gauging Old Uncle's mood, swiftly changed. 'I'm sorry, Old Uncle, if I've hurt your feelings. But you know my nature. I'm frank. I can't pretend. And I must say Naren has one wonderful quality ... he's never a burden on anyone else.'

Bull's eye! Sunanda-itya had to retaliate.

'And who's a burden on you? Have you ever done anything for anyone apart from your husband and children?'

'Our sacrifices are never realised because we don't talk about them. And I don't like to say it, but these two months we have ...'

'Listen, Sumitra-kaki,' Hemant rudely interrupted her. 'If there were no parasites in this house, your sacrifices wouldn't have been needed, let me tell you.'

'Parasites?' Sunanda-atya's voice was shrill. 'Isn't this my father's house?'

'Not any more.'

'Hemant! Sunanda! Will you all stop it! Am I dead that all of you go on like this? You too!' He glared at Kaki and then at the others like a cornered animal.

'Oh God! Inauspicious words now. That was all we needed.'

'Don't serve me.' Kaka got up, flinging his towel across his shoulder. 'I've had enough.'

Old Uncle, sitting by his side, put up his hand on Kaka's arm and said, 'Anant, Anant, don't lose your temper like that. And leave Naren out of all this, Govind. He's chosen his way and asks nothing of anyone. He comes to visit me, sometimes stays a day or two if he's in the mood, and goes away for months at a stretch. He isn't harming anyone. Leave him alone.'

'It's not what he's doing, Old Uncle. It's what we are. The way we behave.'

'It's all right. Govind. You don't need to have any unpleasantness among yourselves because of this.'

I had made a well in the centre of my rice and had poured the dal into it. I watched it unblinkingly as if it was the only thing in the world. And all the while, one word kept hammering in my brain. The word Arjuna had used when speaking to Krishna . . . *Sva-janam*. My people. Our people. Now, the word seemed to me to be blazoned across my plate and every face I looked at . . . with a large question mark in front of it. And, combating with the anger in me was a frantic desire to be resolute, composed and rid of anger. I had been

silent, afraid of what I would say if I spoke. But when Sumitra-kaki said, pleasantly, placatingly, 'Yes, why have quarrels among ourselves because of him?' I could contain myself no longer.

'Ourselves? And isn't Naren, Old Uncle's grandson, one of us?'

'Indu,' Hemant said, 'don't you start now. What right have you to interfere?'

'Why, she has every right,' Sunanda-atya smiled at me, making herself once again, as she thought, my ally, little knowing how much she was wronging me, angering me.

'Just because she has Akka's money ...' Hemant began, and then abruptly stopped.

And at that moment, looking at all their faces ... yes, Kaka's and Old Uncle's too ... I knew how much it rankled in them, what Akka had done. They would never forget, never forgive me. I could act the Lady Bountiful till it hurt, but it would change nothing.

'What have they done for you? Shake the dust of that place off your feet and come home.'

No, I would do nothing in anger. I was determined I would decide on nothing until the fit of rage that had come upon me had passed away. For whatever I did, it had to be done with a tranquil spirit and an unperturbed mind.

But there was Old Uncle When I went to his room I was shocked to see how haggard and pinched his face looked. He tried to give me his usual smile, his usual welcome, but failed dismally.

'Where's Naren?' I asked abruptly.

'I don't know. Maybe he's left already. I thought he would talk to me before leaving. At my age, I never know if I'll see him again.'

'But where's he going, Old Uncle? He just says, "I'm going."'

Old Uncle shrugged. 'I don't know. That's all he tells me too. He must have got a job. Or, maybe, he's getting one. He'll write to me some time giving me his address. That's his way . . . I don't know why Govind had to rake up that quarrel in the morning. And what for? As if Naren is bothered about any of them! Has he asked them for anything?'

And so he went on, querulous, complaining, fretful.

At last he got up, saying, 'Well, I think I had better go to his room to see if he's there.'

'Don't, Old Uncle,' I pushed him back, noticing how pitiful he looked. 'You don't look well. I'll go.'

'Will you?' He seemed so relieved I knew he had intended this from the beginning. 'Do it for me, Indu. Though for all we know, he may have gone away already.'

But he hadn't. In fact not only was he in, but Father was with him too. He seemed however to be packing up, for the room was strewn with almost all his belongings in a magnificent chaos. Naren made room for me on the bed by the simple method of flinging some clothes off it. Father sat in the solitary chair reading something with concentration.

'So you're off, it seems,' I said to Naren.

'Yes. Finally. Grandfather sent you, eh? Tell him I'll see him before I leave.'

Father put down his book with a bang of finality and said to me, 'What did you think of my morning's performance, Indu?'

'I hear you were fighting my battles for me too,' Naren added.

I shrugged. 'I don't know. Only thing I know is that I have a foul taste in my mouth.'

'I know I should take grandfather away from there ... but you know me.' Naren gave us a grotesque travesty of a smile.

'No, I don't,' I said angrily. 'Why can't you do it? What prevents you? To leave him among such people ...'

'And who are you to judge them, Indu?'

We were staring at each other like two antagonists, when Father exploded, 'The hell with all of them!'

'Yes,' Naren grinned easily again. 'The hell with all of them and let's have some music instead. We were about to begin when you came in. Like to stay, Indu? Your father can't believe there's any music in me. He's forgotten my mother.'

'Saroja? Yes, that's right, I had forgotten her. How long ago it all seems. How old are you, Naren? Past thirty, aren't you? She was scarcely twenty-two when she died.'

'How strange,' I said, 'to have a girl younger than yourself for a mother.'

'Maybe that's the reason why she never seems to be a mother nowadays. A kind of younger sister, maybe.'

'Yes that's right, Saroja had a beautiful voice' — Father was continuing with his own train of thoughts. 'Untrained, though, like a bird's.'

'A caged bird,' Naren said.

'Now, let's listen to you, you uncaged bird.'

And so we sat there and listened. And once again it was Naren's voice, Naren's music. But the words were the old ones that spoke again and again of the love of God. Of his greatness. And of total submission to him. And this time I did not listen to the words or puzzle

over their meaning, but let the enchantment of the music flow over me. And Father, too, was silent, speaking no word until it was all over. And only then he said, 'The music ... it's all yours?'

'It's mine,' Naren spoke simply, neither pride nor diffidence in his tone.

'But why only, these songs?'

'I don't know. It's not god. I ...' he smiled wryly, 'I'm neither young enough nor old enough to believe in that magnificent piece of self-deception. What intrigues me is something else. Did they, those composers, immerse themselves in god out of disgust for humanity? Or, was that love of god just an extension of their love for human beings?'

'And what's your answer?'

'I don't have one. A bit of both may be true, for all I know. After all, isn't it much easier to love an unknown unseen celestial being than the human beings we see around us? Seen that way, it seems a kind of escape from reality to me. The reality is us, isn't it, you and I and Indu and all the rest of humanity?'

'Yes, but why these songs? Why not others?'

'Govind-mama, you should have been a lawyer! You'd make a wonderful cross-examiner.' He stood up straight, hands folded across chest, and then dramatically shot out a finger at me. 'You mean to say,' he said in a loud voice, 'you can give music only to these words and none else?'

Neither Father nor I laughed. Naren subsided, giving a rueful grin. 'Fell flat! Oh well, that's how it is. Our funniest jokes But, let me tell you, Govind-mama, how it is. It's only sometimes that I can hear the music. Only with some words. And then, I have to

put them together. And then, the music fills me and there is no more I. Just the music ...'

To my eyes he looked beautiful then. But only then, only for that one moment. For Naren and I ... it was no infatuation. Naren was still Naren to me. I saw him for what he was. Twice, briefly, our flesh had touched. But that had, oddly, created no new bond between us. It had not been so for me with Jayant. Then, with his touch, I had felt as if I had lost not only part of myself, but the whole. Now, Naren's detachment made me feel untouched. There were no lingering feelings to make us uncomfortable. There was no difference in the way we behaved with each other, either. The same ease, the same acrimonious bickering, the same moments of sudden understanding and laughter.

What then, had I achieved by giving him my body? Apart from wronging Jayant? Wronging Jayant? I winced at the thought. But had I not wronged Jayant even before this? By pretending, by giving him spurious coin instead of the genuine kind? I had cheated him of my true self. That, I thought, is dishonourable, dishonest, much more than this, what I have done with Naren.

I came slowly, painfully, out of my reverie to find that Naren and Father had finished their argument and Father was getting ready to leave.

'Are you coming, Indu?' he asked me, moving out of the door. 'Come on, I'm sure it's past dinner time.'

Kaka, so careless about everything else, was punctilious about having meals at the right time.

'I'm coming,' I said.

Naren, who had been watching me curiously, came swiftly over to me, and, dropping down lightly beside me ... I was still on the bed ... said, staring into my

face, one hand lightly looping my wrist, 'What is it, Indu ?'

'Nothing. It was your music.'

'Would you like to stay for some time ?'

He was so close to me, I could feel his breath on my face, see every minute pore on his skin. His hand barely touched me, yet I could sense the urgency in him. Urgency ? No, that's the wrong word. But I knew what it was. And I smiled at Naren.

'No, Naren. I'm going home.'

He got up instantly and said, 'That's all right, then.'

As if he knew why I had said that and what it meant.

Father came back into the room saying, 'Indu, aren't you coming ?'

'A moment.' I got up now. 'So, what do I tell Old Uncle ?'

'Tell him I'll be there in the morning. After my bath.'

'Bath ?' Father grinned. 'You know, Indu, this man is going to surprise us one of these days. I wouldn't put it past him to turn devout all of a sudden and sit in front of the gods ringing a bell as fiercely as . . . his grandfather himself !'

'What's he doing ?'

'Don't you know ? All this devotional music. And now, he goes to bathe every day in the tank near the Shiva temple.'

'Who ? You, Naren ?'

'Yes, I, Naren.' He gave me a rather shame-faced grin.

'But why there ?'

Naren had recovered all his aplomb now. 'To wash away my sins . . . what else ? I have a ritual dip every day like a good Brahmin. Hold your nose, loop up your sacred thread, and wash away your sins. I must say our

ancestors were a complacent lot. They obviously thought their sins went only skin deep.'

'And you're trying the same trick, are you?' Father asked him, not smiling, but thoughtful.

'Well, maybe if I can't wash away my sins, I can drive out my private devils.'

He was suddenly morose as we left him there in the midst of all his belongings. But with one of his characteristically swift reversals of mood, he was grinning again as he popped his head out of the door to call after us, 'After my bath. Tell grandfather I've only a few sins more.' Father and I walked in silence for a while. It was he who broke it saying, 'Private devils? Poor devil of a Naren. You know, Indu, both his parents were drowned?'

I nodded.

'Perhaps it was because of that the boy was scared of water. As a child, it was an ordeal inducing him to have his bath. As for swimming ... whether in a pool, a lake, river or the sea ... it was unthinkable. And now he goes to bathe in that tank every day. When I asked him "why" he said ... "Well, there's no swimming pool in this place. Nor a river nor the sea either."'

'It seems he's decided to let the dead go where they belong ... to lay the ghosts of his dead parents.'

'Maybe.'

We spoke no more after that. I did not want to speak ... neither of Naren, nor the family, nor myself. I felt in some way ineffably free and released, like I had as a girl, when the exams were over. I felt myself brimming with something that I had to hold carefully within myself, something a careless movement, a careless word could endanger.

'No, Naren,' I had said. 'I'm going home.'

Private devils? Was it possible I had driven out one of mine, so that my body could never trap me any more? I went home and delivered Naren's message to Old Uncle. And then we had dinner. Kaki served us and it was as if the morning's scene had never been. Nothing had changed. Why, then, did I feel different, so that the very cobwebs on the dingy kitchen shelves seemed symbols, not of neglect, but of marvellously precise work?

'Some more rice, Indu?' Kaki asked with emphasis as if she had made the same inquiry before.

Father was finishing his rice and curds with loud slurps, while Mini was daintily licking her fingers clean of the pickles like a cat.

'No, Kaki, no more rice.'

'Just buttermilk then? Or curds?'

'No, Kaki. Nothing.'

'You aren't eating anything, Indu,' Atya said disapprovingly. 'What do you want?'

As I served the women in my turn ... they were always the last to eat ... I pondered over Atya's question. What do I want? Suddenly I remembered how I had put the question into the mouth of one of my characters. And, I had made her go on to say ... 'What a large, what a cosmic question that is. I will have to live the whole of my life to know what it is I want. And even that may not be enough.'

There was a despairing hopelessness about these words that now struck me as false. How can I live without knowing what I want? I must know. To live without fear ... fear of being unloved, misjudged, misunderstood, displeasing. Without the fear of failure Such a tall order! But if one began

'Oh God, Indu! Look what you've done!' It was

Sumitra-kaki's wail that woke me up. 'Can you imagine me eating all that?'

'Eat it up, Sumitra-kaki. Eat it up. And forget all your fears of growing fat. And even if you do get fat, I'll still love you. I swear it. Look!'

I put my hand to my throat, the way we had, as children, sworn the most dreadfully serious oaths.

They all stared at me suspiciously as I laughed out loudly, suddenly gay, light-hearted, irrepressibly happy.

Premonition? No, I can swear there was none then. Not that night, nor the next morning, either. Even Old Uncle's bad humour did not dispel my good humour.

'He hasn't come,' he grumbled to me, his lips making the meaningless grimaces of the toothless old. 'Did he say he would?'

'Of course, he did. I've told you so ten times already.'

And then I was ashamed of my impatience. I felt immeasurably distant from Naren that morning. Indeed from all the family. But how could I expect Old Uncle to be remote from Naren?

'Stop worrying, Old Uncle,' I said reassuringly, more gently. 'I'm sure he won't go away without seeing you.'

I left him with his newspaper, his mind, with the easy forgetfulness of his age, now full of the unsavoury antics of politicians, head nodding disapprovingly, face twitching in disgust.

It was a little later that Vithal came home from school for lunch.

Atya, whisking the cream to get butter said, 'Why so late today, Vithal?'

'Somebody's drowned and they were trying to get the body out. I was watching for a while.'

'Where?' Atya asked.

'In the tank near the Shiva temple.'

What made me so certain? I don't know. I only know that in that instant, even as I heard the women murmur and exclaim over the news, I knew who it was. And all the blood in my body drained away. Drained back to the heart which worked like some monstrous pump.

11

It was Naren. I had run to the place in the heat of the afternoon sun like a crazed person with a dreadful certainty in me that left no room for any doubt. And yet, when I reached the place and found him lying on the grass, exuding death from eyes which looked sightlessly at the burning sun, I could not control myself. There were no tears; but, while people stared, moved softly around and spoke in hushed voices, I found myself overcome by a violent fit of shivering. It was a sense of the utter loneliness of the human spirit that overwhelmed me as I saw Naren lying there, detached, remote and far removed from us and all our emotions. This awesome feeling was not dispelled even when I saw that the family had arrived (how had they come and who had summoned them?) and stood around Naren, claiming him now, at last, for their own.

And then the shivering passed and it was as if I was enclosed in a hard covering of ice that would let through nothing but the cold. What pierced

through the numbness was the wailing and weeping that began when we took Naren home. And the sight of Old Uncle, who watched with glazed eyes, almost as sightless as Naren's own, his grandson being brought home.

And yet I was surprised by Old Uncle's strength. It was he who comforted Kaka when he wept like a child over Naren. All those tears . . . I did not know how I would bear them. But I was upheld through it all by my anger, a clean, cold anger that left no room for any confusion.

As for Old Uncle, at times, I thought . . . he is too old. He has not really taken it in. At other times, when I saw his lips move in the semblance of a smile, I thought . . . he is senile. He cannot understand even sorrow. That first night I went into Old Uncle's room at night to see if he was sleeping. Kaka had been with him earlier and had told me that he had fallen asleep. When I opened the door, I saw him lying on the bed, absolutely still. I would have thought him asleep if I hadn't noticed the glint which told me his eyes were open. Wide open and staring at nothing. I came into the room and said softly, 'Old Uncle?'

'Indu. . . .'

His voice was hoarse and when I went closer I saw that he had been weeping. His face had crumpled into a blotchy mass of wrinkles.

'Indu, come here.'

'What is it, Old Uncle? Can't you sleep?'

'Sleep? It's not that. If only it was. It's something else. Tell me the truth, Indu. You're the only one who knows. You're the only one who can give it to me. Don't try to protect me. I can take it.'

His pleas came in a raucous whisper that filled the

room with a quality of desperation. He grabbed my hands and held them tightly in both of his.

'What is it, Old Uncle? What do you want me to tell you?'

'Promise me first. Promise me you'll tell me the truth.' Promise me. Promise me. Naren ... he had said the same words to me the day before he died.

'What I'd like to do,' I had casually remarked, 'is to give all the money to Vithal and watch all their faces.' I had been totally unprepared for Naren's reaction. He had pounced on me like a ... yes, a tiger; and holding my arm in a tight grip had said savagely, 'No, not that. Not to Vithal. Promise me you won't give it to Vithal. Promise me. Promise.'

'Why?' I had asked, chagrin and mortification combating with the pain of my throbbing and hurting arm.

'Promise me first. Promise.'

And when I had promised, he had relaxed into his usual self, saying with a kind of indifference, 'Well, don't forget it then.'

And I, rubbing my arm ruefully, had asked, 'But why, Naren, why?'

'Because,' and his look had been intent and direct again, 'your money, your family, can taint anyone.'

And I had thought ... Poor Naren. When will you grow up and shed this childish resentment?

And now I will never be able to bear those words again. Never in all my life. I will never say them again except this once to Old Uncle.

'I promise, Old Uncle. I'll tell you the truth.'

'Tell me, did Naren ... Did he ... do it deliberately?'

A surge of pity came upon me as I realised the load

the old man had carried within him all this while. I was amazed at the fortitude that had kept him silent until now.

'Oh no, Old Uncle, how could you think of such a thing?'

'How could I ... how could I ...' he repeated with the fretful impatience of a child. 'Forget about that and tell me, Indu. Did he? Did he?'

'No.' I could say the word with conviction. 'I thought you knew. His foot ... it was wedged between two rocks. They had to ...' I swallowed and stopped. Then I forced myself to go on again. 'You know, Old Uncle, better than I do, what a reputation that old tank has! How many have died there. And Naren ... I was with him ... Father and I ... just the evening before. He was cheerful and happy. I can swear he had no such thought in his mind. Why, we spoke of so many things ...'

'Tell me everything he said. Tell me all of it.'

Everything? All of it? Can I tell you, Old Uncle, how we made use of each other? Can I tell you we made love? Not for love, nor lust either, but for motives of our own. He ...? To get back at the family? At me? And I? To get back at Jayant?

No, that's too easy an explanation. Too glib. It cannot explain the feelings between us. The ease, the friendliness. It cannot explain how the darkness inside me was banished, replaced instead, by a gentle, kindly dawn. No, let me just remember those days for what they were, something complete in themselves, unrelated to other days, other places, other times.

I gave Old Uncle a carefully edited version of our conversation. I told him how Naren had recalled his mother. And what he had said about her. And Old

Uncle said wonderingly, 'Strange! When he was a child, he used to ask me lots of questions about them. Later ... he never spoke of them at all. I have a photograph of Saroja and her husband. I offered it to him once. And he said ... I'm not interested in relics.' A small smile touched Old Uncle's face when I told him what Naren had said about him. 'I should take him away from there.' He smiled once again when I told him about Naren's last words to me ... 'Only a few sins more.'

And then, there was no more to say. We were both silent until Old Uncle began to weep again.

I stayed with him the whole night. He talked to me the whole night through. Disjointed, rambling, confused though his words were, they held within them a hard core of grief which I knew could never be pierced. The stories he had told us as children came back to me and he reminded me of Bhishma, lying heroically on his bed of arrows. But where was the Arjuna who could assuage his thirst with an arrow shot into the earth?

I did not attempt to comfort him. I knew there was no comfort I could offer him. I sat and listened instead, occasionally wiping his face when he forgot his tears and let them pour down. And yet, he always spoke of Naren in the present tense, never in the past. Once he spoke to me of his wife, who had been dead these fifty years, confusing her somehow with his daughter, Naren's mother. It was as if in that tired old mind Naren was not a grandson, but a son. 'I wish, Indu, you could have known her,' he said. 'She was only 13, and an ignorant village girl when I married her. And I, a bookish solemn young man, thinking it my duty to educate her. She taught me so much more herself. She knew how to reach across to any person, so easily get-

ing over the barriers of age, class, caste or sex. Mothers-in-law ... you know what they were supposed to be. But I think my mother would have attacked me if I had said a harsh word to my wife. Naren ... he's like her. He goes straight out to meet a person. Most people resent that. They put up curtains to hide their poverty. They're afraid to come out, to commit themselves. But Naren ...'

When he spoke again, I thought his words were strange, coming as they did, at such a time, from a person we had always called, 'Poor Old Uncle'.

'I have been singularly fortunate all my life, Indu.'

Singularly fortunate? When he had lost his wife in his youth, his only child in middle age, and his one grandson, his sole link with life, in his old age?

'I have lost much, but the fact remains that I had it to lose.'

He was calmer now and speaking in his usual manner. But again and again he went back to Naren, as if he could not bear to relinquish that beloved name. As if the name was a living link between him and the person.

'Naren ... he acts as if he hates people. But he doesn't Indu, he doesn't. On the contrary, he expects a lot from them. And invariably, he's disappointed and disappointment makes him bitter and angry. It's the same each time. He believes people are capable of far more good than they know themselves. Once I tried to caution him against believing, against expectation. You know what he said to me? "Am I to go through life expecting nothing, merely to ward off disappointment? I'd prefer to expect and feel and suffer. Anything rather than that negation."' Later, he lost con-

trol once more and burst out, this time not so much in grief as in anger.

'God, god, god! That's a way of evading responsibility. Naren is right. There isn't anything beyond us, beside us. There's just us. And how we fail one another! How we fail, Indu!'

'Don't, Old Uncle, don't!' I cried out, unable to bear the sight of his self-scourging. And suddenly, in the midst of his grief, he smiled. 'How like Naren to deprive me of the small comfort of god when I need it most!'

His voice carried the familiar ring of exasperation it had always done when he spoke of Naren. 'It's all my fault, Indu,' he said after another silence. 'He wanted me to get out of here. He told me so long back. If only I had taken him away from here. This place was no good for him. It gave him the burden of not belonging. But I... it was my cowardice. Here I was safe, enclosed. I was Old Uncle. Outside? Maybe, I was afraid of finding out that I was nothing. And so, out of sheer cowardice, I failed him. Why did I do it? Why?'

And the tears flowed again.

I was aghast by his complete breakdown. Some time later I fell into a light doze. And woke up to hear him crying, 'Who was I to judge him, Indu? Who was I? Why did I presume to judge him and his way of life? I failed him. Even I. Failed him like I failed Saroja.'

In the morning, after his bath, he was again his old self, frail, imperturbable. If he looked more like a shadow of himself than ever, there were few to notice it. For a new furore rose in the house. Old Uncle, rising to heights I'd never dreamed him capable of, had decided not to have any ceremonies for Naren. Most orthodox, most tradition-bound man that he was, he took this

decision, knowing it was what Naren would have wanted.

'He's at peace now,' he told Kaka, who tried to make him change his mind. 'We don't need to worry about him. It was a clean end there when we gave him to the fire. A good life. Yes, Anant, good. Honest and true. And a clean end. What more does a man need? A lot of mumbo jumbo said over him isn't going to make any difference.'

No one could shake him from his purpose. In the end, he clothed himself with the authoritarian dignity of age, the one thing that could be understood and respected in a family like ours.

I stayed aloof. I knew he did not need my help and I did not offer it. But one day I told him of Naren's music. He showed no hurt that Naren had kept it from him. Instead he asked me to play the tapes for him. As we listened, it was I who cried. The first time I shed tears for Naren. And the last. Old Uncle sat absorbed in some thought. When it was over, he said, 'All my favourite songs. The ones he knew I loved.'

Seeing my tears, 'Don't worry about me, Indu, I won't last long now.' He went on with a smile, 'I will go before the house does. Thank god for that.'

Yes, that too had been decided. I had told Kaka that I would not buy the house. That I would, on the other hand, pay for Mini's wedding.

'You can fix up a date now.'

Shankarappa came the next day, full of relief that the matter had been decided at last.

'It's a good thing you've done. It's a wise decision,' he kept on repeating, as if to reassure Kaka. But Kaka was wooden and unresponsive even to Shankarappa's genuine concern and sympathy. He maintained a stolid

silence which he broke only once to say, 'Can't you keep the house as it is?' The words came out of him in a staccato manner, showing the stress he was under. 'Can't you repair it and rent it out?' Shankarappa seemed amazed by the idea. 'Rent it out? Who would pay rent for this?'

Kaka winced and even I felt affronted. But Shankarappa, as if to make amends, agreed to wait until Mini's wedding before demolishing the house. Though, he did not fail to point out, he would be incurring a loss in doing so. He passed his hands over the door saying, 'Beautiful woodwork. Worth a lot of money even now. But the rest of the house' With a disparaging gesture he flicked away three generations of dreams as worthless.

'And the tree?' I asked him.

'What tree?' he stared at me, uncomprehending.

'Our champak tree.'

'Oh, that one! It's right in the middle of the house, isn't it? In the back courtyard? Well, well, it will have to go, of course.'

At that, such a sense of desolation and bereavement came over me, that I could have wept then and there.

The tree whose trunk I had been unable to embrace even as a child. The sense of mystery and wonder that it had aroused in me, growing as it did out of the damp darkness within the house, emerging triumphantly above the roof into the sunlight. The ever green leaves, the golden flower, whose pervasive fragrance had, it now seemed to me, permeated all my life. 'It will go,' Shankarappa's cheerful voice went on. 'No problem about that. There will be no trace of it. Not even a stump to show it was there.'

Not even a stump ? *'If you will it, o Lord, this dead stump will sprout again.'*

But if there is not even a stump ? What then, Naren, what then ? What can even faith do with non-existence ?

Non-existence ? No, there is no such thing. To accept it will be to deny the miracle of life itself. If not this stump, there is another. If not this tree, there will be others. Other trees will grow, other flowers will bloom, other fragrances will pervade other airs.

It was like being let into a great secret. I felt as if I was watching life itself . . . endless, limitless, formless and full of grace.

After Shankarappa left, Kaka stood where he was for a moment, stock still, his cap crushed in his great fist. Then he sighed and said as if to himself. 'That's that.' He turned to me, hiding his feelings with a great effort.

'So, that's over.'

'Yes, that's over,' I agreed, carefully keeping the pity from showing in my face.

'And now the vultures can come to pick at the flesh. Vultures ? No, they're not even that. Just crows.'

I did not reply. It was not my fight any more. I was out of it. Let them squabble over their shares, their dues. I owed them nothing. I had already decided what I was going to do with Akka's money. Strange, that after all my dithering and agonising the solution now seemed so simple and straight. Yes, simple, in spite of the fact that I knew the opposition I would have to encounter. That somehow didn't seem to matter at all. It was as if Naren had made me a legacy too, giving me his simplicity of will. Hadn't he said about Akka once ? 'Oh yes, I can admire the old ghoul at times. After all, she believes in something and nothing can keep her from act-

ing according to those beliefs. That's something, isn't it?

Yes, that's something. I know it now. Yet, I was not as remote as I had imagined myself to be.

'What next?' I asked Shankarappa when he came home again. 'What's going to happen here?'

'Don't you know? I thought you did. We're build-a hotel. Oh, not just me alone. There are three of us. I'm one of the partners. You see, Indu-akka, this is going to be the highway now, instead of the old road running through the town. That means there's going to be a lot of traffic here. Hundreds of cars. And just imagine . . . there isn't a good hotel within 200 miles--either way. Ours will be a first class one.'

A hotel? I swallowed convulsively, closed my eyes. Then opened them again. Why not a hotel?

'A hotel! That's good.'

'Just you come and see it when it's finished, Indu-akka. You come and stay here whenever you come to this place. Treat it like your own home. I promise you there'll be no difference.'

Own home? How could a man be so insensitive to another's feelings? Yet, as Shankarappa went on, I found I was wronging him. In a more subdued manner, he said, 'Your Kaka is furious with me. But what can I do? It's not my fault. He doesn't realise things have to change. If not to me, he'll have to sell it to someone else. And don't you think Indu-akka, it's better to raze it to the ground than to see strangers living in it?' As I looked up sharply at him, by some strange chance he repeated the words Old Uncle had said about Naren.

'It had a good life, this house. And now, a clean end. Even a man can't ask for more than that!'

Abruptly, his mood shifted, pendulum-like, to the other end.

'You must come and visit my house once, Indu-akka.' He grinned at me, showing perfect white teeth. A supari and tobacco merchant, he never touched either himself. Perhaps a man can have only one vice at a time. And his was making money.

'You people say . . . oh yes, I've heard about all these things, even if I don't read . . . you people say we suppress our women. But I tell you . . . and take it from me, Indu-akka, it's the truth . . . it's the other way round. How often have I told my wife to change her ideas, to come out of the house, to meet people! *Un hunh!* She won't listen. I can't do anything with her. Obstinate as donkeys, these women. You come home and teach her, Indu-akka. I know how clever you are. If anyone can teach her, you can.'

I, clever? That was my first moment of humility. How was I to teach anyone? I, who had so much to learn myself. Everything, in fact.

As he left, he said, 'And come back home again. Soon.' Home? Not any more. There had been a morbid fascination in childhood in saying the words . . . 'the last time'. Now, it was like facing death, knowing there's no after life. But why weep for a house, when so much more is being destroyed every day?

As a matter of fact, I felt neither mournful, nor desolate, but, in a peculiar way, both light and free. Yes, the house had been a trap too, binding me to a past I had to move away from. Now, I felt clean, as if I had cut away all the unnecessary, uneven edges of me. And free. But not detached. I would, I knew, never hanker after detachment any more. The very word brought

back Naren's eyes as he lay on the grass near the tank. Detachment . . . it was for the dead, not the living.

But what of my love for Jayant, that had been a restricting bond, tormenting me, which I had so futilely struggled against? Restricting bond? Was it not I who had made it so? Torment? Had I not created my own torment? Perhaps it was true. But all these were theories and I wanted no more of them. There was only one thing I wanted now . . . and that was to go home.

Yes, home. The one I lived in with Jayant. That was my only home. To think otherwise would be to take the coward's way again. I would put all this behind me and go back to Jayant. What kind of a life can you build on a foundation of dishonesty, I had asked myself once. What kind of a home have I built? Now I would go back and see if that home could stand the scorching touch of honesty.

Nevertheless I knew I would not tell Jayant about Naren and me. For that was not important. That had nothing to do with the two of us and our life together. But there were other things I had to tell him. That I was resigning my job. That I would at last do the kind of writing I had always dreamt of doing. That I would not, could not enrich myself with Akka's money. That I would, on the other hand, pay for Mini's wedding.

Maybe Jayant would understand. Maybe he wouldn't. But even so

Chakra

Jayawant Dalvi

translated from the Marathi by
Gauri Deshpande

The only home young Benwa and his mother Amma know is a decrepit pavement hut; the only life they know is one of poverty and violence, patched with a few pleasurable moments of food, drink or love-making. Amma dreams of escape from the crowded pavement, of a shack of her own, and a child by her truckdriver lover Anna. Benwa dreams of being like their popular friend Looka, who can handle any situation with the flick of a knife or the flash of a smile.

The outcome of their dreams is worked out against the vividly evoked background of the Bombay street-slums. This bold novel (translated unabridged in this series) won its author three prestigious book prizes and has now been made into an award-winning film.

Wait For the Moon

Niranjana

Translated from the Kannada

by Tejaswini Niranjana

I was born at the bottom of the ladder. Then I moved to the middle rungs. Then the ones above them. Then hanging in the sky.

Why do I want to write ? I'm a murderer, a threat to society. The papers have screamed out my guilt. But I've got to write, before I leave the world. Please don't call me a coward or a weakling. And please don't bury me near poor folk. They might disturb my peace with their suffering. Don't bury me near the rich either. They suffocate me.

A compelling novel which blazed a new trend of writing.

The Death Certificate

P. Sachidanandan

translated from the Malayalam by
Gita Krishnankutty

In a nightmarish, bureaucratized world where documentary evidence is the only evidence, a man searches for a death certificate to convince himself of the reality of death — a quest that forces him to reassess the meaning of existence.

A compelling novel depicting the alienation and *angst* of modern man in a chaotic and meaningless world.

In Indu's ancestral home, that she escaped from so many years ago, nothing seems to have altered. Yet all is different. Akka, the rich family tyrant, is dead. Her large family, though they do not know it, are all on the threshold of great change. And the key to their future now lies in Indu's hands.

For the usually determined Indu it is a time of questioning. Of thinking again about her life, her journalistic career, her marriage for love, about her illusion of hard-won independence. Has she broken the stranglehold of family and tradition, only to be dominated as completely by love for her husband? Is she her own self, even when she is working? Or is it her tragedy never to be free, never to be complete?

After illuminating interactions with the varied personalities in her family, Indu, in the course of this absorbing novel, works out their futures, and also her own personal equation.



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